

FASCISM AND THE GLOBAL FAR RIGHT



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A Historical View

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and Javier Rodrigo**

REAKTION BOOKS

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Published by
REAKTION BOOKS LTD

2–4 Sebastian Street
London EC1V 0HE, UK

www.reaktionbooks.co.uk

First published 2026
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Printed and bound in Great Britain by Bell & Bain, Glasgow

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

eISBN 978 1 83639 213 2

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FOREWORD

by Sergio del Molino

I cannot think of an emptier political term than ‘fascist’. It can appear in any context and be aimed at anyone. Very few public figures have escaped the accusation in the shouting on social media and the hysteria that dominates any current political discussion. Even those who are fundamentally occupied with identifying fascists from the trenches of the radical (or not so radical) left end up being labelled as such at some point during the fray. The proudest, purest anti-fascist propagandist might stumble in the column, express some heresy, and be thrown into the fascist wagon by those who applauded that person’s anti-fascism the day before. For example, in my country – Spain – journalism and politics are rife with characters who have been called fascists for the most bizarre reasons, though none of them even remotely correspond to the fascist profile.

The rise of rhetorical anti-fascism, and the deep crisis of representation that plagues democracies around the world, have given wings to the radical right as heir to historical fascisms. The ultranationalist, xenophobic Sweden Democrats party (the reader will discover that the enemies of liberal democracy love to include ‘democracy’ in their acronyms) has just become the second largest political force in the country, putting an end to social democratic hegemony in one of its supposedly impregnable bastions. This is the latest triumph among movements that are already firmly embedded in parliaments throughout Western Europe. They have become powerful in Strasbourg and have governed without opposition in Eastern European nations such as Poland or Hungary. While none of them would consider themselves fascist, they are the closest thing to historical fascism that exists in the twenty-first century.

If those who are insulted as fascists from the watchtowers of the agitprop left are *not* fascists, and those who could be fascists (based on their ideology, electorate and rhetoric) refuse to consider themselves as such, is fascism then a mirage? *Where* and *who* are the fascists? Is the radical right a contemporary phenomenon without connection to interwar fascisms, or a resurrection of them? Or is there, as some analytical currents suggest, a fascist substrate that manifests itself in supposedly democratic movements or institutions and exposes them for what they are? Is there essentially an underground fascism emanating from the deep state and economic structures, as argued by those in Spain who see the democracy established in 1978 as a continuation of Francoism by other means? In that case, it would be a truly unusual, self-conscious and clandestine fascism that has renounced one of its main historical features: stagecraft. It is hard for me to imagine a fascism without parades but who knows?

These issues fit within a broader debate on the crisis of democracy and the emergence of populism, raising the noise and confusion to intolerable levels. With so many voices competing to analyse this moment, even the most informed readers find it difficult to make their way through the conceptual undergrowth. Here the contribution of two contemporary historians, Maximiliano Fuentes Codera and Javier Rodrigo, is very valuable: not because their profession endows them with authority – which it does – but because they expand the visual panorama, clearing out clichés and inertias of thought.

In broad strokes Fuentes Codera and Rodrigo clarify what is meant historiographically by fascism, based on the three most representative European cases (Italy, Germany and Spain), and narrate its mutations, survival and resurrections in post-war Europe. From this knowledge base, they elucidate whether the twenty-first-century radical right can be considered fascist, then end with an analysis of the current crisis. The last of these undertakings trespasses the borders of their discipline; one necessarily oriented to the past and averse to judgements about the present or projections concerning the future. However, it is consistent with their position as citizens: the condition from which they challenge their readers. In doing so they honour Jürgen Habermas's idea that there is no political issue that cannot be subjected to free debate. In other words the experts deliver their informed opinions in the agora with the same concern (and often the same bewilderment) as the neophytes. The authors of this book

enter the town square armed as historians, and from there they accompany the rest of us, astonished and sometimes anguished, as we observe the cracks forming in democracies.

Fascism and the Global Far Right is not a complacent read. Fuentes Codera and Rodrigo have tested, and demolished, some commonplace ideas I had taken for granted. As a writer and polemicist, I have always felt close to some of the more vehement figures whose ideas about fascism and its survival have taken deep root among intellectuals. This pair of historians shows no mercy for authorities such as Umberto Eco or Hannah Arendt, whose philippics have become commonplace, handed down to us on stone tablets. I admit that I felt rather an idiot at seeing their prophecies and analyses of fascism exposed and dismantled. It saddened me to realize how they, and many other intellectuals, have helped banalize this phenomenon. Instead of enlightening, as good thinkers are supposed to do, they cast shadows everywhere, pointing to fascists where there were none or exaggerating causes and origins.

Readers will find just the opposite here, if they dare to dismantle what they thought they knew about fascism and look at the new radical right without prejudice, seeking to understand it. A word of caution: you will come away from this book with more questions than answers and with your intellectual reference points demolished, as mine were. But you will emerge with a much clearer, more precise gaze and sturdier conceptual tools that allow the debate to continue with the depth required to understand our current situation, free from banality.

It begins by learning to distrust history as example or oracle. Distinguishing contemporary radical-right nationalist movements from twentieth-century interwar fascisms does not trivialize the threat they pose to democracy. However, living in a state of permanent anti-fascist alert can also prevent us from appreciating the characteristics of a growing, worldwide political movement. We become blinded to its more subtle effects, such as contagion among conservative and liberal forces, or lose sight of why the popular classes find it so seductive. Often the most difficult thing is to actually see what is in front of us, rather than seeing what we want to see. This book provides another torch, shining forth from history to illuminate a formless, unsettling region that we have not yet mapped because it is in full expansion.

It is rare to end a prologue by giving credence to what was written across unexplored regions on medieval maps: *hic sunt dracones* – ‘Here be dragons’.

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INTRODUCTION: A HISTORICAL LOOK AT THE PRESENT

In November 2016 Donald Trump triggered a major political earthquake by unexpectedly defeating Democratic candidate Hillary Clinton in the U.S. presidential elections with his populist, nationalist and xenophobic platform. A decade on from this event it has become commonplace to talk of the ‘rise of fascism’ and the ‘far right’ across the Western world, although such fears have stalked European politics for much longer. Earlier that year the Brexit vote had caused another convulsion in the heart of Europe.

In the French elections of April 2017 Marine Le Pen won 34 per cent of the vote in the second round. The same year, the Freedom Party of Austria entered government in coalition with the Austrian People’s Party. In spring 2018, Matteo Salvini’s Lega Nord party in Italy also formed a coalition government with the Five Star Movement (Movimento 5 Stelle). On the night of 2 December 2018, the Vox party emerged in Spain as a new political force; it was the first time since 1982 that a far-right force party had found its way into the Spanish parliament – led by Santiago Abascal, it had won twelve seats.

In the European elections of May 2019 far-right parties obtained their best ever results in terms of votes and seats in parliament, multiplying the outcomes of the 2009 and 2014 elections. They were the most voted for parties in France, Italy, Poland, Great Britain and Hungary. By the end of that year the far right had seats in every national parliament in Europe except Ireland and Malta. Jair Bolsonaro also became president of Brazil that year, and Narendra Modi significantly improved his results as leader of the Hindu ultranationalist Indian People’s Party (Bharatiya Janata Party, BJP), which had an absolute majority in the then second-most populous country in the world.

Thus three of the world’s five largest countries had a far-right leader: Bolsonaro in Brazil, Trump in the United States and Modi in India. In the

European Union two governments – Hungary and Poland – were controlled by the radical populist right; four others – Bulgaria, Estonia, Italy and Slovakia – had ministers from radical right parties, and two more (Denmark and the United Kingdom) remained in power through the parliamentary support of a party with the same tendency. All this coincided with the end of ‘Iberian exceptionalism’: the Chega! party entered the Assembly of the Republic of Portugal in October 2019.

Much of the media and society saw this as a radically new and unexpected phenomenon, but the influence of the far right had been clearly increasing for at least two decades. The incorporation of the Freedom Party of Austria, led by Jörg Haider, into government in 2000 (after becoming the second largest political force with 26.9 per cent of the vote in the 1999 elections) is the clearest expression of a process that would develop in ways far from predictable at the time. Their participation in government set off a strong local reaction that led to a resounding international boycott. However, when the same party returned to government in 2018, a lot had changed. Protest in Austria was minor, and the international community accepted the new coalition without significant issue.

A similar process of increasing resonance took place in France. Jean-Marie Le Pen reached the second round of the 2002 election with 16.9 per cent of the national vote. Yet with the substantially higher voter turnout in the second round, he stagnated at 17.8 per cent. Twenty years later, his daughter Marine Le Pen made it to the second round with 23.15 per cent of the vote. This time, however, instead of watching their ballots languish due to the usual cordon sanitaire, they received 41.46 per cent of the vote in the second round.

Austria and France are not exceptions. Something has changed in the last twenty years.

The fundamental novelty is the growing normalization of radical- and far-right parties around the world. The surprising ease with which political parties and a significant portion of the media have incorporated far-right ideas and slogans has been noticeable for some years now. At the end of the last century the idea of a quarantine, or cordon sanitaire, as a mechanism to expel these forces from governments and institutions seemed indisputable, but it has since disappeared from all but a few countries. As shown by Emmanuel Macron’s and Friedrich Merz’s governments in France and Germany, it is more the exception than the rule.

Of course, it is not our place to judge the motives that lead citizens to seek alternatives to the current system of representation and neo-liberal economic framework, which is not concerned with who suffers the social consequences of the model and treats them as collateral damage, or unfortunate sidenotes. But we do observe that within this framework the anti-fascist consensus that shaped the main Western democracies after 1945 has been called into question. In Spain today, Vox has demonstrated that it is possible to form part of a coalition government without condemning the Franco dictatorship.

From the Second World War to the end of the twentieth century, the far right had only been in power in Latin America, Spain, Portugal and post-communist Croatia. In the twenty-first century, a growing number of radical-right leaders and parties have come to power in more or less consolidated democracies such as Hungary, Poland, the United States and Brazil. These governments took their countries down an illiberal path. Despite their great regional, organizational and ideological differences, they all attacked the independence of judges and the media, undermined the separation of powers and questioned the rights of minorities. The speed of their emergence and the depth of these tendencies depends on the legal and electoral framework of each country, but the common drift was clear.

In Poland, the Law and Justice party (*Prawo i Sprawiedliwość*, *pis*) clashed repeatedly with civil society and institutions in its attempts to limit the freedoms of the media and the courts. Despite its ongoing efforts to follow the model of Viktor Orbán in Hungary, it lacks the constitutional majority to do so.

The Hungarian government has been able to develop these policies, transforming the liberal democracy that existed when it came to power in 2010 into an authoritarian regime. Though elections continue to take place, the independence of the judiciary and the media is a thing of the past. Orbán's illiberal democracy is basically an ethnocracy: a nominally but formally democratic regime in which the dominance of an ethnic group is structurally determined. This is not a new phenomenon but substantially different in that it is carried out from a place of power and nourished by ideas such as those put forward in 1991 by the French National Front, whose 'Fifty-Point Programme' established the foundations of a 'welfare nativism' that segregated the welfare state, distinguishing between 'natives'

and ‘foreigners’. Similarly, religious rights could be respected or violated depending on whether they were considered ‘national’ or ‘foreign’.

It is increasingly common to see radical-right populist parties in coalition governments; in countries such as India and Brazil they were the dominant force in the coalition. The same occurred and occurs in the United States, if the Trump administration is still to be understood as a kind of coalition government between the radical right and the conservative wing of the Republican Party. In other countries, the radical-right party is the junior partner in a government led by a conventional democratic party, as is the case with the Austrian People’s Party or the Bulgarian Socialist Party. In those contexts, governments may manifest illiberal and nativist impulses but most of the radical proposals end up partially diluted.

The process has not ended – in fact it is in full bloom, and the scenario is far from consolidated. The debates are intense and consensus is still a long way off, making analysis difficult. Despite Donald Trump’s electoral defeat to Joe Biden at the end of 2020, this populist tycoon continued to challenge, even threaten, American democracy. The assault on the U.S. Capitol building on 6 January 2021 made this clear. Five days later Robert Paxton, one of the most renowned specialists on interwar fascist regimes, publicly acknowledged the need to revise his position. Having doubted Trump’s fascist nature during his years in office, Paxton claimed in a *Newsweek* article that everything had changed. Some leading U.S. political figures, such as Mark Milley, have come to the same conclusion recently, and several scholars are showing a similar perspective. The events in Washington had demonstrated the similarities between the 1930s and the present. Meanwhile academics such as Jason Stanley and Federico Finchelstein in 2020 and 2017, respectively, became more insistent in their warnings that a transition from populism to fascism could take place under Trump’s leadership in the United States, a country far removed from the fascist tradition.

Though it will surely not be ‘classical’ fascism that germinates among the American far right, Trump’s support for the white supremacism of the Proud Boys is not exactly reassuring; however, Abraham Lincoln’s country is far from being an exception. In Europe, Chega! came third in the Portuguese parliamentary elections of January 2022. In April that year Viktor Orbán won his fourth consecutive election in Hungary, despite his close ties with Vladimir Putin amid strong condemnation of Russia’s brutal

invasion of Ukraine. He stated that his victory was ‘so great’ that it could be seen ‘from Brussels’. Far from calling into question Orbán’s decade-long illiberal regime of xenophobic and homophobic policies, the results accorded him 54 per cent of the vote.

In the French elections that same month, Marine Le Pen of National Rally improved on her 2017 results and again reached the second round, with more than 8 million votes. Despite Emmanuel Macron’s victory, the combined votes for Le Pen and for Éric Zemmour in the first round gave the far right more than 30 per cent of the vote, a number well above what the current French president obtained. The French elections in the summer of 2024 saw the left-wing New Popular Front coalition win, but only after both they and President Macron’s Ensemble withdrew candidacies in fragmented districts in the second round to halt the rise of Le Pen’s candidates, which still managed to be the political formation with the most votes with 37 per cent.

Within the context of the leaderships of Giorgia Meloni in Italy and Javier Milei in Argentina, and the growing presence of parties such as Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) in Germany and Vox in Spain, Trump’s victory in the November 2024 elections represented the beginning of a new phase in this process, a phase marked by radicalization and a scenario of deeper international tensions than in his first term as president of the United States.

Looking at the panorama, fascism seems to have returned, at least in its purely rhetorical version, causing more and more analysts to ask if today’s radical-right parties and leaders are fascists or not. But the question is not always accompanied by the more pertinent one: what is fascism? For many analysts, fascism and its rhetorical uses have always been with us. The thesis of eternal fascism, formulated by Umberto Eco at a 1995 conference in the United States, seemed to demonstrate this and was broadly used to explain the political scene in Europe and other parts of the world. A new Italian edition of that conference was published in 2017, followed by a new Spanish edition a year later. The publication was preceded by an excerpt from it: ‘Ur-fascism can return in the most innocent of guises. Our duty is to unmask it, using our index finger to point out each of its new forms, every day, everywhere in the world.’

Though the premises were imprecise and not supported by studies from the main authorities on fascism, they achieved noteworthy global

distribution. According to Eco, the presence of one or more of the hallmark features of fascism – ‘cult to tradition’, exploitation of the fear of difference, the frustration of the middle class, popular elitism, chauvinism and ‘selective populism’, among others – was sufficient to create a ‘fascist nebula’. A very similar thesis runs through a set of texts published between 1962 and 1975 by the writer and filmmaker Pier Paolo Pasolini. They were recently collected in a book titled *Il fascismo degli antifascisti* (2021).

These ideas have been very relevant to academics and analysts in their attempts to think about the possible relationships between the radical right and fascism in the last decade. The U.S. philosopher Jason Stanley argued a few years ago that ‘fascist policies’ were being developed in Russia, Hungary, Poland, India, Turkey and the United States, with the aim of gaining and staying in power. The combination of authoritarian leaders with appeals to a mythical past, anti-intellectualism, hierarchy, the spirit of the nation, victimization and the dismantling of the welfare state shows continuities between the interwar years and the present day. These approaches were based on the thesis of eternal fascism. Within months, guides for ‘unmasking’ fascism and works on combatting it began to multiply.

As historians of fascism, populism and the far right, this whole situation intrigued us in two ways: on the one hand the use of the term ‘fascism’ as an insult and the left’s crudest identification of any gesture, reaction, decision or attitude contrary to its own political or symbolic agenda as ‘fascist’; on the other is the more subtle but growing awareness, in the international radical right, of a kind of return of fascism. This book represents an almost immediate response to this phenomenon.

Fascism, at least as a concept and object of discussion, has returned to the present. A simple search for the word ‘fascist’ on Google brings up millions of results. The term ‘Nazi’, popularly used as a synonym for ‘intolerant’, brings up about 1.88 billion. The problem is that this semantic inflation has devalued the concept. Emilio Gentile, one of the greatest analysts of Italian and international fascism, proposed in *Chi è fascista* (2019) that the thesis of eternal fascism is merely the consequence of the banalization of fascism as part of the defascistization process that began after the Second World War. One cannot speak of fascism apart from the historical, official, ruling fascism that really existed. To do so would be to defascistize fascism itself. This allows the past to be adapted to current

political projects and keeps the concept of fascism alive by leaving the signifier in its place and changing the meaning.

Despite the links between fascism and populism that Federico Finchelstein intelligently demonstrated, the current political right – from Trump to Orbán to AfD to Le Pen – does not see itself reflected in fascist parties and ideologies. However, their governments and parties may indeed be permeable to some elements that appeared with or in fascism, or to a degree of historical memory akin to it. As we will demonstrate, the radical and far right both have ultranationalism, historicism and chauvinistic patriotism in common with the fascists. The same can be said of xenophobia and other forms of heterophobia, though some parties have replaced ethnic racism with cultural racism. In other words, they reject multiculturalism but accept those who assume ‘national values’. Nonetheless, they do seek to provide new answers for a world that is very different to that of the interwar years. For this reason, it does not work to describe the broad, diverse arc of the radical right as fascist. To do so is ahistorical and, as Enzo Traverso has argued, hinders the understanding of new threats to democracy that have little to do with the militia parties born after the First World War. ‘To define a thing is to replace it with its definition,’ wrote the Cubist painter and sculptor Georges Braque, a quote cited by Peter Schwenger in *The Tears of Things* (2006). Therein lies the problem that Gentile and Traverso denounce: the danger of ahistoricity.

Undeniably, we must face reality with new tools, which includes looking historically into the past to think about our present – this is a democratic necessity. However, defining our present should not lead us to dissolve unfolding historical processes into categories. Far from seeking definitive conclusions, it seems we must try for tentative explanations by looking to more recent history. As Robert Paxton argued, it is about paying greater attention to processes than to essences.

In this book we will trace the basic constituent elements of fascism, as we see them, to look at the present historically. As historians, we always approach the past from our own present, interrogating earlier times in terms of our own realities. We recognize the volatility and contingency of the words we use to analyse the past, alongside the need to rely on shared verifiable definitions and debated ideas: concepts. We know this can be a heavier aspect of our work, after decades of experience in debates about what Francoism is, how to define fascism, how to deal with populism or

what the extreme right or radical right is (and is not). But we must also acknowledge that definitions and concepts count for a great deal in these matters. In fact, this book begins with a history of the concepts and a review of their practical applications, to understand why they are used and why a central contemporary historical process such as fascism is largely trivialized.

Fascism as a concept has almost as many definitions as interpreters. This multifaceted phenomenon admits readings from the most diverse fields of study: from philosophy to political science, from the history of art to the history of literature. Here we will take a historical and contingent look at fascism, which we understand as one of the great political, social and cultural utopias of the first half of the twentieth century in Europe. It embodied the most successful form of counter-revolution in Europe between the two World Wars and was projected in the most atrocious way possible on the Continent. It took the form of total war, plunder, violence and elimination for its victims, but was overwhelmingly hopeful for those who adopted it as a vital horizon for their personal, communitarian and national desires.

We have been working on this subject of intense debate for decades, but it contains elements that are shared by much of the historiography. Among them is a clear consensus regarding fascism in power as a kind of anti-liberal, anti-democratic and anti-socialist regime born in a context of long-term crisis and totally contingent to its time. The objective of fascist regimes was to protect the national community by developing policies of recruiting, violence, cleansing and social, racial, demographic or economic readjustment and relocation. War occupied a fundamental place and was considered the natural state of fascism, according to its founders, who shaped a culture along with individual and collective identities. Fascists claimed that they never hid their identity – it was a source of pride, as it is today – yet mostly defined a style. But like all historical processes, which are never suspended in time or space, above all they defined the nature of a form of power in relation to a given context. The European fascist experience was the violent, totalizing and ultranationalist recourse of an armed counter-revolution by the European radical right. It resulted from the successive crises of the interwar period, and its success or failure depended heavily on the contexts in which it unfolded.

Do we live in an era propitious to the return of fascism, if indeed it can ‘return’, ‘persist’ or ‘reincarnate’? Or are we immersed in a populist phase dominated by the radical right that even permeates legal spheres – supposedly the most impermeable to its precepts – as political scientist Guadalupe Sánchez Baena argues in *Populismo punitivo* (2020)? Are we in an era of diversity-cancelling populism, as Princeton political science professor Jan-Werner Müller, in *Contesting Democracy* (2013), suggests? How useful is a category that can hold everything from early Podemos to Trump and all the European radical right variants? The scholar Enzo Traverso surely hits the mark when he argues that the concept can be much more useful as an adjective than a noun. Even so, populism as a rhetorical procedure for exalting the supposedly immanent ‘virtues’ of the people against the elites is a slippery concept.

The term ‘populism’ is not the ark of the covenant: impregnable, unlocatable, humanly incomprehensible. As a challenge to the principle of liberal representation shared by nearly all contemporary political cultures (except fascism, of course), populism would be an undercurrent in world politics. With especially deep roots in Latin America, it is a narrative frame of refusal (with an antisystemic touch) of liberal democratic institutional architectures. It is a way of constructing (using rhetoric with a vocation for political action strategies) a true democracy that is truly representative and truly coincides with the supra-individual will. In this context, the will of the citizen is replaced by a principle of collective legitimacy that generates a new subject of law, ‘the people’, and is embodied in specific political forms and institutional artefacts. Finchelstein proposes that its contemporary origin may lie in the ways in which fascist alternatives disappeared from the political arena. However, it is worth noting that its forms and strategies were already present and identifiable – more as an undercurrent than an ideology – in movements prior to the birth of fascism. More than a result of fascism, populism would in fact be a result of the advent of mass societies themselves and of how state architectures and forms of political representation were constructed in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

In any case, since the start of the twenty-first century, it seems clear we are witnessing an extremely contemporary form of populist momentum. From the left and the right, appeal to the people has spread throughout Europe and beyond. While the candidacy of Jean-Luc Mélenchon for La France Insoumise in the April 2022 presidential elections demonstrated that

populism is still alive and well in the political left, the concept has become central to the analysis of the radical right. The populist momentum that Alain de Benoist, French philosopher and intellectual father of the Nouvelle Droite (a far-right movement in France during the late 1960s), spoke of in 2002 reveals the depth of the crisis of liberal democracy and its system of representation. Roger Eatwell and Matthew Goodwin described how just a few years before Donald Trump became president of the United States, American citizens' levels of trust in the country's main institutions indicated a delicate state of democratic health: only 35 per cent trusted the Supreme Court and the presidency, and less than half that amount, 12 per cent, trusted Congress, as historian Steven Forti has argued.

A 2019 study of 34 countries by the Pew Research Center showed that 51 per cent of those surveyed were not satisfied with how democracy was functioning. Spain was no exception. The 2021 Eurobarometer indicated that 90 per cent of citizens did not find their political parties trustworthy and 76 per cent of them thought the same of Congress. This 'society of mistrust' – a concept developed by Ilvo Diamanti and Marc Lazar in *Popolocrazia* (2018) – is present in much of the Western world. *Popolocrazia*, the adaptation of actors to populist language and approaches, along with the collapse of many of the parties that had articulated political systems during the second half of the last century, are key phenomena of our time. The reasons are many, but at the root of them all is the disparity between the promises of prosperity and autonomy through neo-liberal globalization and the growing inequalities among cultures, ways of life and social sectors.

The defeat of fascism marked a turning point in the evolution of contemporary politics and capitalism. While fear of the expansion of Soviet communism instigated far-reaching social reforms, it must be borne in mind – as historian Tony Judt recalls in *Postwar: A History of Europe since 1945* (2005) – that Western European statesmen also opened their countries' economies to government intervention to shore up the quality of life of a middle class that had been susceptible to fascist slogans during the interwar years. Only full employment, robust social services and high growth could have integrated the working and middle class into a solid democracy of the masses. As Jan-Werner Müller observed in 2013, the new post-war democracy – which did not really establish itself until well into the 1950s, thanks largely to the success of the welfare state – was considerably more

limited than the democracy that emerged after the First World War. By the 1970s, Western European countries had consolidated systems with mixed economies, strong trade unions, catch-all parties and high voter turnout. Southern European countries such as Greece, Portugal and Spain converged towards that model as they emerged from right-wing dictatorships.

The scene began to change in the late 1970s. The subsequent rise of a new Anglo-Saxon right led by Ronald Reagan and Margaret Thatcher, the impact of the events of 1989 on the political left, and the fading of Fordist ways on the Continent, explain much of the crisis of the European social model. These elements also heavily influenced the process of European integration. The historian Quinn Slobodian in *Globalists: The End of the Empire and the Birth of Neoliberalism* (2020) explains how European neo-liberals in the 1960s saw the European Economic Community as a pilot project for creating a political order that would legally protect a free-market society. It was not about ‘freeing’ markets from public interference, as Milton Friedman and the Anglo-Saxon neo-liberals envisioned, but ‘imprisoning’ them in a thick web of laws accompanied by heavy use of (supra)national courts that would allow the free action of private economic subjects.

Thomas Piketty and the World Inequality Lab have demonstrated in their global inequality reports how the gap between the highest and lowest income populations has only widened since 1980. The 2022 report indicated that 52 per cent of global income was in the hands of 10 per cent of the world’s population, while the poorest half of the world’s population received just 8 per cent of global income. Here it is important to note the significant differences between countries. Inequalities are very high in the Middle East, Brazil, the United States and South Africa, and more moderate in most European countries and developing countries such as Malaysia or Uruguay. Globally, the poorest 50 per cent own just 2 per cent of total private property (real estate, professional and financial assets, net debt), while the richest 10 per cent hold 76 per cent of global wealth. Here again there are important regional differences in levels of inequality. Latin America and the Middle East are the most unequal regions, followed by Russia and sub-Saharan Africa, where the poorest 50 per cent own just 1 per cent of the wealth, while the richest 10 per cent hold about 80 per cent of total wealth. The situation is somewhat less extreme in Europe, where the poorest 50 per cent own 4 per cent of total wealth, compared to 58 per cent

for the richest 10 per cent. The COVID-19 crisis has only increased the concentration of wealth among the richest. These figures, as Piketty pointed out, have departed from the consensus reached after 1945. It seems the social elevator has broken down: more than nine out of ten Americans born in 1940 earned more than their parents in their thirties, while only one in ten born in 1980 can say the same. Since the early 1980s, neo-liberal policies and German ordoliberalism (a branch of neo-liberalism that prescribes a strong state to structure and optimize competition within a social market economy) have contributed significantly to the erosion of liberal democracy.

The outbreak of the global pandemic in March 2020 failed to strengthen Western democracies. Despite government responses, radical-right discourses remained strong and even gained power in Spain and Europe. In the early months of the pandemic, radical-right groups pushed various theories about a supposed 'health dictatorship'. In the heterogeneous space of the international radical right, positions on COVID-19 ranged from denial to shades of ambiguity. Concepts such as Corona-Diktatur, Covid Viral Authoritarianism or Dictature Sanitaire emerged to point out excess in state (and EU) powers over individual rights. Spain was no exception; Vox tried to lead the sectors that were critical of vaccination and the restrictions imposed by the Sánchez government.

In early 2022, a report was published in the journal *Nature Human Behaviour* based on a survey of more than 100,000 people from twenty countries, including Spain. The results showed that people who were sympathetic to extreme ideologies were more likely to believe other theories: for example, that former German Chancellor Angela Merkel and Barack Obama belong to a reptilian extraterrestrial elite. The study, led by the University of Marburg, showed a close relationship between belief in conspiracy theories (such as the one established by Holocaust denier David Icke) and proximity to extremist political projects, particularly those of the radical right. While this relationship was much clearer in France, Austria, Germany, Poland, Belgium and the Netherlands, the conspiracy theory mindset was found to be growing in Spain also, especially among young people. The Manichaeon vision of the world, based on a sharp distinction between good and bad, friends and enemies, was rooted in various sectors of European society. In such an environment, democracy as we know it is in danger.

The dilemma of ‘fascism’ or ‘democracy’ expresses at least three issues: the radical interpretative and narrative banalization of historical fascism and its time, the deterioration of democracy and traditional parties, and the normalization of the radical right. The growing symbiosis between the conventional right and the radical right is also evident in Europe. In this frame, a series of fundamental questions will give shape to this entire book.

To begin, should the necessary questioning of these anti-liberal or illiberal projects lead to the inexorable revival of the anti-fascist discourses of the 1930s and ’40s? Is this the best alternative to them? Are we in a period similar to those years? In other words: is the new radical right fascist? Moving on, do strategic approaches based on premises such as ‘stopping fascism’ – now common in social or post-social democratic thought and post-electoral strategy proposals – make sense? In the twentieth century, fascism was the yardstick for defining anti-fascism. In the twenty-first century, those who call themselves anti-fascists and identify with their symbols (in speeches or on social networks) with varying degrees of sincerity decide what fascism is, regardless of whether the person accused of being a fascist displays any corresponding traits. This is a problem that leads to lightweight definitions of what fascism is, or directly to the absence of a definition, while making it possible to project fascism rhetorically in any direction.

In this guise, the adjective ‘fascist’ has saturated the media and public debates, implying that including the radical right in the political equation deteriorates everyone’s rights and constitutes a return to Europe’s darkest hour. Fascism as a ‘meme’ is already embedded in the public debate and even seeps into the opinions of intellectuals not exactly given to acritical thought or the wholesale purchasing of interpretative frameworks. Fascism seems to be here to stay, making it even more urgent to ask, as we do here, what historians mean when we talk about fascism.

Beyond its rhetorical use, this book delves into the ‘whys’ of the phenomenon. Successive crises – the economic crisis that began in 2008, the refugees in 2015, managing the pandemic in 2020 – have created a political context that has given rise to new identitarian alternatives, such as the national populists in Catalonia. Disruptive, movement-based political forces have grown. In short, this context reveals ever-greater movement towards not fascism – the result of a very specific scenario – but new forms of anti-liberal, if not anti-democratic, politics that substitute the individual

rights of citizens with a different collective subject: the people, the community, 'those below', or similar rhetorical forms. The crisis of democracy has allowed populism to settle in. Its rhetorical expression has crystallized in the banalized use of some of the most important historical categories of the twentieth century, including fascism.

In this book, we analyse first the forms of historical fascism, then those of the post-fascist and populist far right up to the present day. We draw lines of continuity, observe discontinuities, and above all identify the elements essential to the emergence of extreme political alternatives and utopias. Foremost among these elements is the political agency of the societies in which they developed.

No matter how much social network users (or bots) roar, or how little promise the political alternatives to the current territorial, economic, identity and health crises seem to carry, we are nowhere near the economic, political, social, cultural and post-war context that birthed fascism. But we can only arrive at that conclusion, and therefore a better understanding of our present, through deeper understanding of what fascism was and what it meant to millions of people in the twentieth century. For many of them it was synonymous with exclusion, plunder, deportation or murder. It is therefore crucial, from the present, to understand the historical forms of European fascism in relation to their political uses. Only then will we be able to understand, analyse and face the current challenges of democracy. That is the aim of this book.

1

FASCISM IN ITS ERA: EUROPE

To speak of fascisms in the plural, as earlier historians did – including the Italian academic Enzo Collotti, who took the baton from one of the first great interpreters, the socialist Angelo Tasca (1892–1960), Italian intellectual, politician and anti-fascist historian, exiled in France – makes it possible to project the term on to situations and historical processes of great diversity. To aid understanding, it seems useful to try to briefly clarify the reason for the interpretative variability, the lack of consensus among historians and social scientists, and the conceptual volatility of something in the past that nonetheless seems quite distinct, intuitively. It is no surprise that historians disagree on definitions of fascism, given the brevity of its existence as a historical force (existing roughly from 1922 to 1945) compared to the epochs of liberal democracy or even real socialism. This is linked to the imprecision of the movement itself and the incoherence of the various fascist movements, groups and regimes. It also reflects the significance of fascism as a radical political alternative in Europe and beyond, as anyone will understand who recalls images of the active German extermination camps in Poland from 1942 to 1945. If fascism included Auschwitz, then after the Second World War nobody (well, almost nobody) would want to be identified with it.

Similarly, conceptual and terminological issues confront us with the complexity of looking at the past through the changing lenses of the present. They remind us how complicated the study of the past is and should be. Projects, ideologies, cultures, debates, strategies, processes and praxis are often confused in conversations about fascism in the twentieth century. Faced with a reality that is always complex and often difficult to grasp, historians and social scientists look to texts, literature, primary

sources (speeches, letters, memoirs and other materials) and the works of great theorists and thinkers to find stable footholds for examining the past. From there they construct their own reflections and conclusions, eventually placing one historical situation or another among the fascisms based on its theoretical purity and coherence with the political project. It works on paper but not in reality. In fact, fascisms never lived up to their founding myths and projects. They were openly mestizo – incoherent, impure, complex, mixed – in political, cultural and identitary terms.

Finally, categorizing fascisms has been complicated by the historical diversity of their stages and the rather generalized idea that the stages must be successfully completed to attain a full fascism, one free from qualifiers that would nuance its length or complexity. The great Italian historian Renzo de Felice in 1975 distinguished them as ‘fascism-movement’ or ‘fascism-regime’, and many others have followed in his wake. The first involves a battery of intellectual and ideological constructions and the preparation of strategies to seize power. The second, once a fascist party has taken power, entails construction of corresponding forms of territorial, administrative and human control: single party, single labour union, militia, recruiting and social order.

Where should we point the searchlight to identify a fascism? That would depend heavily on who is holding it. Scholars such as Emilio Gentile and Adrian Lyttelton consider mass mobilization essential to fascism, while Roger Griffin defines it in *Modernism and Fascism: The Sense of Beginning under Mussolini and Hitler* (2007) more as an organization based (at least in theory) on national myths about ‘rebirth’ (palingenesis). Politics carries these national myths to fulfilment by deploying the party–state–leader triad to bring about a ‘fascist revolution’. Myth and political organization construct a hierarchical unity and community that transforms the character of the nation. Although the fascist project ends up exceeding the normative and institutional limits of political, practical and even aesthetic acceptability, it is something more than just destruction of the liberal state. It is more than the subordination of the party to the leader as sole repository of political will, because polycracy (the rule of many) and individual agency generally abound in fascisms. It is even more than the theoretical limits of totalitarianism, which negate neither its myth nor its nature, because all totalitarianisms are imperfect compared to their founding myths.

What then? Is it reaction or revolution? Anti-modern or modernizing? Exportable or irreproducible? Again, it depends on where you focus. According to the social and cultural historian George Mosse, fascism requires a mix of mass democracy, leader worship, public obedience and rejection of liberal capitalism and Marxist materialism, along with a good dose of terror: not as a static concept but as an active element of varying intensity. Fascism was heir to nineteenth-century antiparliamentary traditions but radically new in its forms. Prominent among them was relational, supra-individual, objectified terror: a political weapon in peacetime, an eliminationist weapon in total war; in short, a tool for materializing the aspirations and political traditions of thousands of Europeans. In addition to its forms, Collotti argues that it is also necessary to look at its objectives. Fascism is a common response to a generalized crisis; it proposes a substitute order created through mobilization, force, inclusion–exclusion dynamics, coercion and identitary unity, with hierarchy as the core concept and violence as the differential strategic element for the extreme reorganization of models of political action and thought.

Hierarchy, violence, identity, imperialism, corporativism, suppression of representativity, political intolerance. Not all these fascism-defining features show up in every place where fascist projects were deployed. While we are fully aware that fascist groups have existed nearly everywhere and many fascist expressions exceed the regimes that were constituted as such, the methodological and interpretative approach in this book is to study the fascisms that actually existed: those that were in power. Though synonymous with ideological impurity, regulatory variability, strategic diversity and imperfection – the historical subjects themselves knew this about fascism, accepted it and even promoted it. Benito Mussolini himself, intent on constructing a fascist regime in Spain during the Spanish Civil War of 1936–9, argued for the unification of parties and the creation of a single party under a military man with no political ties to early fascism: General Francisco Franco (1892–1975).

A research methodology for such a task requires us to rethink inherited definitions and explore alternatives. For example, perhaps there is no such thing as a single fascist model. The primordial Italian case, though fundamental in the history of fascism, is little use in understanding its global deployment in the 1930s. Italy would fit the ‘early comer’ model as a forerunner of the fascist era, which spanned from 1933 until the end of the

Second World War, with the Spanish Civil War in between as its milestone and point of no return. Perhaps understanding fascism requires looking beyond its attributes to include an analysis of its contexts: its moments, strategies, options, geographies and interrelations. With all this variability at the base, if there is a common element within the history of fascisms – which are inherently fascisms in power – it is that they result from fascistization processes. In other words, along with their ideologies, we must attend to praxis: their adaptations, contingencies, failures and successes. Or to put it another way, their outcomes.

When it comes to defining the term, rather than ‘movement fascism’ versus ‘regime fascism’, or ‘classical fascism and its epigones’ (as has been suggested on occasion), perhaps it would be more appropriate to distinguish between a rhetorical–symbolic fascism on the one hand, and a practical–real fascism on the other: one that can only be explained from the exercise of power. While the former has fascinated historians and political scientists, we prefer to focus here on fascism that existed rather than rhetorical or literary forms of it. In our view fascism is understood by its vocation for, and use of, political power. It results from complex historical processes and variables that need not be identical to the Italian phenomenon (construction of the fascist dictatorship from within the liberal democratic system, taking advantage of its fault lines) or that of Germany (formation of the National Socialist alternative using the representative mechanisms of the Weimar Republic, in response to the political and socio-economic crisis generated primarily by the economic crash of 1929). This is a good moment to revise the classical model of fascism derived from political science, expressed as a progression from crisis to creation of a fascist movement to seizure of power, exercise of power, imperialism and military defeat. Among other issues, the model entails a restrictive interpretation that excludes fascist identifications and everything this implies for the study of the past and its echoes in the present. The history of fascism is far more complex than that.

The classical model has been problematic in the historiography of fascism, or at least it seems so to us. Most attempts at defining it and its practical features have strayed little from the historical space occupied by the Italian and German experiences, which have been elevated to paradigms. This classical fascism is a kind of radiating nucleus; its sparks are reflected in other imitative experiences (the epigones), usually without the success of the original. The result has often been a snapshot: a fossilized

image that lacks the historical and formational dynamics of fascisms. Such ideal-type fascism would be a kind of reaction, aimed at suppressing representation and deactivating the socialist alternative to power, deployed by irredentist, war-traumatized ex-combatants, heir to the defeat of 1918 and haunted by the ghosts of 1917.

It is probably clear by now that we do not entirely agree with this view. From the outset it excludes the possibility of fascism being proactive rather than merely reactive and eliminates its cultural roots prior to the 1910s and '20s – and therefore prior to the First World War. It also excludes from the interpretative panorama the development of fascism alongside other political cultures in Europe during the first third of the twentieth century. As a result, any country that was not defeated in 1918 – including Spain – is eliminated from the fascist family. Seen in this way the fascist experience would have reached its apogee (needing no further deployment) in 1925 in Italy and 1933 in Germany, when constitutional guarantees were suppressed, (controlled) demolition of the liberal constitutional system occurred, and revolutionary alternatives were banned from the public arena. But we know that fascism was much more than that.

In Europe, other forms of fascism existed that did not respond to liberal democracies in crisis or to nationalist territorial irredentism. Of course, these and other factors contributed to their creation and as political movements, but beyond that they needed propitious contexts to facilitate a transition from project to reality, from rhetoric and symbolism to the practice and exercise of power.

Fascism in its most advanced expression as National Socialism cannot be understood apart from the colossal economic crisis and the unemployment of Weimar Germany. This does not imply that only the outraged and unemployed voted for Hitler in 1932, not least because socialist and anarchist workers' movements were best at capitalizing on the labour unrest of the 1920s and '30s in Europe. They clearly never would have reached power without the support of individuals who saw the Nazi utopian alternative as a way out of the crisis that impacted not only their national identity and civilizing culture – if it was felt deeply enough to move them to protest and combat – but above all their lives and the lives of their families. This aspect of fascism should not be disregarded: not only was it an alternative to the liberalism that had burned to ashes in the trenches of the First World War, but it was a national movement for

constructing and deploying a utopia of well-being and development. National humiliation in defeat works very well in political speeches and in the a posteriori explanations they generate, but what earns votes in times of economic, employment or security crisis is an offer of growth, work and defence for the community. The populist element has always been embedded in fascist movements as a ‘quick fix’ for the problems and complexities – often perceived as unwanted growths or quasi-intellectual carbuncles – of contemporary societies.

Continuing briefly in the German example, the very iconoclastic historian Götz Aly develops something similar in *Hitler's Beneficiaries: How the Nazis Bought the German People* (2005). The title is slightly misleading because the author argues that National Socialism did not ‘buy’ the people but won them over with the creation of a welfare state, a ‘National Socialism’ built from plunder. In other words, Germans and the national administrations of German-occupied countries during the Second World War were the main beneficiaries of the policies of occupation, plunder, Aryanization of the economy (liquidation of Jewish property), expulsion and elimination of racial minorities and the construction of a racially hierarchical Europe. This was a primary mechanism for constituting a kind of welfare state, a national socialist ‘people’s state’ and the cornerstone of the German fascist project. It rested on plunder, robbery and appropriation to raise Germany from the ashes of deep cultural and identitary interwar crisis: one that was also contingent, political and economic, marked by unemployment, indignation and populism. Fascism came into this frame – and has since been presented by analysts – as a political religion, a phenomenon of yearning and a longing for transcendence. It managed to seize power in specific, contingent circumstances that allowed it to erect itself as one of the great civilizing alternatives of twentieth-century Europe.

If we understand fascism as a form of state built from combative, palingenetic and violent counter-revolution, a hierarchical and organic organization of society for growth and well-being as a national community, and as an amendment of every geopolitical, economic, representative or gender aspect of nineteenth-century and new interwar liberal democracies, then fascism can only be understood from power, no matter how utopian it may be.

Power was accessed by various means, depending on the moments and contexts. It could not be the same in the 1920s as in the '30s, when democracies were already aware of how Mussolini exercised power. Italy was the 'early comer', and Germany had co-opted the democratic system from within. Then there were the civil wars in Spain and other complex scenarios of invasion or confrontation between resistance and collaboration in territories such as Croatia, France or Romania. A very early fascist movement developed in the last of these, with the Legion of the Archangel Michael, created in 1927 by Corneliu Zelea Codreanu. In 1930 it became the Iron Guard, the fascist movement that was integrated into the National Legionary State of General Ion Antonescu. Other examples of construction came from within fascist regimes, such as the 4 August Regime led by General Metaxas in Greece from 1936 until his death in 1941. It contributed to German occupation that same year, leading to the creation of a collaborationist regime that was embroiled in a civil war and dependent on the country's complex geostrategic situation. In Greece, Romania, France and most certainly Spain, military profession and rank were clearly no impediment to leading a movement or even a state belonging to the fascist family.

To deny the viability of fascisms that did not come to power through legal means based on existing parameters would constitute a conceptual and historical perversion in our view, because it assumes that fascisms could not use armed force to impose themselves and prevail over citizen resistance. There must be more possibilities than unconditional, unanimous support – which there never was – or cunning use of institutions to eventually destroy them from within.

The German and Italian examples demonstrate that there was no single form of fascism. These changing regimes not only sought to alter reality but had to adapt to it. In other words, context is not everything when approaching the history of fascism and fascisms, but it is a significant element of analysis.

In the broader context, the chronology of fascisms occupies the 1930s and '40s especially. The Second World War provides the frame for the greatest number of states belonging directly to, or imported into, the family of fascisms: a family that was dismembered and destroyed, though not annihilated, in 1945. If it had succeeded in its all-out war against liberal democracies and communism – which Mussolini identified as the other two

contemporary historical revolutions – it would have become the great dominant reality, the great political project, the great alternative to the liberal democracies born from nineteenth-century revolutionary precepts, and the great retaining wall against communist regimes. We cannot underestimate what Europe might have been if the Axis had won the Second World War. It is harrowing enough to recall what fascist Europe was prior to that conflict, let alone the features it acquired within the frame of war: eliminationism, extreme imperialism, racial relocation, social utopia. As Joseph Goebbels wrote in his diaries (as received from Hitler himself), war offered opportunities for full and unhindered development of the reality of the German fascist regime that would be unthinkable in peacetime.

Thus, speaking about fascisms in the plural makes it possible to include both the common elements and the differentials in the varied national experiences of this self-identifying family. Historically its members cultivated bonds that united them, even across the boundaries that separated them. Despite its irredentist ultranationalism, fascism also became a kind of counter-revolutionary International (it seems the two were not incompatible), based not only on example or impregnation but on collaboration. A Fascist International: born – and not by chance – in the context of the Spanish Civil War, the frame that created one of the most notorious concepts of the twentieth century. The Rome–Berlin Axis was forged in 1936, assisted by the counter-revolutionary insurgent movement against the Second Republic in Spain.

In fact, counter-revolution was a defining element of European fascisms, from the early comer Italians to the other regimes that bore the label. It does not explain them entirely, nor is it the only interpretative key, but dynamics of armed preventative counter-revolution were set in motion to avoid revolutionary contagion (though in most cases, a prior or latent revolutionary process was not even required; the rhetoric sufficed). These dynamics precipitated the rise of fascism to power through *coups d'état*, leading to political repression or civil war. Without the Soviet counter-example, fascism and other ultranationalist political movements might not have existed. The year 1917 (and 1922, with the creation of the Soviet Union) marked a before and after in Europe: in power-seizing practices, or what Curzio Malaparte in 1931 called 'coup d'état techniques'; in the expectations of a workers' movement that soon adopted general strikes and revolutionary techniques (think of Spain in 1917); in the potential

economic, political and cultural victims of the revolution; and, of course, in how other social and political agents perceived, received and fought against the revolution.

The struggle against real, latent or imaginary revolutionary threats amalgamated the conservative, nationalist, irredentist or revisionist political forces that saw fascism as the armed response to socialism. However, the fascist political alternative established itself in Italy in tandem with other authoritarian political regimes, including the Second Polish Republic and the kingdoms of Bulgaria, Yugoslavia, Hungary, Romania and Greece. The contemporaneous dictatorships prior to the 1930s were not fascist but sometimes imitated fascist forms of government and were influenced by corporativism, authoritarianism and anti-parliamentarism. They had internal revolution/counter-revolution conflicts, border issues and problems managing national minorities, but they were not fascist regimes. The dictatorship of Miguel Primo de Rivera in Spain (1923–30), for example, embarked upon what Eduardo González Calleja summarized in 2005 as authoritarian modernization, combining traditionalist–right elements with corporatist and authoritarian elements more akin to the Italian experience. It failed in many respects, especially in the construction of a single party capable of mobilizing a significant portion of society. However, it laid the foundations of a regime that Primo de Rivera's son José Antonio ardently defended in his early public appearances. In many ways the authoritarian regimes of the 1920s defined a period in which fascism was influential but failed to become hegemonic.

Of course, fascist movements contained elements that differentiated them from other political alternatives born after, or even before, the First World War. Fascist paramilitary organizations embraced the cult to violence, the centrality of struggle in discourse and praxis, crushing the enemy of fascism and the enemy of the nation (which amounted to the same thing: fascism tended to establish itself as the sole naturalized representative of the nation, with no nation existing outside the fascist national community).

Fascism resulted from fascistization, and nothing worked better than violence to fascistize society. We are aware that it is no small audacity to propose the existence of a 'fascist' violence (strongly masculinized, indebted to trench solidarity and its subsequent mythification): a repertoire of violence ranging from the persecution of socialists, communists and

anarchists in Bologna in 1922 to the extermination of Jews in Europe and the racial hierarchy project for the continent during the Second World War. But we believe, as Aristotle Kallis suggests, that fascism contained genocidal potential. Taken to its extreme, such power fuelled the mass murder of entire population groups by the Third Reich between 1942 and 1945. In interwar Europe, other fascisms passed through its preceding stages of identification, expulsion and exploitation.

We know from the works of Tim Mason that acceptance of violence was a homogenizing element in all triumphant fascisms, which ironed out implicit ideological impurities. It served as fascism's most powerful political magnet for interwar right-wing conservatives. Political scientist Daniel Woodley in *Fascism and Political Theory: Critical Perspectives on Fascist Ideology* (2009) argues that fascist violence had specific forms and objectives as well as three great functions: social cleansing, promotion of a horizontal experience of combat and solidarity – and vertical obedience, we would add – and the projection, exhibition and ostentation of force and power. This was no 'irrational' violence, as the Marxist historian Eric Hobsbawm called it. It was a vehicle coherent with the paligenetic construction of a nation conceived as a biological and historical community of like-minded individuals threatened by foreign elements. None of the fascisms renounced this vehicle. The Spanish fascist author Agustín de Foxá (1906–1959), like many others, claimed that such a rebirth required purification, cleansing, collapse, ruins . . . the destruction on which the nation would be constructed.

Violence was thus quintessential to fascistization in societies where fascist regimes developed and was favoured in the militarized contexts that generally hosted these processes. The Italian example was no exception – the weight of paramilitarization was evident before it came to power, as we shall see – though it had less relevance there than in other places, such as in Spain. Furthermore, in purely organizational terms, fascisms tend to create institutional architectures in which political pre-eminence, representativity and societal order become the domain of single parties. In these spaces, party, state and leader converge, and the leader emerges as the only source of legitimacy and legality. Leader logic, hierarchy, *Führerprinzip*: whatever the descriptor, it was ultimately a mechanism for completely altering the forms or representation and legitimacy born of revolutionary liberalism, which envisioned (at least in theory) the deployment of political power

based on a sovereignty that rested on the principle of citizenship rather than belonging.

Are these features comparable to the proposals of far-right populisms today? Is this what the radical right is demanding? Indeed, some far-right splinter groups today, like others that emerged after 1945 in post-fascist Europe, call for violence, social homogeneity and identity nationalism. They may reproduce historical fascist traits, such as antisemitism (usually whitewashed as anti-Zionism) or anti-communism. They may even consider themselves fascist groups rhetorically and symbolically, but they are anachronisms, nowhere near becoming real power alternatives; and if we place ourselves within the framework of the radical right, the distance with regard to fascism only increases. To our knowledge, no group or party (past or current) of the new radical populist right in Europe has invoked the state of exception implicit to fascism as a way of exercising power. It seems unthinkable that any of these parties – from the National Rally to Vox to Fidesz of Hungary– would call for fascism as Mussolini defined it: a permanent state of war.

The age of fascism: Italy as an early comer

So let us look at fascism from a historical perspective. In the early 1920s, Europe witnessed the birth of a political, institutional and identity alternative to the colossal economic, social and cultural crisis generated by the First World War itself, and its bitter effects on the labour market. Milan's Piazza San Sepolcro has since been identified as the birthplace of this grand new political project. In March 1919, just over a hundred assorted individuals responded to the call from the socialist Benito Mussolini and his newspaper, *Il Popolo d'Italia*, to lay the political and programmatic foundations of what even then was called fascism, in nostalgic tribute to the late nineteenth-century myth of the Sicilian grain sheaf, or *fasci*. The original scenario also became the name of a founding term in Italian and world fascism, *Sansepolcristmo*: a geographical, political, identity and mythical concept alluding to a place, to a spirit, to heroism, to the primitive, to genesis. All political cultures need myths, especially one as recent as fascism, and the more solid these myths are, the more vividly those who embrace them and identify with them can imagine their place in

the world. This is one of the great attractions of fascism: it goes beyond politics to become a form of transcendent identity.

Although some historians of political thought place fascism intellectually within French Marxist revisionism, its Italian maternity is indisputable. The word 'fascism' is one of the few Italian words – along with some others related to food – that remains virtually intact when exported (as a neologism, variance in translation to other languages would generally be minimal). The etymology underscores the primacy of the Italian fascist phenomenon in the genealogy of the great era that emerged from the ashes of the First World War. However, this should not lead us to teleological conclusions, implying, for example, that it resulted from late unification and nationalization in Italy and could not have happened anywhere else. Italy was indeed going through a very contingent political–institutional crisis, but it is a long road from there to identifying crisis as the *sine qua non* for the birth of fascism. Approaches unrelated to historiography tend to rush down that road without a second thought, while historians hasten to add qualifiers.

Like all historical phenomena, the genealogy of Italian fascism – the first in the brief history of fascist regimes – can give an impression of teleology, single-variable determination, homogeneity and coherence from beginning to end. Nothing could be further from the truth, though admittedly fascism was the political movement that best capitalized on governing Italy in the crisis following its rather uneven participation in the First World War. Our tendency to look for the origins of fascism among paramilitary movements following the First World War or in concepts such as the 'mutilated victory' in Italy in 1918, or to follow ex-combatant movements like the *arditi* (veterans from elite Italian army units) and cite the capture of the city of Fiume (the Croatian city of Rijeka) by the aviator-poet Gabriele D'Annunzio in September 1919 as antecedents of fascism, all flow out of the victory and rise to power of the fascist model in 1922. Without that co-opting, that rise to power, neither the epic nor the reconstruction of the origins would have made sense. The heroic narrative would have amounted to no more than another example of failed movements of irredentist lunatics or armed groups of misplaced, ultranationalist and paramilitarized individuals. However, it would not have affected political reality, which is something infinitely more complex than its representation a posteriori. Even *Sansepolcristmo* and the embryonic

fascist organizations of 1914–15 in Milan might have remained simple anecdotes that never reached the historians of today. And yet all this is looked upon now as the genesis of fascism.

Could scarcely more than one hundred men really have flipped the switch that led to imperial conquest? To a full-scale war the likes of which had never existed before? To Auschwitz? It is impossible not to see teleology in this. And yet the history of fascism in Italy is one of unexpected growth to the point of becoming a real alternative to power. The incipient *fasci italiani di combattimento* (fascist combat groups), born of protest and the desire for direct action, drew more and more men into a single vocation to build an anti-socialist, anti-liberal political movement with a will to power. In October 1919 around 17,000 members attended the conference of the movement in Florence. The following year in September, attendance nearly doubled to more than 30,000. This was linked to D'Annunzio's failed occupation of Fiume and the aviator's decision to declare war on his own country following the 1920 Treaty of Rapallo between Rome and Belgrade. Then in 1921, amid waves of revolutionary strikes, conference attendance soared to over 100,000 members, organized into 800 sections.

Within this frame, the Fasci deployed a *squadrista* strategy, a feature that outranked even its symbolism and its rhetoric. In what would later be called the 'days of struggle' – clearly a mythopoetic reconstruction of an infinitely more mundane reality – local groups would viciously hunt down strikers, break into the left-wing *case del Popolo* (party and trade union social centres) and prevent land occupations. The most important Italian industrial and agricultural employers' associations, Confindustria and Confagricoltura, supported this form of 'white terror'. Organized squadrons of 'Blackshirts' (the uniform colour became a signifier for 'fascist') carried out truly punitive expeditions in the countryside and in the city, especially in 'red' regions such as Emilia-Romagna. These were the years of *olio e manganello* – castor oil and the cudgel – against socialists and Catholic labour organizations. They were also the years when the *Ras* leadership was formed, as local party bosses rose to prominence in 1921 with the creation of the National Fascist Party (Partito Nazionale Fascista, PNF), including Roberto Farinacci in Cremona, Dino Grandi in Bologna and Italo Balbo in Ferrara. Above them all towered the figure of the great leader and founder of the movement, Benito Mussolini, who was 39 at the time.

Now structured as a political party, the fascist movement began its journey to create a nationalist, counter-revolutionary political space that was internally contrary to liberal constitutional forms of power. This ran in tandem with a strategy of increasing political tension, at least in public and institutional life, reinforced by the exponential growth of the *fasci* paramilitary squads. In 1921 there were around 320,000 members organized into 2,200 groups throughout the country. This two-pronged political action characterized the early fascisms of Italy and Germany. While engaging in open displays of violence, they stood for office as part of Giovanni Giolitti's National Bloc in 1921 and won thirty seats in parliament. Altogether the National Bloc won 270 seats, followed by the Catholic People's Party (200 seats), the Socialist Party (122 seats) and the Communist Party (16 seats). With such meagre electoral results for revolution and counter-revolution, the political situation in Italy prior to Mussolini's rise to power did not seem very extreme.

No fascist revolution, no power grab, no *coup d'état*, yet the ungovernable parliament resulting from those elections enabled Mussolini to co-opt the leadership of a minority government under the Italian monarch. As the PNF openly called for liquidation of the 'inoperative' liberal order, its members thwarted the socialist-anarchist general strike organized by the Labour Alliance in the summer of 1922. Fascist party members replaced workers in the factories so that production would continue, and city centres were occupied in Venice, Modena and Ferrara. If fascism did not take hold inside the factory gates, it certainly helped to ensure that socialism did not leak beyond them. This resounding political and organizational success set the scene for the much-mythologized phenomenon that put Mussolini in power: the March on Rome in October 1922, devised by Italo Balbo. In this show of force mixed with populist, anti-establishment demands, some 50,000 Blackshirts descended on the capital by train and private transportation to force Victor Emmanuel III to name the PNF leader as head of government. Mussolini himself, acting cautiously given the possibility of a fiasco, did not travel to Rome but waited in Milan for news of the outcome. In hindsight, a demonstration involving 50,000 people was significant considering the means and possibilities available in the 1920s; but it certainly does not seem like unbearable pressure for a monarch. In fact, the march on Rome gave the king a perfect excuse to throw himself into Mussolini's arms.

Totalitarianism did not begin when Mussolini took power; in fact, it could not even be called a fascist regime. His first government was a coalition with only three PNF ministers and Mussolini, who assumed the presidency and some ministries. He repeated that tactic on several occasions throughout his life, as a manifestation of his highly personalized exercise of power.

The PNF acquired institutional logic and respectability while reinforcing its party–state presence with the creation of institutions such as the Grand Council of Fascism in December 1922 and the National Security Volunteer Militia, which sought to organize the adult male population into militarized structures. The party's predominance became increasingly evident after the 1924 elections, in which Mussolini and his National List (Lista Patriottica) – comprised of liberals, conservatives and fascists – won 275 of the 374 seats. This reflected some obvious legal rigging by means of the Acerbo Law, which gave the PNF two-thirds of the seats in the Chamber of Deputies. Such manoeuvres were common in fascistization processes. As Il Duce himself said in relation to the unification of parties in Spain in 1937, the key to constructing fascism was not to transform members of other political forces and cultures into fascists, but to ensure that fascism emerged predominant from the resulting convergence of forces. In the resulting political hybridization, fascism would always act as a magnetic pole.

After gaining control of the Chamber and establishing the bases for fascistizing politics, the fascistization of the state began, which is what Mussolini and his followers had been desiring since 1915. After the assassination of the socialist deputy and renowned anti-fascist Giacomo Matteotti in June 1924, the government issued decrees to end freedom of the press, dissolve parliament, reinstate the death penalty and dismiss opposition deputies, leading to massive political exile. The king did not remove Mussolini (who had been accused of instigating Matteotti's kidnapping and death) from office at that time, once again linking his fate to that of the fascist leader. Thus reinforced, Il Duce launched a raft of 'most fascist laws' to transform an improbable system of constitutional representative democracy into a one-party regime around himself as the supreme leader, with ruthless intolerance for opposition and dissent. The Law on the Defense of the State increased Mussolini's power exponentially, but what really expanded it were practical actions such as abolishing political parties and free association, reforming the Penal Code to include

internal exile – *confino* – and the creation in 1927 of OVRA (Opera Vigilanza e Repressione dell'Antifascismo) to persecute the opposition. This dealt the final blow to the liberal system and ushered in a totalitarian state: one of economic control, investment in public works, repopulation, transformation, recruitment, social order and hierarchy.

Representative liberal democracy was no longer necessary; only popular referenda around the indestructible bloc of the nation, united by the great legislative works of the regime, namely the Charter of Labour or Carta del Lavoro of 1927. This 'fascist constitution' of sorts inspired the Fuero de los Trabajadores of 1938 in Spain, the first and most important of the Spanish fascist laws, which regulated the relationship between citizens and the state through work. The former seat of legislative power was now occupied by the Camera dei Fasci e delle corporazioni, a consultative body and transmission line for government-led economic policies. There, production organisms were represented vertically, giving rise to what would become the typical corporative organization of fascist regimes (and others, such as that of Primo de Rivera and his National Consultative Assembly in Spain (1927–30)).

The Italian corporative chamber was not elected; it functioned as an advisory body to Il Duce. Four hundred members were selected by the Grand Council and endorsed in plebiscites (in 1929 and 1934) based on single lists, which gave them up to 98.4 per cent support. As has been demonstrated on so many occasions, pushing ballots into a ballot box is not synonymous with democracy.

Before the National Socialist Party in Germany (NSDAP) came to power in 1933, Italy was already busy adapting its fascist political project to the specific realities of its institutions and citizens. As mentioned earlier, the significance of the Italian experience from 1922 onwards sometimes pales in the blinding glare of the organizational capacity and the political and economic strength of Nazi Germany. Patrizia Dogliani has explained this with great precision in *Il fascismo degli italiani* (2014), observing how literature and cinema also helped to diminish its weight. In the comic, burlesque tone of Federico Fellini's partially autobiographical *Amarcord* (1973), set in the fascist years, Il Duce appears as a gigantic, oneiric, omnipresent head. Roberto Benigni's light-hearted and lyrical *Life Is Beautiful* (1997) made a well-deserved mockery of Italian racial laws in 1938. While such films can bring us visually closer to the complex and

normalized (if not banalized) reality of Italian totalitarianism, the primordial Italian fascist experience within the great family of European fascisms should never be underestimated. Nor should the degree of deployment it achieved, with a party that aspired to incarnate the true national community in its ranks, and a Grand Council as the supreme organ of power. It could even remove Il Duce and did just that in 1943. Such a thing would have been unthinkable and legally impossible in Spain at that time.

According to PNF calculations, in 1942 there were about 27 million people affiliated to party organizations: the Opera Nazionale Dopolavoro for workers and producers, the Opera Nazionale Balilla for youth (60,000 in 1924; 6 million in 1937), the Avanguardia Studentesca for post-secondary students and the Massaie Rurali groups for rural women (up to 3 million) who were members of the party's Fasci Femminili. These groups best illustrate the type – or 'style' in fascist terms – of new society under fascism: not a unanimous or plural society but one of social order and hierarchy, community belonging, identification with the homeland and being Italian.

With these legislative, institutional, social and cultural tools, fascism launched out to pursue its great aim of transforming Italy and the Italians into a united nation. The Lateran Pacts with the Vatican in 1929 even enabled recovery of the territorial unification of the Risorgimento of 1871. New institutions were created, including the Ministry of Press and Propaganda in 1935, run by Mussolini's son-in-law Galeazzo Ciano, and the Ministry of Popular Culture (the notorious MinCulPop) in 1937, under Dino Alfieri. Policies openly designed to transform society were also implemented. The fascist natality policies developed in this context included a celibacy tax and fiscal exemptions for large families. They fostered Italian population growth from 38 million registered in 1922 to 45 million in 1937 (though some of this was attributable to procedural improvements for recording births and deaths). With the same objective of transforming Italian society, racial laws were passed in 1938. These mimicked the German laws of 1935, with some home-grown elements that excluded Jews from public life and prohibited adoptions and mixed marriages except among ex-combatants and PNF members.

Italy under fascism boasted a new style of uniformity and social order that disdained class hierarchies – people stopped using the formal pronoun

lei – and updated aesthetics, especially in urban architecture and public infrastructures. The train stations of Milan and Florence provide a good sample of this, as do the Fascio houses in Como and the entire EUR district of Rome, a modern neighbourhood in the southern part of the city.

Interventionist, palingenetic, imperialist: a power that saw itself as a reflection of the Roman Empire and borrowed from that era to construct in the present, eliminating contingency and erasing what Il Duce called the ‘centuries of decadence’. This palingenesis was not so much a recovery as an updating of the past to construct and legitimize the present and the future. It implied ‘construction’ in the literal sense, a form parallel to destruction and a reification of space, as demonstrated in the brutal demolition campaigns in the centre of Rome during the 1920s and ’30s. Sections of the city surrounding the Capitolium, the Colosseum, several imperial fora and the Circus Maximus were destroyed to enhance the grandeur of those structures and create a scenario for the great regime parades. Fascism as a culture or a subculture was extremely fond of regimented parades, public display, and homogenization of the individual into a uniform and uniformed mass.

The long-standing issue of imperialism aptly illustrates the degree of trivialization, stereotyping and ignorance surrounding the complex reality of Italian fascism. Mussolini called for a Rome revived by fascism, a Roman Mediterranean, an empire. Though his words and speeches overflowed with the habitual hollow rhetoric of new regimes, he was actually calling for explicit use of the myth of Roman-ness and empire to legitimize a tremendously aggressive foreign policy, something he further justified because Italy had been rather secondary in nineteenth-century imperial distribution. Accordingly, for nearly twenty years, Italian diplomacy and military action reflected a single declared objective: to claim a place in the international theatre and become a great power that was not subordinated to the interests of other countries. If history was for Mussolini an aggressive struggle between peoples – young and old, vital and decadent, revolutionary and conservative, anti-democratic and liberal democratic – then international politics should acknowledge Italy’s new place, won through dynamic national revolution. If space was not granted, it would be carved out. Such a stance exemplifies the characteristically bellicose aggressiveness of fascism and its lack of euphemism when projecting its

political projects on to its specific realities, as much as was possible or allowed.

Mussolini's particular crossing of the Rubicon did not start a civil war, as Julius Caesar's had. Instead, it led to a brutally unequal campaign to occupy Ethiopia, the defeat of Emperor Haile Selassie's kingdom of Abyssinia – a member of the League of Nations – and the ascension of Victor Emmanuel III to the rank of emperor in May 1936. The combined Italian forces of around 600,000 soldiers were vastly superior in weapons and low on scruples, despite Mussolini's claims to the contrary, which led them to use poison gas (mustard, arsine) against African troops. The practice was denied until very recently, when evidence from Italian historians such as Angelo Del Boca (1996) and later Nicola Labanca (2012) demonstrated that these extremely lethal actions were indeed carried out. Italian colonial power inflicted all manner of violence on the indigenous people: expropriations, deportations, racial segregation, summary justice and proud, undisguised sexual violence against Abyssinian women and girls. This has only recently been officially recognized.

Few things may have given Mussolini greater satisfaction than celebrating the bimillennial of the birth of the emperor Caesar Augustus by restoring the Ara Pacis Augustæ, the Altar of Peace. Built in 13 BCE to commemorate that leader's victories in Gaul and Spain, attempts had been made early in the century to rescue its ruins from beneath the foundations of a Renaissance palace. This time it would be a complete technical and scientific success: planning began in 1933 and the work started in 1937, which required freezing the flooded Roman subsoil. After forcing the Florentine Uffizi Gallery and the Vatican Museums to relinquish their bas-reliefs from the famous structure, Mussolini and his government inaugurated the restored altar in 1938. It was a superlative demonstration of power and a bold declaration: not of the intentions but the reality of a fascist empire directly descended from the Roman one.

Meanwhile, fascism was transforming the map of Europe through explicit, decisive support for its natural allies in the Spanish Civil War (1936–9), which had been raging for two years on the western edge of the continent. Italy was destined to dominate Europe alongside its natural ally, Germany, though much of Italian public opinion at the time held that country responsible for all the evils of the century.

It mattered little that the Italian army had been bombing Ethiopians with mustard gas prior to the creation of the Rome–Berlin Axis on 1 November 1936, in the frame of joint aid to Franco’s uprising in Spain. The Italian Parliament did not acknowledge the violence and use of gas in the Ethiopian war of occupation until 1996. Until then it remained a taboo smothered in denial. This banalization of Italian colonialism – and fascism along with it – is difficult to reconcile with the complexity of historical contingency. The narrative was metaphorically perfect: good colonialism in Libya and Ethiopia against an erroneous expansionist policy in Europe marked by alignment with a Third Reich, on to which the most sinister angles of Italian fascism were projected. Hitler was the epitome of all evils, though Mussolini was perfect for the job. Fascist Italy attacked Ethiopia in 1935, intervened in the Spanish war against the Republic in 1936, occupied Albania in 1939, attacked Greece in 1940, attempted an ill-fated offensive against France, then in 1941 joined forces with Germany to invade Yugoslavia and the Soviet Union. On all these occasions, and especially the wars of occupation, the outcome was extreme violence. As in Spain or Italy, war was the propitiatory context, the natural and desired space. It constituted the perfect place for developing the real social and political projects of fascisms: those alluded to in peacetime but radicalized in wartime.

Paramilitary violence, political persecution, expelling the adversary, racism, war crimes. In scarcely fifteen years, Mussolini and his followers had constructed a totalitarian, corporativist, ultranationalist, imperialist regime alien to the liberal-rooted constitutional conservatism that had prevailed over the socialist threat born in 1917. They felt they had reason to be proud, even if they could not imagine how little time they had left in power, even if that ‘little’ would involve the worst collective massacres in the history of humanity. The Italian fascists could always claim first place for having created the movement and given it a name, though the multiple lenses of history have shown us that its greatest impact would be in Germany.

The highest exponent of fascism: Germany

The historical context that framed the rise of the National Socialist Party in Germany (NSDAP) to power differed from that of the PNF in Italy, though

they share some features. Here we will not dwell on Imperial Army ex-combatant movements such as the *Freikorps*, where the leader of the paramilitary organization known as Sturmabteilung (SA), Ernst Röhm, and Auschwitz commandant Rudolf Höss were both members, or the provenance of Hitler, Rosenberg, Hess, Himmler and Goebbels. There is no need to recall their Bavarian ultraconservative origins or to re-emphasize their supposed contacts with racial-populist secret societies in the literal sense of the word *völkisch* (a difficult concept to translate, as it denotes a romantic nationalism that exalts the ethnocultural values of the German people, the *volk*) – the word also implied an antisemitic, social nationalist, racial identitarian profile opposed to the Weimar Republic. The Thule Society, for example, was a precursor to the anti-capitalist, antisemitic, anti-liberal German Worker's Party (DAP), which changed its name to the NSDAP in April 1920 and elevated young Hitler to leadership in July 1921.

There is no need to make these connections because no Nazi leader belonged to them, apart from a few contacts that the great ideologues Hess and Rosenberg cultivated early on in their NSDAP membership. Also, when Hitler took control of the party, he prohibited ultra-minority secret societies and shut down Thule in 1930. Despite their organizational irrelevance, however, they left a great cultural and symbolic mark (starting with the swastika on the party flag). But perhaps it is also advisable to move on less transcendental planes. As with the beginnings of the Italian fascist movement, teleological constructions a posteriori have given enormous importance to historical elements and processes such as party organization and its reference image of the *fasci*. They speak of the importance of the courage shown by Hitler and his followers at the Munich Putsch of November 1923 to protest the end of passive resistance to the economic conditions of the Ruhr Valley, which had been imposed by the Entente powers after Germany's defeat in the First World War, even though this was also a failed attempt to overthrow the German government. They underscore the Promethean nature of Hitler's sentence for high treason and condemnation to five years in prison (though he only served nine months in Landberg) because he dictated his political thought to Hess during that time, later published as *Mein Kampf* (1925). Yet Alfred Rosenberg was the real ideologue and strategist behind antisemitism, *Lebensraum* and Versailles revisionism.

Many elements of Nazi power in Germany can only be understood by considering their positioning prior to the Munich coup, with the creation of the Röhm SA assault detachments (storm troopers) in 1921, or subsequently, with the creation of the paramilitary organization Schutzstaffel (SS) in 1925. It would be impossible to grasp this rise to power without first attending to the combination of violence and propaganda in both of those paramilitary formations, and the influence of someone like Joseph Goebbels in the capital of Berlin. For the purposes of this book, however, it must be emphasized that the real political conditions which gave the Nazi Party the chancellorship of Germany were framed in the Weimar Republic and the Great Depression following the stock market crash of 1929 and withdrawal of credit flows in Europe. This led to a radical loss of purchasing power, failed businesses and mass unemployment.

The NSDAP entered this scenario and became a party of the masses: a repository for the conservative and counter-revolutionary vote in Protestant and rural areas, as well as glue for the anti-republican hatred arising from the deterioration of living conditions throughout Germany. Of course, the long debate over political responsibilities and alternatives that were not considered before Hindenburg asked Hitler to form a government in January 1933 should also be mentioned. Two months earlier, for example, Chancellor Kurt von Schleicher tried using political alliances to weaken and isolate the NSDAP. However, Hitler and his party seemed to have no political ceiling; votes for the party doubled between September 1930 and July 1932. This was subject to revision, however, as they proceeded to lose 2 million votes from July to November, but other factors were converging. There was pressure on the streets, with violent campaigns between the SA and members of the socialist and communist parties; the latent threat of a *coup d'état*; personal pressures, as when the former chancellor Franz von Papen refused to take up office and insisted on giving it to the Nazis; and, very probably, President Hindenburg's deep conviction that this was the way out of the German crisis. As a result, and as had occurred with Mussolini in 1922, Hitler was called to form a government on 30 January 1933. Like the Italian leader, his first term was also as a minority government. Only three of the eleven ministers were NSDAP members, and Von Papen – a staunch believer in the conservative revolution – served as vice-chancellor.

We have already seen how, once in power, fascist regimes expand and strengthen themselves using the networks and powers of the state itself. But

a state is an incredibly complex organization encompassing all manner of institutions and administrations from the judiciary to city councils, and from the army to schools. These can be reformed, controlled and fascistized gradually, or all at once using the tool preferred by fascisms (and others) in contexts of regime change and transition: the state of exception. While it took Italian fascism three years to fully control the mechanisms of the state, Spanish fascism was born in a state of exception, because a proclamation of a state of war entails just that for the territory to which it is applied. In Germany, it was implemented on 27 March 1933, two months after Hitler became chancellor and one month after the notorious Reichstag fire of 27 February. It followed a tense, confrontational electoral campaign and elections in which the NSDAP won 44 per cent of the vote. This overwhelming success reflected how the Germans perceived Hitler and his movement as the ideal formation for getting the country back on track, turning the political and socio-economic crisis around and setting everything on a path to a bright future. After the elections, the autonomy of the *Länder* (federal states) and the municipalities came to an end as the *Gauleiters* (regional leaders of the NSDAP) assumed territorial powers. Meanwhile, the SA occupied opposition party headquarters and trade unions, and the swastika was required to be displayed as the national flag. Finally, Hindenburg signed the Enabling Act of 23 March 1933, which transferred powers from the legislature to the executive. It gave full powers to the chancellor and effectively destroyed the Weimar system. Thus the most advanced democracy in Europe, alongside that of Spain, was supplanted by that most fascist of legislative frameworks: a permanent state of exception.

Prior to the Enabling law, the Decree of the Reich President for the Protection of the People and the State was signed on 28 February 1933. It outlawed the Communist Party while strengthening and politicizing the police forces. Some 50,000 police posts were created, 80 per cent of which were filled by SA members in a glaring example of the strategy of entering state institutions to 'Nazify' them and thus build an ethnopopulist, revolutionary, *völkisch* state. This new totalitarian civilization was protected by the *Führerprinzip* – the leader/strongman principle – known as *caudillaje* in Spain. Accordingly, the leader became the supreme source of all law and ultimate legitimacy. In Spain, the latter originated in the Divine and was therefore providentialist in nature.

The history of Nazi violence also involves several points of no return. National Socialist doctrine described democracy as a ‘cancer’ and Marxism as ‘rot’ that had to be cut out, eliminated. Thus the history of Nazi Germany was one of integration and protection through exclusion and violence, from the special laws of 1933 that swept away all revolutionary tradition and exalted the protection and defence of the national community over individual rights (the right of ‘the people’ over subjective rights) to the anti-Jewish legislation in the aftermath of Kristallnacht – the Night of Broken Glass – on 9 November 1938.

The racial laws of 1935, imitated by Mussolini in 1938, marked one of the most important points of no return. This objectification of violence was behind the first concentration camp internments of 1933 based on who one was (communist, socialist, opposition) and for what one represented supra-individually (Jew, asocial). As German occupation spread across much of Europe from 1938 to 1940, the model was exported with it. Germany invaded countries with very important Jewish minorities during the Second World War. Managing the ‘problem’ of national and ethno-religious minorities involved experimentation and trial and error, which entailed the summary killings of 1941 and deportation to six extermination camps from 1942 onwards. Though not teleological in any way, there was no turning back on the path begun with intent and coherence in 1933.

The objective: to Nazify the state and the German people. The new administration opened the first concentration camp at Dachau, just outside Munich, in March 1933. The historian Robert Gellately recalled, in his 2001 work *Backing Hitler*, that its inauguration was publicized in all the main German media. Nothing educates better than example. In fact the prophylactic aspect of internment was never hidden in the German concentration camp system, linked as it was to the prison system and (perhaps even more) to political persecution, identity transformation and the re-education of Germans. The euphemisms would come later, with the absolute qualitative leap made by the creation of the six Aktion Reinhard extermination camps, which we will talk about in the next chapter. Meanwhile, Nazism – like Italian fascism – had made euphemism obsolete; this was an age for being explicit. The notorious and public anti-Jewish campaign urged on by the administrations included boycotts, the dismissal of civil servants, and the ideological hygiene campaign organized in May and June 1933 by the Nazi student federation (NSDStB), which left such

shocking images for history with its collective rituals to burn anti-German books. The time for concealment had passed in the new National Socialist Germany.

Germany quickly became a one-party regime through the prohibition and dissolution of other parties. The Communist Party had already been banned, and the Socialist Party was dissolved in June 1933, followed by the Catholic Zentrum party in July. At the pinnacle of power was the strongly hierarchical, top-down NSDAP. Within that structure, different agencies collaborated and sometimes competed to be closest to the Führer, his right-hand-man Rudolf Hess and his Chief of Staff Martin Bormann. These two ranked above the eighteen Reichführers – Goebbels, Himmler, Göring, Frank, Rosenberg and others – and the *Gauleiters*, the powerful territorial governors. With a monopoly on power, the party's political formations, and especially the still secondary SS (10,000 members in 1931; 50,000 in 1933; and 200,000 in 1935 after the dissolution of the SA), began to overpower the state institutions. The best example was Göring's creation of the Geheime Staatspolizei, the Gestapo secret police, to investigate cases of sabotage and treason. Eventually, they became the regime's all-powerful political police.

The aim of all this was to create a dual state – like in Italy, only more efficient – with a programme for mobilizing the population from cradle to grave. Organizations for youth (Hitler Youth), women, students, workers (German Labour Front, DAF) and the various NSDAP internal fronts gave shape to a totalitarian society aided by pictures, projection, narrative and an image as creators and protectors of the *Volksgemeinschaft* (the national community). This last task fell to Goebbels and his very effective Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda (March 1933). There, devotion to Hitler and Germany could only be absolute. The plebiscite to ratify Hitler as Head of State on 1 August 1934 provided the best possible internal and external demonstration of the fervent devotion of the German people to their Führer and the project he represented. In his welfare project for Germany, investment in public spending rose from 15 to 33 per cent of GDP between 1929 and 1938. Thanks to price and wage controls, along with decisions related to the refusal to comply with the rearmament and colonization clauses in the Treaty of Versailles, unemployment fell from 6 million to under half a million people.

The process, however, was neither as immediate nor as linear as it might seem. Fascistizing the institutions, the state and the political class took time.

To promote the last of these (and curry favour with the army), and to maintain internal order and control, the NSDAP carried out an internal purge of SA leadership and other party currents, which were seen as a threat to the state. The heads of Ernst Röhm (the SA leader accused of planning a *coup d'état*) and Gregor Strasser (organizer of the party's internal structure, representative of its anti-capitalist wing and political enemy of the Führer) were served up on a platter of bourgeois respectability to reduce internal rhetorical-symbolic revolutionary tensions. Strasser, whom Kurt von Schleicher had proposed as vice-chancellor in December 1932, in an attempt to split the NSDAP, was murdered (along with others, it seems) by Reinhard Heydrich at the Gestapo headquarters and his corpse was dismembered. His death was presented as a suicide.

That internal purge, known historically as the Night of the Long Knives, took place during the night of 30 June to 1 July 1934. Around two hundred people were killed, and thousands were arrested. It marked a radical change from the rhetorically revolutionary paramilitary logic of the movement to statist, truly dictatorial, totalitarian logic. In contrast with subjective, individual political persecution, objectifying violence established the conditions for the supra-individual violence of fully deployed fascisms. It also marked the change from the SA to the SS, which set itself up as a parallel state that combined objective terror with state respectability, first in Germany and then in the occupied territories. The transition was also reflected in the concentration camps. The SA 'savage camps' (Dachau, Oranienburg, Papenburg and others), designed for preventative internment of political enemies, became the 'Dachau model' of repression and legal terror against all those hostile to the *Volk*, led by Theodor Eicke and supervised by Himmler. All of it was conditioned by the objectification of violence.

However, this process was also contingent. We must not allow ourselves to be caught up in the easy tendency to see the 'origins' of something in everything that happens, especially when the 'something' is Auschwitz. In the European context, there was nothing exceptional about the first German camps and there was no prototype. They ranged in size from SA torture cellars with a handful of prisoners to the Prussian state camps on the Emsland plain that held 3,000 inmates by September 1933. There were no firm instructions about location either, so the authorities occupied every available space: hotels, pubs, ruined castles, abandoned barracks.

Improvisation was the watchword, and it extended to treatment of prisoners, reflecting a logic of preventative anomic internment. The sites varied immensely regarding forced labour, food, discipline and everyday violence. Murder remained the exception, with the early camps more about intimidation, though they shared the same general mission of crushing the opposition.

Without these political weapons, the new regime would never have been able to establish itself so quickly. The Nazi press was full of glowing reports about the camps and there were dozens of former prisoners explaining their experiences in the press. Releases were frequent; most inmates were discharged after a few weeks or months and maintained contact with family and friends during their incarceration. Before long all Germans knew about the camps, although their understanding of what was happening inside varied greatly. As the regime became established, however, the camps' usefulness declined. The emergent ss camp system was a small-scale, symbolic operation with dubious prospects. By the summer of 1935, there were only five concentration camps with about 4,000 prisoners among them, compared to over 100,000 inmates – a fifth of them political detainees – in the prison and penitentiary system. The Camp Inspection office in Berlin had only thirteen civil servants.

With Himmler's promotion to head of the Reich Police, the ss camp network grew more rapidly but with more limits than is usually thought. The Sachsenhausen camp opened in 1936, Buchenwald in 1937, Flossenbürg in 1938. After the Anschluss (the German annexation of Austria in 1938, based on the argument that Chancellor Arthur Seyss-Inquart requested German military presence), the infamous Mauthausen camp opened in 1938. The Ravensbrück camp for women opened the year after, this time reflecting the classic image of a totalitarian camp: with electrified barbed wire, *Appellplatz* (exercise yard) and forced labour. The concentration camp was, as Nikolaus Wachsmann described in *KL* in 2012, the space of passage from individual to supra-individual terror, from political to social terror, of total segregation with or without criminal charges for the benefit of the people and the race. Homosexuals, Jehovah's Witnesses and conscientious objectors were interned from 1935 on, followed by Roma populations, 'vagrants' and 'asocials', such as beggars, vagabonds or pimps. But, as Wachsmann observes, this does not mean that we should elevate the concentration camp to the pinnacle of National

Socialist power. There were around 7,500 detainees in 1937 and 24,000 a year later (by that time in Spain, more than 200,000 Republican prisoners of war had already seen the inside of concentration camps). The exponential leap is evident, but their role still seems secondary, even in the year before the outbreak of the Second World War. Until 1939 the violence was objective but relational. However, we will see in the next chapter that from 1939 onwards, and especially from 1941, relational terror became absolute genocidal terror.

Seen in perspective, and with knowledge of Nazi social engineering practices during the Second World War, the German national community clearly united around the elimination of internal dissent under the banner of law and order, amid the construction of a dictatorship of mutual favours and collective exploitation of the common enemy. We also know today that, under that flag, the protection and Aryanization of the *Volk* was pursued through separation and elimination of political dissent, expulsion of the socially 'different' and prophylactic practices against those considered racially 'inferior'. Here again, we cannot turn an explanation into a teleology, as if there had been no alternatives, parallel paths or points of no return.

Two of those points occurred on very specific dates: 15 September 1935 and 9 November 1938. The first corresponds to the promulgation of the racial laws or Nuremberg laws, masterminded by the jurist and Minister of the Interior Wilhelm Frick. These were crucial to the explanatory framework of what some historiography has called Nazi 'biopolitics'. Two laws (the Reich Citizenship Law and the Law for the Protection of German Blood and German Honour) established degrees of membership in the German national community, from which rights (and deprivations) were derived, based not on citizenship but on racial descent. Though we insist on the need to avoid determinisms, without exclusion from citizenship and the severely limited protection of individual rights this entailed, large groups of Third Reich victims would have experienced a different fate in the years following the enactment of these laws that flew in the face of liberal revolutionary tradition.

Entire narrative architectures have been constructed on the teleological succession of phases, such as those identified by Hannah Arendt (Identification/Exclusion/Plunder/Exploitation/Elimination), or the late identification of the explanatory elements of subsequent processes as if they

had already been thought of for the future. We know that this is not the case: contingencies matter and contexts change.

Determinism aside, identification of these points of no return is effective in the field of German segregation policies. The laws of 1935 sanctioned what were already common practices in Germany at the time. The Hereditary Health Tribunals – as many as two hundred of them – began functioning in 1933. They handed down verdicts that mandated the sterilization of up to 350,000 hereditary patients (schizophrenics, invalids, alcoholics) or even more radical practices, such as eugenic infanticide. There was a campaign to expel Jews from public life: from the civil service (except ex-combatants), universities (establishing a Jewish maximum of 1.5 per cent), public medicine, public baths and public spaces. Jewish-owned or -financed shops and businesses were marked. These practices were normativized in 1935 and multiplied exponentially; they also proved useful in occupation policies from 1939 onwards. Anti-Jewish propaganda, with an aesthetic pause for the 1938 Berlin Olympic Games, became suffocating. Religion became ethnicity and the Jewish people became the collective scapegoats for the defeat of 1918, the 1929 crisis, the Great Depression, the backwardness of the nation and its burdens. Their political identity, as complex as that of any other minority, was homogenized into a paste along with Bolshevism, the Second and Third Internationals and the enemies of the *Volk*. They were the most easily identifiable group within a wider hierarchy of supposed enemies that included Slavs and Gypsies. As the Second World War set in, they became the victims of German relocation and racial hierarchy policies. Physical elimination without recourse was reserved for this most hated group: the Jews.

Against the backdrop of the racial laws of 1935, the other point of no return on the road to extermination took place during the night of 9 November 1938. Using the assassination of the diplomat Ernst vom Rath in Paris as their excuse, Nazi leaders unleashed a pogrom (an organized massacre) throughout the country. Urged on by Goebbels, and heedless of the criticism and warnings of other Nazi leaders such as Himmler – who saw it as necessary but rather unmodern – party members destroyed 7,000 shops, burned 177 synagogues and beat to death some 100 Jews. Hitler himself also ordered mass arrests that night. Over the next few days, around 26,000 Jewish men were dragged off to Buchenwald, Dachau and Sachsenhausen. Jewish prisoners suddenly became the majority among

camp inmates and soon numbered around 50,000. Though Nazi leaders quickly cancelled the pogrom across Germany, its effects could be felt inside the camps for several weeks in the form of the unprecedented abuse, deprivation, torture, suicide and murder of Jewish prisoners. Hundreds of Jews died inside the concentration camps in late 1938, but in November of that year, the final objective of the Nazi leaders was not mass incarceration or murder of German Jews: it was to terrorize them into emigrating. This was why most Jewish prisoners were quickly released again, which marked them for life. Those who did not emigrate were subjected to increasingly asphyxiating regulatory frameworks.

Implementation of the Decree on the Elimination of the Jews from Economic Life prohibited Jews from economic activities, expelled Jewish children from schools, and created spaces of territorial control that effectively pushed Jewish populations into ghettos. The Central Office of Jewish Emigration was created under Adolf Eichmann in 1938; its explicit aim was to expel the Jewish population from German territory. Deportations and expulsions in the form of forced displacements were the task of the Reich Security Main Office (RSHA), under Reinhard Heydrich: an eerie prelude for one of the most important minds behind what is known as the Final Solution.

Identification, exclusion and expulsion: the initial phases of a process that combined sociopolitical intentionality with scientific and technological progress. Clearly there was systematic persecution prior to the Second World War and several hundred people died; but the goal was expulsion, not annihilation. Though significant, these numbers are nonetheless difficult to identify as the preface to the mass annihilation that occurred from 1941 to 1945 in the occupied territories, and from 1942 onwards in the extermination camps of Poland, in the frame of a war of total occupation and ethnic expansionism consistent with the vision of European races that had been deployed since peacetime. The latter was used to justify annexation of Austria in March 1938 and of the Sudetenland in September of that year, prior to occupation of Bohemia and the creation of the protectorate of the Slovak puppet state of Moravia.

On 1 September 1939 everything took on a new dimension and a new era opened for fascism. With the signing by Vyacheslav Molotov and Joachim von Ribbentrop of the Treaty of Non-Aggression between Germany and the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, the German

expansionist phase began with the invasion of Poland and did not stop until it reached the gates of Stalingrad. That day, which many would subsequently deem the worst day in history, the Second World War began.

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2

FASCISM AND WAR

What about Spain? Considering its war origin and subsequent transformations, its obvious differences and equally obvious similarities with the German and Italian regimes, can the term ‘fascism’ be applied to Spain? Can we call the Franco regime ‘fascist’? If so, from when? The questions seem pertinent: if the radical right in Spain today is branded as Francoist, it would help to know if being Francoist was, and is, a way of being fascist.

Before we begin to answer these questions, a brief explanation of terms is in order. As concepts go, defining the regime that emerged from the Spanish Civil War constitutes one of the longest, most prolific debates in Spanish historiography. Recent (and less recent) analyses have led to a re-evaluation of concepts such as fascism, parafascism or ‘fascistized’ to describe the founding years of Francoism during the Civil War and the post-war period, until 1945 (when European fascist regimes collapsed) or 1948 (when Spain emerged from the state of war that began in July 1936). Nonetheless, there is still generalized consensus – perhaps more conventional than scientific – about using the concept of Francoism to describe the historical period from 1939 to 1975. Does a history of the concept of Francoism and the nature of its power exist? What is it, and more importantly, what connotations does it carry?

These questions have fuelled one of the richest (and longest) debates between historians and political scientists regarding the Franco regime, beginning with the *coup d’état* against the Second Republic in July 1936, and especially from 1 October of that year. That was the Day of Exaltation of Francisco Franco as Head of Government and State, when his fellow members of the National Defence Committee appointed him as Supreme General of All Armies. In this long discussion about the past and its

denominations, and as befits a work of this nature, we openly acknowledge our unequivocal position among those who defend the use of the term 'fascism' to define the architecture of the Franco regime, at least until the end of the 1940s. However, we also recognize and situate elements foreign to the fascist political alternative, such as the scant doctrine generated by its leader or the internal conflict at its origin (the Italian regime and other fascisms ended in civil wars but did not begin with them). These aspects subjected the nascent Spanish New State to tensions and contradictions from which other regimes canonically accepted as fascist were clearly not exempt. So, who was not seen as fascist?

Having considered the various opinions and acknowledged the risk of simplification, it seems plausible to consider Francoism as the Spanish form of fascism, which grew – it could not be otherwise – in the space of political counter-revolution and, like its European counterparts, from a process of fascistization. In Spain this occurred in a context of total war and rearguard mobilization, converging into a Catholic, counter-revolutionary movement that expanded during a ('necessary', 'desired', 'glorious', 'triumphant') civil war to liquidate the elements deemed 'anti-Spain'.

In fact, the civil war facilitated Spanish fascism. The Germans, but especially the Italians, saw the Spanish conflict as an opportunity to help construct a 'brother regime' to add to their own combative, counter-revolutionary family. This context also acted as the hinge between colonial foreign aggressiveness and military interventionism in Europe. Only a few months after his African triumph and the proclamation of the fascist empire, Spain represented a chance for Mussolini to infuse foreign diplomacy with a new fascist policy founded on Italian power and no longer dependent on the great powers, which he had always demanded. In Spain a fundamental ally could be obtained in the Mediterranean at low cost and a potential enemy eliminated: the openly anti-fascist Republic of the Popular Front. From its inception, the Spanish Civil War was clearly the first great combat between revolution and counter-revolution, but also between fascism and anti-fascism.

Some historians argue that Francoism and the Franco regime was fascist in nature in its early period, during and after the Civil War: from 1936 until 1948–9. Like others, this theory combines work from multiple social, political, cultural and economic aspects of the Francoist past. The intent of the Civil War victors was not only the repression of adversaries, but the

construction of a national community defined by the radical exclusion of the vanquished: both as material persons and for what their individual and collective political experience represented. Despite the diverse political and cultural experiences that converged into a civil war, and Franco's leadership on 18 July 1936, the events of that day precipitated and amalgamated a fascism as heterogeneous and functional as those that developed in similar experiences on the continent.

Spanish fascism, organized as the Falange Española (FE) de las Juntas de Ofensiva Nacional-Sindicalista (JONS), was not the only predecessor of a broader national movement that took shape with its unification decree of 1937. It resulted from mass incorporation of the Spanish extreme right into this episode of the conflict: the radicalization of its projects, assimilation of totalitarian schemes, unprecedented practices for controlling the masses, military discipline in their own ranks and violent liquidation of the adversary, as argued by historian Ferran Gallego in *El evangelio fascista* (2014). Spanish fascism, including the warlord regime of its charismatic 'natural leader', can only be explained through the Civil War experience.

It seems significant, for example, that Mussolini himself identified Franco as the first and most prominent of Spanish fascists. Why? Because although Franco was not a dogmatist, theorist or devotee to fascism as a political religion, he understood better than anyone that all the traditional counter-revolutionary political forces would be needed to construct a fascist regime. No fascism came to power on its own strength; they all required alliances with economic elites, right-wing traditionalist parties and state institutions. These alliances were evident in Italian fascism and the National Socialist rise to power, despite the mythology about their revolutionary, autonomous natures. Il Duce recognized this when he wrote that Franco in 1937 was doing something similar with conservatism and traditionalism to what they had managed to do with the Popolari (Italian People's Party). It consisted of attracting them to the fascist pole by severely reducing the alternatives, then incorporating them into the fascist game under inferior conditions. Those parties had been included in government at first, but many of their members had already been assimilated into the PNF by 1925, when the Single Party was established, and all others were outlawed. In the performative context of the Civil War in Spain, political cultures converged in a political space. It was not identical to the Italian and German spaces,

nor radically different to the Croatian and Romanian expressions, but related to them by degrees of kinship.

The July 1936 *coup d'état* in Spain could certainly not be defined as fascist per se, but despite the rhetoric that had accompanied the March on Rome, there had never been a fascist *coup d'état* before 1936, so there was no model for comparison. Fascism is a phenomenon with much greater political, cultural and identitary complexity than the pretensions of the coup plotters, who gravitated around a group of military insurrectionists backed by a civilian political plot that included fascist groups and their acolytes. A fascist definition of insurrectionist Spain in 1936, and Spain under the power that emerged victorious in 1939, remains valid, though it was not the project the insurrectionist military explicitly envisioned. The *coup d'état* stretched out into a large-scale civil war based on eliminationist processes and rhetoric. The scale of the conflict served especially well as a frame for constructing a politically organized society around a single party and a charismatic leader, where power was constructed – and fascism is anchored in the practice of power – in ways coherent with the needs of the moment in which they were deployed.

The counter-revolution in Italy used ‘castor oil and the cudgel’ during peacetime in the 1920s. Germany in peacetime opted for preventative internment of the enemies of the nation. In Spain it was the cleansing of the nation: in the preventative, supra-individual violence of the summer and autumn of 1936, from the highest state officials to the last towns in the rearguard. In this way, Spanish fascism was the first that needed total war and violence to establish itself in power, compared with the ‘peacetime’ establishment of Italian and German fascisms. If there was an intrinsic element in the fascistization of insurgent Spain, a factor on which to construct and cement the homogeneous but not monolithic ultra-Catholic, violent, militaristic political identity of Spanish fascism, it was the massive, disproportionate, structural and prophylactic use of violence. This prerequisite for nation-building created loyalties and fears; it paralysed, congealed and destroyed.

Thus fascism in Spain does not refer exclusively to the Falange of José Antonio Primo de Rivera or the JONS of Ramiro Ledesma Ramos (the two fascist parties created before the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War), but above all to the Single Party, the FET–JONS, that was born in April 1937 and which is rarely counted as a mass fascist party in international fora. The

pre-eminence of the Falange in the insurgent ideological and political conglomerate, as well as its centrality in the regime's political architecture, can only be understood from its predisposition to kill and die. It was therefore based on a violent political culture that could facilitate armed seizure of local power. The participation of the Falange militias (and, in their territories of influence, the Traditionalist Communion) in the rebel army was more than significant from the earliest mobilization. It gave the insurgents a first-rate volunteer force and political influence in every sense. Manuel Hedilla (Secretary General of the Falange after the arrest of José Antonio Primo de Rivera) recalled how he led a vanguard force of 80,000 volunteers – with their own uniforms, quartermasters and services – under the FE and JONS banners in late 1936. There was an additional Second Line with more than 100,000 armed men in the rearguard. The fascist alternative, now guided by a fascist political party, grew and advanced throughout the second half of 1936. The FE–JONS alliance had received around 25,000 votes in February 1936. In April 1937 the re-founded Falange – with a new leader, new allies and a new context – became the Single Party in Spain. It presented itself as the main civilian force, an amalgamator of wills in service to the insurgent army, which saw the Falange as the armed branch of the counter-revolution that would vanquish the communist ogre and cleanse Spain. In the fascistization of the rearguard it became consolidated as a party of the masses, the first line of fascism that really existed, the *sine qua non* for participation in the civil sphere and for integrating the military sphere into power.

What explains the power of the Falange, then, when no single person or authority gave it the preponderance that made it the most important and influential political party among insurgent collaborators? First was its capacity for attraction, which surely had greater qualitative than quantitative relevance. Second was its willingness to take up arms, kill and die on the front or to gain territorial control of the rearguards, which at that time was crucial to achieving military objectives. The image of power it presented, perpetuated by propaganda and later by a surprisingly indulgent and admiring (or ignorant) historiography, should not overshadow the early difficulties of the insurgent army to juggle the war effort, human resources and control of the rearguard territories. In that space, the militarized civilian part of the rebellion flourished.

The pre-eminence of the Falange in the days of fighting for Spanish fascism – with the civilian plotting of the *coup d'état* and the weeks of practical implementation that followed ('cleansing' in the rearguard, imprisonments, assassinations) – catapulted the Falangists directly towards power and the highest state offices in early 1937. The Unification Decree of 19 April 1937 created the Single Party from the fusion of FE-JONS and the Traditionalist Communion (adding a 'T' to the acronym) and placed General Franco at its apex. The path had begun with the uprising (no other party, not even Renovación Española or CEDA (Confederación Española de Derechas Autónomas, the coalition of authoritarian Catholic right-wing parties created in 1933, which actually won the second legislative elections held in Spain during the Second Republic, although it did not come to power), had put so many combatants in the trenches), followed by the militarization of the militias in December 1936. It continued with the appointment of the 50 members of the FET-JONS National Council in October 1937: 25 Falangists, 8 military personnel, 5 monarchists and 12 Carlists. This formed the basis of the political and institutional architecture of the National Movement. More than a few historians have desired to see this as total control by the leader, the betrayal of fascist values, or the adoption of its aesthetics and symbols at most. Nonetheless it endured as the only party in Spain until its dissolution under the 1977 Law for Political Reform. Quite a success for such a failure.

More than one of them would have been truly proud of how things turned out in 1937. To construct their new political regime amid the unprecedented war mobilization of 1936–7, the insurgents looked most intently to the Italian model. They lacked their own political architecture and felt close to that fascist regime, but there were also practical advantages: Mussolini had sent aeroplanes to get Franco out of Africa and carry his army back to the Spanish mainland. Then, after an impasse in the conflict from November 1936 to February 1937, he reactivated support with the occupation of Málaga. In the end, Italy became a third belligerent in the Spanish Civil War by sending more than 75,000 men to Spain, more than twice the number of soldiers in the combined International Brigades. Il Duce used these endorsements as a way of asserting his own territorial claims in the Balearic Islands, but his main desire was to influence the political and institutional architecture of the nascent regime. He certainly accomplished that.

What else would explain why Mussolini personally congratulated Franco on the unification of parties and the creation of the FET–JONS under his command in 1937? Or his prediction that the New Spain would rest on the foundations of the Single Party, the unified militia and the single labour union? Some would attribute to Il Duce a degree of opportunism equivalent to his gift as a failed visionary – he did not foresee his own death in April 1945 – but he was right in the end. The Spain that emerged from the Civil War indeed rested on those foundations (and others, as we shall see). Falangism was not a purely revolutionary ‘Jose Antonio’ (Primo de Rivera) style of fascism opposed to Francoist state structures. Rather, it integrated naturally into the top-down political apparatus of the new regime and became its political–administrative transmission line throughout the territory.

Mussolini argued that there had been three contemporary revolutions: the American liberal, the Asian socialist and fascism, the last the only properly European one. This point needs emphasizing: on the one hand, the very founders of fascism as a political phenomenon and a revolution that would mark an entire era, as that of 1789 had done, believed that fascism had to be first and foremost agglutinating. It was a binding agent that united all counter-revolutionary forces to save the nation, the people and the civilization that constituted their historical tradition. They did not see fascism as the expression of an exclusive, violent, insignificant, minority (at first) political faction that rose to power in a facilitating context (royal co-opting in Italy, election amid an unprecedented crisis of legitimacy in Germany, internal war in Spain, foreign occupation in Croatia). Rather it was all the counter-revolutionary forces condensed and united by a single superior ideal, fused into a mobilizing magma that would configure party, state and leader into a new state.

It is helpful to recall that the first Falangists saw themselves as fascist, vanguard revolutionaries. They rapidly got hooked on power amid the counter-revolution and construction of the New State, precipitated by the July 1936 *coup d'état* that had unleashed a civil war: fast and mobile at first, then long and drawn-out, with stable fronts. None of the old guard were missing in the new structure. This included the ‘Old Shirt’ and Secretary General of the party Raimundo Fernández Cuesta, who arrived in the Francoist zone. There was also Pilar Primo de Rivera, who was appointed National Delegate of the Women’s Section and was the sister of

the party founder (by then referred to as *el Ausente*, the Absent One), along with Mercedes Sanz-Bachiller, the widow of Onésimo Redondo, the JONS leader of Castile. Some of these, like Dionisio Ridruejo, would later hypocritically number themselves among the vanquished and present themselves as anti-Francoist democrats. In the beginning, however, they all integrated smoothly and virtually without critique into the new leadership roles described in the organigram that would channel political and social representation in Spain until 1977.

Were other cultures, traditions and political families represented in the National Movement? Of course they were, because there was no political representation outside of it, no belonging to the state institutional architecture, though the capacity for political agency from within was severely limited. Rhetorically, at least, the National Movement represented the communion of the Spanish people, the victorious community, organized into the Single Party, the Vertical Trade Union, and party structures such as the Women's Section, the Youth Front, the University Student's Union and the Union Organization for Education and Recreation. The last of these was a translation of the Italian National Afterwork Club (OND). The first Spanish fundamental law, the Labour Charter, took inspiration from the Italian Carta del Lavoro and contained the fundamental principles of traditionalist social Catholicism. Rhetorical contradictions notwithstanding, the founders and theorists of the fascist National Movement in Spain insisted on a deeply religious, markedly Catholic Spanish fascism.

Rather than an exclusive exception, war appears in recent revisions as central to the construction of the regime that we believe can be called fascist without too many prefixes or suffixes, at least until the late 1940s. Though often presented as a lack of fascism, the Civil War can also be interpreted as the culmination of a constructive process. There, part of the military (without a divided military there would have been no war), the Church, the reactionary right-wing elite and the popular masses fused and openly collaborated in a nation-building project. However, the presence of the masses among the drivers of Spanish fascism has been notably marginalized in the historiography on the Republic and the Civil War. The Falange was active in the political construction of the rearguard and in disseminating patriotic propaganda, deploying a rhetoric of integration alongside political and social cleansing of the rearguard. The Single Party organized a complex network of information and denouncement, rhetorical

inclusion and social exclusion. In Spanish fascism, the enemy first had to be purified, then integrated. 'The Red mass that was not destroyed' had to be integrated, affirmed Franco's brother-in-law and minister Ramón Serrano Súñer in April 1940. The 'Red mass' waited in the laboratories of the New Spain: the prisons and concentration camps. There, direct and indirect propaganda and patriotic conferences devised by the Single Party's Office for Propaganda on the Fronts included lecture series on social and moral education for prisoners and detainees in a form of mass brainwashing (unsuccessful in most cases, we have learned).

A different power-constructing framework led to the application of violent, repressive policies generated for that context and that purpose. As we have seen, fascist regimes had a common nature, convergent aspirations and a political matrix that included violence as a significant element of a higher project of radical social, cultural and human restructuring. This was the case in Italy and Germany, then later in Hungary, Romania and Croatia. In Spain, the Civil War context expanded and accelerated the dimensions, times, forms and possibilities of fascist violence. Spain was a test field for fascistization through combined mobilization, collaboration and exclusion, but Europe was the definitive, most brutal subsequent scenario. Europe would finally and forcefully reveal what fascism was all about: what Mussolini meant by a state of permanent war; what Hitler meant when he predicted the end of the Semitic race; where the journeys that began in 1922 and 1933 would take them.

Rise and fall

War and fascism, fascism and war. These inseparable concepts give the measure in numbers and lives of what fascism was in Europe: rhetorically, theoretically and practically. The fascist regimes entered full force into the new frame initiated in 1939 with the German–Soviet invasion of Poland and European declarations of hostilities. The continental war expanded into a world war and a scenario for the globalization of fascism in regimes of occupation, collaboration and colonization. Then, after several months of 'pretend war' without military movements, 1940 became the year of The Great Occupation. The Germans did not encounter fierce resistance. In Poland, occupation operations lasted 36 days; Denmark surrendered within 24 hours and without resistance in April 1940; Norway fell after two

months of fighting. In May, the Netherlands was occupied in four days, Belgium held out for nineteen, and neither had declared war. France was brought to its knees after 46 days; Yugoslavia surrendered after 12. Mainland Greece withstood the onslaught for 24 days, and Crete held out another month thanks to the British contingent on the island. All these military successes cost the Germans fewer than 100,000 military casualties.

The map of Europe changed radically in 1940. In June, Italy moved from pre-belligerence to full intervention when it attacked the French city of Nice . . . and failed (providing a glimpse of future military performance). The fascist continent was unfolding at last. In ten months, Hitler accomplished what none of his predecessors ever had when he set foot in Paris on 14 June (German troops arrived in Paris on that day; Hitler on 23 June): he had subdued the continent. In a way, Germany was fulfilling the manifest destiny that it had been denied in 1918. It had lost the First World War, but in 1940 Hitler brought France to its knees. The agreements and status quo from after the First World War broke down; antisemitic policies already active in Germany were deployed on a large scale as Germany projected its theory of living space and colonization, something it had been demanding since 1933. The north of France was occupied directly, and a like-minded regime was imposed in Vichy under Marshal Pétain, a hero of the First World War who turned traitor during the Second World War.

The seemingly unstoppable German push was only opposed by the United Kingdom, which had recovered its expeditionary corps at Dunkirk (about 400,000 men) and opted for national mobilization and resistance at any cost: blood, sweat, tears and more than 50,000 civilians killed in bombardments. Elsewhere Hitler met no opposition in the Balkans, and Greece fell in the spring of 1941. Yugoslavia disappeared with the creation of the collaborationist Serbian state and the imposition of fascist power in Croatia, with Ante Pavelić at the head of the Ustaše movement. Europe became fascist, occupied or collaborationist in under eighteen months, but the German military machine was not unstoppable.

The diversification of war theatres made it difficult to sustain the aggressive thrust in Europe, Africa and then Asia from June 1941 onwards. Operation Barbarossa brought the German army within 50 kilometres (31 mi.) of Moscow in September and led to the occupation of territory in modern-day Ukraine in October. It had to find formulas for rearguard control that would keep the internal fronts as calm as possible. With its

aggression against the Soviet Union in 1941, Nazi Germany sent more than 3.5 million soldiers east, so they were no longer available to maintain control in the rearguards. This was one of the purely pragmatic reasons for setting up occupation and collaboration regimes. The Reich, which included Austria, deployed a tiered centre-to-periphery occupation system. Although it did not scrupulously follow the notion devised by Werner Best, jurist and plenipotentiary commissioner in Denmark, it did establish de facto colonial protectorate annexation zones (Protectorate of Bohemia and Moravia; General Government in Poland; Reich Commissariats in Ukraine, Ostland, Norway and the Netherlands), occupation regimes and zones (Belgium, Northern France, Occupied France, Serbia and Greece) and a fringe of collaborationist regimes that were heavily dependent on the Reich (Slovakia, Croatia, Vichy France, Italy after 8 September 1943 and Hungary from October 1944 onwards).

In his book *Colaboracionistas* (2022), historian David Alegre observes that Nazi Germany often used the counter-revolutionary traditions of an invaded country to build its occupation and collaboration regimes there. However, it relied on the forces that could guarantee the greatest stability and security in the rearguard rather than those most clearly aligned with National Socialism. As Alegre so aptly points out, Nazi occupation regimes in Europe reflected a mixture of strategic, biological-racial and purely pragmatic considerations. The rule of Miklós Horthy in Hungary, from 1920 to 1944, for example, created an authoritarian and counter-revolutionary state from which Ferenc Szálasi's Arrow Cross Party emerged in 1939. A carbon copy of the NSDAP, it was only in power from October 1944 to January 1945. In the Slovak Republic, the priest Jozef Tiso – an open admirer of Franco and ally of Hitler – combined control of the Hlinka single party with the pro-totalitarian tendencies of his ministers. In Belgium, the collaborationist regime was deployed from the openly pro-Nazi Rexist movement, rooted primarily in French-speaking Wallonia, and the state quickly became fascist. In the Netherlands and Norway, the job fell to Anton Mussert's National Socialist Movement (NSB) and to Vidkun Quisling's Nasjonal Samling, respectively. Despite how much Vichy France under Marshal Pétain (until its occupation) desired to present itself as the French shield against fascism, its National Revolution included fascist elements such as Jacques Doriot's French Popular Party and Marcel Déat's National People's Union. In the same way, fascist movements joined

Salazar's National Union in neutral, pro-Allies Portugal. A totalitarian concept of society expanded in the Independent State of Croatia (NDH) with Ante Pavelić at the head of the single party, which became the Ustaše national movement, as studied by Rory Yeomans, Alexander Korb, Mark Biondich and others. Their power was all-encompassing and their reign of terror indisputable (despite the territorial sovereignty dispute in the context of the internal war against the communist militias, on the one hand, and at times against the pan-Serbian militias, the Chetniks, on the other). The total social cleansing deployed by Croatian fascism against national, religious and ethnic minorities even led to the opening of a concentration camp in Jasenovac, which rivalled the Aktion Reinhard extermination camps in its homicidal function and eliminationist vocation.

All of this suggests that if there was an element that historically combined the heterogeneous elements of fascism and gave content to fascist violence for the regeneration of the nation and the community through separation, exclusion or elimination of its scapegoats and the fascistization of the state, it was the context of war. War was the *sine qua non* for the rise of fascism after the First World War and in the late 1930s and early '40s, when Spain, Romania, Croatia and France were fascistized and the most extreme social projects of Italy or Germany became radicalized and propositional. In this process, collaborationists became the main target for national resistance movements, thus creating small-scale civil war scenarios between fascism and anti-fascism (or a large-scale one in Italy during the Social Republic).

War was thus the necessary step for unleashing the full potential of fascism. The occupation launched in 1940 was intended to place Europe in a racial hierarchy and subject it to slave labour, at the feet of Germany and fascism. The context concentrated the terror and then extended it, with the help of Heydrich's Reich Security Main Office (RSHA), to many more suspicious Germans and thousands of foreigners, nationals from belligerent countries and prisoners of war (Czechs, Poles, Spaniards). Both useful and normalized, these war scenarios gradually became spaces for the most brutal exploitation, plunder or simple elimination of undesirables. Russian prisoners were murdered in 1941 and 1942 under the mantle of the Aktion 14f13 and 14f14 programmes. Partisans interned in the Natzweiler-Struthof (and others) eventually disappeared under cover of the Night and Fog Decree issued by Hitler. The cumulative terror gave rise to total

exploitation, and a boom in forced labour occurred in tandem with the increased economic needs of a nation at war, as shown by historians such as Christian Gerlach in his *The Extermination of the European Jews* (2016) as well as Götz Aly and Susanne Heim (*Architects of Annihilation* (2003)). Private sector companies such as IG Farben, Krupp, Siemens and Daimler-Benz joined the state-owned slave enterprise. Germany seemed unstoppable, with the entire continent under its boot and the entire German population affected by its exponential expansion of power. The Axis powers, with Hitler at the head, ruled the world until the end of 1942.

Military setbacks began with the failed 872-day siege of Leningrad and the Soviet defence of Stalingrad, where around 700,000 Axis soldiers and about 1.7 million Russians (a minimum of 1 million soldiers and 40,000 civilians) died between August 1942 and January 1943. In November 1942 U.S. forces landed in North Africa and the Wehrmacht responded by invading Vichy France. From that point on, German rearguard cleansing policies became radicalized and generalized: villages were destroyed in mainland Greece in retaliation for resistance activities; hostages were murdered in Italy; the first concentration camps were constructed in the Baltic countries in the summer of 1943. All this was consistent with what fascism represented: a counter-revolutionary, violent, expansionist, welfare-style utopia. A force so radical and extreme could only be fought with its own weapons: the most radical violence, the murder of civilians, the bombing of rearguard populations in a total war of extreme mobilization and mass conscription. In these last areas, however, the Soviet Union had the numerical advantage, with a population of around 180 million people and a Red Army of nearly 30 million men.

The confrontation of these empires of terror, combined with Soviet advances through the Caucasus, Crimea, Romania and later Hungary, Austria and Czechoslovakia, spread German resources thin just as the war became completely globalized (with the entry of the United States in December 1941). With the U.S. push, new fronts opened in North Africa, Sicily and Normandy (250,000 Allied soldiers and 400,000 German soldiers killed), forcing the Germans to gradually retreat. Paris was liberated on 25 August 1944. Meanwhile in Italy, it was clear things would not last forever. Mussolinian fascism held out as the Italian Social Republic from 1943 to 1945, shielded by its alliance with Germany but in a new frame of civil war, armed anti-fascism, political radicalization and no monarchy. Mussolini had

been deposed by the Fascist Grand Council and the new government of Marshal Pietro Badoglio had asked the Allies for an armistice. But the Germans moved to rescue their old ally and claimed territorial sovereignty over Italy, effective in the northern territories, with the city of Salò as the capital. This led fascism to a civil war in which Italy was defending itself from Allied occupation with the help of its German occupiers. So, after twenty years of power, Italian fascism ended in civil war. Perhaps it could not have been otherwise.

With the fall of Berlin in April 1945, fascism was defeated on all fronts. The Italian internal war between fascism and anti-fascism, between the Italian Social Republic and the partisans, supported by the U.S. Army, came to an end. Milan was liberated on 25 April, still a national holiday in Italy to this day. Mussolini was shot dead after being captured near Lake Como as he tried to flee Italy. Hitler committed suicide in his bunker on 30 April. Germany capitulated on 2 May, then declared total surrender on 8 May. In the Pacific, the war continued through late August: atomic bombs were dropped on Japan (the Hiroshima detonation produced a temperature of 1 million degrees Celsius at its centre and was the cause of 70,000 deaths), marking the most brutal of all possible endings to Axis imperialism and aggression. The most conservative estimates indicate that more than 55 million people died or disappeared from 1939 to 1945.

In those years, the fascist project – safeguarding the national community, expansionism, colonialism and racial war – reached unimaginable heights. The systematic looting of defeated enemies that accompanied it was consistent with fascist, pro-welfare, populist zeal. According to Götz Aly in *Final Solution: Nazi Population Policy and the Murder of the European Jews* (1999), this full-scale, far-reaching, predatory racial war fostered unprecedented equality and social progress in Germany. To maintain the economic status of the National Socialist utopia, with its racial relocation, territorial expansion and other factors, the Third Reich eventually opted for large-scale population extermination. The German people were the immediate, sumptuous, economic beneficiaries of racial relocation, colonization, population substitution and genocide in Europe. Money laundering, dispossession, bloodshed and expropriation to bolster the military budget – not to be documented under any circumstances – were the norm in France, Belgium, Holland, Italy, Serbia, Hungary, the former

Czechoslovakia, Bulgaria, Romania, Greece and especially in the 'supplementary' East.

The costs of the occupation were very high and much of the war budget was extracted – in taxes, social contributions and labour exploitation – from those sent to Germany as prisoners of war and forced labourers. In fact, the elimination of hundreds of thousands of Soviet prisoners of war was a central dynamic of Third Reich extermination practices: over 3.3 million were taken prisoner but only 930,000 survived. War scarcity mainly affected the populations of occupied countries, prisoners of war and persecuted minorities. Genocide significantly impacted the German economy by increasing the supply of consumer goods while decreasing demand, as owners and buyers disappeared in the gas chambers. And while the income from de-Judaizing Europe was modest, the plunder was enormously useful. From 1940 onwards, 50 per cent of the wages of Jewish forced labourers went into state coffers to be used for weapons manufacture and public subsidies for German women and children. During the Second World War, more than two-thirds of German war revenues came from the exploitation of foreign resources and people considered racially inferior. This dual discrimination of race and class allowed most Germans to enjoy a good situation and pretend to be oblivious to the criminal source of their well-being for a long time.

Aftermath: an atrocious epilogue to the fascist utopia

Fascism ended amid piles of burning corpses, except in regimes like Spain that managed to evade military occupation and defascistize their political projects. Only a few months earlier, the occupiers and the occupied, the founders and the collaborators, had taken their utopia of racial cleansing, community health, exploitation, profit and well-being to its extreme. This 'perfect' process was preconceived, determined and executed with precision, coldness, malice, ambition and efficiency. There is a rather widespread tendency to imagine that the deportation and extermination of the Jewish people, along with Roma, Slavs and other minorities, could hardly have existed on the scale that is usually presented; however, the extermination of Jews in Europe was ambitious in its approach and indisputably efficient in its results. The research of Omer Bartov indicates that the Jewish minority was erased in Poland, Belarus and Ukraine.

Though the process was indeed effective, it does not automatically imply a master plan that lacked nuance, variation or adaptation. In fact, what we know as the Holocaust was not an event but a complex, botched, chaotic process of adaptation, trial and error. A sensory map of Auschwitz, such as the one requested by the German historian Nikolaus Wachsmann for *KL: A History of the Nazi Concentration Camps* (2012), could help us understand the improvisation and imperfection of the death camps. Today we can talk about them, write about them, even build artistic performances based on them, but we must not fall into aestheticization. The death camps – or those like Auschwitz which combined internment, labour and elimination – were a stench of human waste, death, urine, burned and rotting flesh, bodies in decomposition. Words cannot begin to describe what was seen, smelled, touched or heard by those who spent hours, days and weeks in the six great German death camps in Poland (Auschwitz II-Birkenau, Sobibor, Treblinka, Belzec, Majdanek, Chelmno). This was the great battle of writers Jorge Semprún, Primo Levi and Shlomo Venezia: a battle for representation that was lost before it started.

The extermination camps resulted from the trial and error that accompanied the invasion of the Eastern European territories from 1941 onwards. Practices ranged from direct and dirty Einsatzgruppen (occupation task force) annihilation methods to mobile extermination units, to the eventual development of industrial gas chambers. During the war of occupation, the Central Office for Jewish Affairs, Race and Resettlement had to instruct and train the Einsatzgruppen in racial and biological questions of language or physiognomy in the four great areas into which the East had been divided for rearguard control and the persecution of Bolshevism, partisans and Judaism: the ontological enemy of the German race and the national community. However, the linguistic, cultural and ethnological complexities of territories such as the Caucasus eventually far exceeded their projections. In its European conquests of 1939–40, Germany did not have to enter unknown territories. It shared culture, education, history and sometimes language with the occupied nations. What began in June 1941 was unprecedented massacre. In 1941–2, around 12,000 SS members, trained in anti-partisan, anti-Jewish persecution, implemented the ‘local’ phase of the genocide. Estimates indicate that 63,000 people were executed in the first five weeks of occupation; up to a million were killed in the first year and 400,000 more in the second year.

At this time, measures were adopted to assist the supreme task entrusted to the Wehrmacht and the SS: the creation of a safe and secure living space for the German nation. The famous Commissar Order of 6 June 1941 established the disciplinary framework for the elimination of Bolshevik Jews. Meanwhile under the Aktion T4 programme, August Becker and RSHA specialists such as Albert Widmann and Arthur Nebe were experimenting with the use of prussic gas to eliminate residents in psychiatric hospitals and free up beds for the wounded from the front lines. The programme facilitated the murderous euthanasia of approximately 70,000 infirm individuals and 6,000 prisoners of war. In 1941 soldiers began connecting the exhaust pipes to the inside of vans used to move people (women and children) between ghettos, and later between the Chelmno and Belzec extermination camps. Around 350,000 were annihilated in transit between ghettos, more than all the civilian rearguard victims of the Spanish Civil War. In July 1941, in what would become Auschwitz-I, Aktion T4 technicians began experimenting with Zyklon B gas – to eliminate not Jews but Soviet prisoners of war.

With the growing problem of public order and sanitation in the overcrowded ghettos, the need arose to organize alternatives to direct and costly elimination, and the equally weighty moral implications of killing non-combatants, women and children. To address this and to establish elimination criteria, representatives of the National Socialist elite met in Wannsee on 20 January 1942. Reinhard Heydrich and Adolf Eichmann summoned officials from the Interior, Justice and Foreign Ministries, Occupied Territories, the NSDAP and the RSHA to rigorously study the real numbers, precepts and objectives for their Final Solution to the Jewish Question in Europe. They based this on a mandatory, *sine qua non* order from Hitler (though they left no written record). The plan they eventually settled on anticipated the annihilation of around 10 million individuals.

From then on, an accelerated process began to eliminate the rejects, the unnecessary ones. In the Majdanek camp, converted to a death camp in February 1942, some 30,000 people from the Lublin ghetto (in the occupied zone) and 40,000 from the territories controlled by Hans Frank's General Government were gassed in one month. In July 1942, up to seven gas chambers were in use, as all European Jews were being sent to Majdanek and Auschwitz. Sobibor had been inaugurated in May, with motorized gas chambers and no crematorium: corpses were thrown into pits or cremation

ditches. Treblinka had also opened, with its three motorized gas chambers. The Wannsee plan instructed the emptying of Jewish ghettos into specific camps: Chelmno for the Lodz ghetto, Treblinka for the Warsaw ghetto, Belzec for the Galicia ghetto, Majdanek for the Lublin ghetto, and the southernmost Auschwitz II-Birkenau was for Jews deported from France, Italy, Czechoslovakia, Hungary or the Balkans. By July 1943 the four camps assigned to specific ghettos had successfully completed their function and were then gradually abandoned. In 1944 Auschwitz and Majdanek remained active as extermination camps for deported Hungarian Jews, but extermination was not confined to the camps. In 1942 it was extended to prisoners, civilians from occupied countries, political prisoners and enslaved Jews selected through Oswald Pohl's Central Office of Economics and Administration. In the second half of 1942, Reich Minister of Justice Otto Georg Thierack agreed to the plan to work political and asocial prisoners to death in Nazi prisons. Heinrich Himmler acknowledged it in his famous Posen speech to a select audience of sixty *Gauleiters*, *Reichsleiters*, businessmen, senior civil officials and SS officers in October 1943. He presented it as a painful but necessary process to preserve Germany's greatness and control of Europe. It remains as one of the few existing records of the eliminationist will of the Third Reich. But that greater Germany would soon come crashing to earth, dragging with it the remains of the social utopia its extermination camps represented. As the camps were hastily emptied in 1944–5, interns and guards set out on foot for Germany. Hundreds of thousands of sick men and women fell on the way, unable to continue the forced evacuations known today as the 'death marches'.

Jews, the unwell, Gypsies, homosexuals, communists, prisoners of war: the key to genocide lies in the perpetrator's extreme simplification of the complex life and identity of the victims. Then those lives can be terminated, not because of who they are but because of what they are. This subtle difference contains the key to reading the Holocaust and other mass crimes of the twentieth century. Those who died in the gas chambers were not only Jews: they were also Hungarians, Russians, Poles, Belarusians, Italians, Estonians and the French. They were also communists, partisans, women, children, old, sick or unfit for work. But their multifarious executioners saw them as interchangeable, depersonalized pieces of a colossal, supra-individual victim . . . and treated them accordingly.

Social utopia required such efforts. But every person killed for the greatness of the German national community had a father, mother, brothers and sisters, sons, daughters, loves, heartbreaks, pains, aspirations, sufferings and longings. All this was lost in campaigns of hierarchy, annihilation and racial and political cleansing. The rejects. The great historian Saul Friedländer recounts in *The Years of Extermination* (2007) that as Hitler celebrated his last birthday in the Berlin bunker, and the Reich was disintegrating under bombs, a score of children aged five to twelve were murdered after having endured a year of medical experiments. Such was the desire for thoroughness: no traces, no loose ends, no future. At least 1.5 million Jewish victims of the Third Reich were under the age of fourteen.

It is impossible to comprehend even a fragment of such enormous loss, so it is time to honestly acknowledge defeat: we can only approach the edges of this abyss of horror, the density and nature of the gigantic black hole that swallowed up all who entered Auschwitz. In our opinion, this is best done by paying tribute to the victims but also by analysing – repulsive as it may seem to us – the logic of the executioners along with the contexts and processes that led millions of people to accept these deaths as necessary, or at least tolerable. The challenge is colossal, but we must try; and we must not remain indifferent to the spurious use of the ideas, categories and names that nourished these utopias. To deny that the populist radical right is fascist does not whitewash the latter; but to say that it is whitewashes fascism, its effects and its legacy. It may even express a degree of contempt for its victims. Fascism was a specific, collective utopian movement that generated the greatest regime of terror, the highest death rates not related to natural causes or disease, and the highest rates of intentional direct and indirect violent death in human history. It denied representation, democracy and minority rights; in its most extreme forms it expelled, displaced or annihilated their representatives. It left a most poisonous, pestilential legacy in the second half of the twentieth century.

3

FROM FASCISM TO THE FAR RIGHT

Condemnation of fascist regimes was the basis for the construction of European democracies after 1945 in processes that were not at all predetermined. As Martin Conway explained in *Western Europe's Democratic Age, 1945–1968* (2020), the transition from fascist to democratic regimes might not have occurred. Europe was not waiting for a natural return to democracy after years of dictatorships and violence. In fact, European post-war processes were full of paradox and fundamentally contradictory. On the one hand, the states that emerged from the war began to rebuild on the premise of preventing communist infiltration. This enabled the political and military cadres of the defeated regimes to integrate into the new structures, leading to especially incongruous out-comes. The Austrian Kurt Waldheim, for example, despite his Nazi past, went on to become Secretary-General of the UN (1972–81) and president of his country (1986–92). On the other hand, anti-fascism became the founding myth of revived Western European nations. Marco Tarchi – nephew of Angelo Tarchi, Minister of Corporate Economy during the Italian Social Republic and member of the Italian Social Movement in his youth – wrote in 1995 how this effectively made former fascists *esuli in patria*: exiles in their own country.

Most Europeans who had supported fascist regimes, or opportunistically collaborated with them, adapted to their new contexts by becoming apolitical or working from within the new democratic systems. However, a handful of fascists remained loyal to the cause and began acting in the margins of emerging societies. They defended undemocratic, corporatist representation criteria and idealized the regimes defeated in the war. In these circles, Axis war crimes were relativized, the Holocaust denied and Allied ‘war crimes’ denounced in the name of ‘historical revisionism’. They

formed groups, such as the St Martin Fund in Belgium or the Mutual Aid Society of Former Waffen-SS members (HIAG) in Germany, to provide support for ex-combatants on the Eastern Front and their families. These neo-fascists sought to remain politically active in an openly hostile political and legal climate. Social support was scarce, and they suffered significant repression. For example, the Socialist Reich Party (SRP) of Germany was banned in 1952, followed by the National European Social Movement of the Netherlands in 1955. On the rare occasions when they stood for office, they obtained nowhere near the vote thresholds needed for parliamentary representation. Though they were neo-fascists, there was little about them that qualified as new. Nostalgia was their main feature and they generally acted in the frame of associations and camaraderie groups that supported the fascist 'martyrs'.

Broadly speaking, the neo-fascists followed two paths. Some of them formed clandestine terrorist organizations, such as the Fasces of Revolutionary Action (FAR), created in January 1946 by Giorgio Almirante, Clemente Graziani, Julius Evola, Pino Rauti and Pino Romualdi. This explicitly anti-democratic, revolutionary organization committed several attacks against partisan organizations, leftists and unions in its early years. In 1951 some of its leaders were tried and acquitted. Meanwhile, other neo-fascists had come out of hiding in the reconciliation that was promoted after the civil war in Italy. They formed the Italian Social Movement (MSI) in December 1946. Many of its founders and members, including Almirante and Romualdi, had been in the FAR.

It was young people who founded the MSI and carried on the legacy of the Republic of Saló, the last incarnation of the Italian fascist state. The MSI struggled to survive and build support networks for its members, many of whom were incarcerated for crimes committed prior to 1945. Under the leadership of Giorgio Almirante, a former official of the fascist government, the MSI managed to enter the Italian Parliament in 1948, though fascist activities had been suppressed under the new constitution through the Scelba Law. The MSI presented a radical, anti-capitalist discourse of clear ideological proximity to Nazism. It won six seats that year, and the MSI had continuous parliamentary representation until its transformation into the National Alliance in 1994. It even gave parliamentary support to the short-lived Tambroni government of 1960. Ferran Gallego has argued that the MSI was in a cultural no-man's land that expressed the ambivalence of the post-

war far right, where conservatives, radicals, nostalgics and revanchists coexisted. Oscillating perpetually between past and future, it sought to remain loyal to the fascist tradition yet make it coincide with the Europe under construction from the 1950s onwards. 'Nostalgia dell'avvenire' read the posters for a regional elections rally in the early 1970s, as Giorgio Almirante proclaimed: 'We are nostalgic for the future.' The MSI was the only mass party to vindicate Mussolini's regime after his death. This distinguishing element made it a reference for like-minded groups in Europe.

To escape marginalization in their countries of origin, some neo-fascist leaders attempted to articulate an international network. Building on the success of the MSI, the European Social Movement was founded in Malmö, Sweden, in 1951 with the aim of developing a corporatist, anti-communist empire in Europe. The platforms of the founding parties – the MSI, Oswald Mosley's Union Movement and the Socialist Reich Party – were closely linked to basic fascist tenets such as antisemitism and racism. In the context of decolonization, this translated into white supremacism. However, despite the support of most of its important leaders, the network never attained more than a marginal presence. Many of its members found the new movement insufficiently racist or radical, and by 1957 it was failing.

In France, neo-fascist groups played a much more marginal role. Public condemnation of the Vichy regime had left them very little space, and accusations of collaborationism and treason limited their development. The violent group Jeune Nation, formed in 1949, reflected a vision much closer to Italian fascism than to Nazism.

In fact, openly neo-fascist groups remained marginal in Europe, except for Italy. A revival of far-right populism took place in the mid-1950s when various populist parties and movements emerged, defining themselves as openly opposed to the post-war elites. Though some of these groups had former fascist party members, they distanced themselves socially and ideologically from neo-fascism. They protested post-war living conditions and especially the marginalization of the rural peripheries in the early development of the welfare state. These populist movements contained some embryonic features of the post-industrial far right of the 1980s and '90s: outcry against the elites, an appeal to a 'wholesome people', vindication of 'those below' against 'those above' in the face of economic malaise, and a focus on 'anti-politics' that denounced professional

politicians and their institutions. However, these movements were oriented much more towards the past than the future, which differentiated them from movements that would develop towards the end of the century.

During the 1940s some 'parties against all parties' emerged, such as the National Agricultural Party in Ireland or the Common Man's Front in Italy. The latter, founded by the journalist Guglielmo Giannini in late 1946, gained prominence through its widely circulated weekly, *L'Uomo Qualunque*. With a discourse centred on harsh criticism of the state, taxation and democracy, it denounced the 'excesses' of the purge of fascism. The party gained the sympathies of pro-fascist voters, who gave them more than a million votes in the 1946 elections. After winning the corresponding thirty seats, the formation rapidly declined and most of its supporters ended up joining the MSI. Its vindication of the 'common man' and its critique of politics and parties in the name of 'honesty' and practicality echo in radical-right approaches today.

Though manifest in several European countries, far-right populism became a central phenomenon of post-war politics in France. The most relevant formation to emerge from this populist movement, born on the battlefields, was the Union for the Defense of Tradesmen and Artisans in 1953. Pierre Poujade, its leader and a bookseller-stationer from the Saint-Céré commune, gave the movement its name. Poujade had family roots in integral nationalism (his father was an architect and member of Action Française). He had been a youth member of the fascist French Popular Party and the Pétainist youth organization Comrades of France. But he had not been a collaborator: he had left France after the Nazi occupation in 1942 and joined the French resistance in Algeria.

'Poujadism' was characterized as a cult to its leader and by its strident anti-parliamentarism. It reflected the angst of the middle classes, faced with post-war social and economic changes and increasing tax burdens stemming from colonial conflicts. The group presented itself as apolitical, without ideologies and systematically opposed to everything. This allowed it to gain transversal sympathies: from those nostalgic for fascism to those collaborating to defend French Algeria, to young extremists such as Jean-Marie Le Pen. It soon became a mass movement, with about 400,000 members by 1955. The French Union and Brotherhood candidacy won more than 2.7 million votes (12.62 per cent of the electorate) in the legislative elections of January of the following year, which translated into

52 seats. One of them was held by Jean-Marie Le Pen, who at the age of twenty-seven became France's youngest deputy. His granddaughter, Marion Maréchal Le Pen, would repeat this landmark achievement in 2012.

However, autocratic leadership and lack of internal cohesion hindered development, and soon a rift occurred between Poujade and Le Pen. Poujade wanted to keep the movement apolitical, but Le Pen was already thinking about creating a pole for regrouping the far right and capitalizing on discontent over the colonial wars. With the founding of the Fifth Republic in 1958, the Poujadists disappeared as quickly as they had emerged, but their legacy was foundational to the renewal of the French far right.

French populism and the Italian MSI opened doors to crosspollination and hybridization among nostalgic, post-war, neo-fascist movements and to new ideas that would shape the radical right going forward. One of the clearest expressions of this process was the National Democratic Party of Germany, founded by former Nazi leaders in 1964. It focused on immigration from outside Europe, which would be a central issue of the late twentieth century. The British National Front also made an impact in the late 1970s with an openly racist discourse and the slogan 'Make Britain Great Again' (which made a dramatic comeback across the Atlantic in 2016). Its proposals aligned with those of George Wallace, Governor of Alabama and a candidate in the 1968 U.S. presidential elections. Wallace managed to win five southern (formerly Confederate) states with a discourse that defended racial segregation.

In the mid-1950s, a new generation emerged in several European countries that understood the need to renew the ideas and organizations that had expressed continuity with the interwar period. Many in these groups considered that fascist memory should no longer be denied but be recovered in a fresh way that freed it from its anchors in the past and transformed it into a source of far-right regeneration. In 1956, the most radical sectors of the MSI, led by Pino Rauti, left the movement and founded the Ordine Nuovo Study Centre. They accused the MSI of having abandoned the fascist origins of the party and assumed a negotiating attitude with the monarchist parties and the Christian Democrats. Rauti was influenced by the elitist and aristocratic theses of the philosopher Julius Evola. In *Rivolta contra il mondo moderno* (1934), Evola had critiqued the decadence and spiritual degradation of modernity, both democratic and communist. He advocated a

return to premodern, non-Western forms of civilization, such as those embodied in the Nazi and fascist regimes. Rauti, Giano Accame and Evola had founded the magazine *Imperium* in the late 1940s to educate young people, giving priority to culture over strictly political and partisan work. Armed with these ideas and his opposition to the Atlanticist and moderate line of the MSI, Rauti (formerly an Italian Social Republic participant) called for the construction of a Europe-nation to offset the two Cold War blocs. Ordine Nuovo was one of the most important extra-parliamentary organizations of this period, but was dissolved in 1973 after the Italian government accused it of trying to create a new National Fascist Party.

These notions fuelled a real turning point of profound ideological renewal and the emergence of a new ultra-right that surged into politics and society over the following decades. The French abandonment of Algeria in 1962 dealt the final blow to the Secret Army Organization (OAS, created in Madrid in 1961) and its failed terrorist actions. Algerian independence thwarted the *pied noirs* who had supported the OAS and marked the beginning of the decline of the French far right: those youthful, extra-parliamentary, profoundly anti-communist groups who preferred direct action. Then, Dominique Venner, who had been linked to the OAS, supported a unified, neo-fascist Europe that would disrupt the bipolar balance of world power. He went on to start the magazine *Europe-Action* in 1963, a publication in clear harmony with Rauti's approach. It covered themes such as defence of the white world, the cultural struggle, globalism and a 'realistic' concept of race.

Jean Thiriart from Wallonia shared these ideas. He had participated in the nationalist Fichte Bund movement, had joined the Association of Friends of the Greater Reich and had collaborated with Léon Degrelle and the Nazi occupiers in Belgium. Belgium's abandonment of the Congo in 1960 led Thiriart to start the Civic Action Movement (MAC) and in March 1962 he participated in a meeting in Venice. There, the parties that had created the European Social Movement a decade earlier tried again to form a European grouping. When the project failed, Thiriart founded the Jeune Europe movement, which he led for six years: a vertical European structure with delegations in France, Italy, Germany, Austria, Holland, Switzerland, Great Britain, Portugal and Spain. A new generation was forged there around the reference figures of Claudio Mutti, the Italian director of the movement's magazine, *La Nation Européenne*, and the Frenchman Jean-

Claude Jacquard, future president of the Research and Study Group for European Civilization (GRECE). New, Evolian-rooted culturalist approaches were thus embedded into the neo-fascist profile of many groups in the movement. In Spain, Jeune Europe was represented by the neo-Nazi Spanish Circle of Friends of Europe (CEDADE).

Jeune Europe became the most important post-war, international, far-right organization and managed to shift attention away from nostalgia for fascism. The collapse of colonial empires had launched a new myth of Europe, a new mission for the continent. Thiriart described the project in *Un empire de 400 million d'hommes l'Europe* (1964): to construct a single continental entity, a kind of Jacobin, secular Europe that would link Brest and Bucharest and challenge Cold War Europe. He thus revealed an alignment with Russian Eurasianism *avant la lettre*, long before he came into contact with Aleksandr Dugin. He also revisited biological racism and developed a kind of right-wing Third Worldism by supporting the struggles of the non-aligned countries that were gaining independence in Africa and Asia. All this led to the constitution of the European Community Party in 1965. Though the project was short-lived, Thiriart's ideas were at the core of the profound changes that took place the following decade, in the heat of the explosive movements of 1968.

In many ways, the lingering traces of that year on Western Europe were far more important than the immediate consequences, especially in the realm of ideas. Tony Judt observed in *Postwar* (2005) that the rampant individualism of the 1980s was partially rooted in the ideas of the 1968 youth revolt. Traces of this were also found in the far right. Countering the new left of the French student revolt known as 'May 68', a *new right* appeared, accompanied by a resurgence of youthful, extra-parliamentary, terrorist, anti-communist neo-fascism. One of the first expressions was Occident, created in 1964 and outlawed four years later. Ordre Nouveau took up the torch in 1969 and disappeared in 1973. In Italy, the Avanguardia Nazionale and Ordine Nuovo gained notoriety, expressing something between the Nouvelle Droite and the ultra-right legacy of the interwar fascisms. The self-styled Nouvelle Droite brought about the biggest transformation: a deeper mutation originating with the French experience after withdrawing from Algeria and the ideas of *Europe-Action*, which produced a new cosmovision to challenge the dominant post-war perspective. Nouvelle Droite became the main platform for disseminating

theses concerning 'biological realism' with clear racist connotations, for exalting nationalism, or for stoking the struggle against communism and liberalism to defend a threatened Western race.

Groups and individuals began to develop these ideas in ways that relegated the violent street actions of the previous years to the background. Young Alain de Benoist, who had collaborated with *Europe-Action* and other French neo-fascist media such as *Défense de l'Occident*, started a new publication, *Nouvelle École*, in February 1968. It became the main expression of a diffuse and heterogeneous GRECE, founded the same year and also led by de Benoist. Its main objective was to intellectually renew the far right in France. However, the cultural hegemony of the left after May 68, along with the consolidation of the welfare state and Keynesian economics, hindered the development of its postulates. De Benoist recalibrated for a long-term project of building a far-right counterculture that could influence cultural and university environments first and eventually reach conservative and neo-fascist political parties. This metapolitical strategy was at the core of what de Benoist himself began to call 'right-wing Gramscianism'.

Influenced by authors of the German conservative revolution – especially Oswald Spengler, Carl Schmitt, Ernst Jünger and Arthur Moeller van den Bruck – Alain de Benoist and GRECE introduced a series of elements that became fundamental to the radical right in developing approaches based on a few key ideas: a break with Catholic tradition and Judeo-Christian heritage; critique of egalitarianism, economism and neo-liberal individualism; overcoming Maurrassian nationalism with Indo-European neo-nationalism; and the cult of collective difference. These ideas modernized traditional far-right thinking by replacing classical racism based on biology and superiority with ethnopluralism based on ethnicity and supposed equality. They argued that cultures were equal but distinct, and that people could only develop within 'their own' national cultures. The first outcome from all this was opposition to multiculturalism, which was paradoxically criticized as being racist, followed by critique of Enlightenment-based universalism and egalitarianism. In this framework, the United States, with its melting-pot society and its individualism, became the antagonistic model that justified the need to reformulate the pan-European fascist dream, to emphasize critique of the American cultural and economic colonialism to which Europe was subjected. This pan-

Europeanism became central to understanding why, after the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989, the new far right found itself better situated ideologically than the new left. The end of the story impacted the former much less because its national and continental projects questioned and transcended Cold War bipolarity. Non-leftist challenges to a 'single mindset' and globalization became a key element in the 1980s.

In the early 1970s, a group of young people led by Marco Tarchi from the MSI established an intense connection with French intellectuals. Based on the ideas of Pino Rauti, Julius Evola and Adriano Romualdi, they started the journals *La Voce della Fogna* and *Diorama Letterario* in 1974, then went on to create Hobbit Camps for neo-fascist youth in 1977. These camps received that name because of J.R.R. Tolkien's writings, which were appropriated by neo-fascists through the perspective of Julius Evola.

Despite this notable influence, tensions soon began to appear among Nouvelle Droite intellectuals. Pierre Vial broke away from the group in the 1970s and was in contact with Le Pen's National Front for a time. Guillaume Faye distanced himself from de Benoist's thinking in the 1980s. Early in that decade, the GRECE project had apparently lost its intellectual leadership capacity. After further splintering, de Benoist launched a new journal in 1988, a personal project he called *Krisis*. There, together with French journalist Charles Champetier, de Benoist resumed his earlier critique of liberalism, individualism, egalitarianism and monotheism. He also reactivated his nation-state project to create an organicist, communitarian society and recover collective identities, the 'right to difference', federalism, and proposals for international relations based on a multipolar world disconnected from Washington. These ideas carried through to the end of the twentieth century, as reflected in the manifesto *La nouvelle droite de l'an 2000*, published in 1999.

A new radical right

The first significant wave of the global radical right and far right appeared in the 1980s and became integral to European politics in the 1990s. The intellectual foundations and the sociopolitical changes of prior decades rendered new expressions, as shared elements, parties and traditions gave shape to fresh approaches. Italian expressions presented clear links to historical fascism, but something new was happening in France.

While 1945 had clearly marked the end of fascism as a political project, the end of the bipolar (Cold War) world revealed widespread disenchantment with communism. In a controversial essay published in 1992, Francis Fukuyama argued that the end of the Cold War had ushered in a new 'post-historical' era in which ideologies would disappear, and liberal democracy and the market economy would constitute the final horizon of human development. Though his theses turned out to be essentially inaccurate, this conservative U.S. academic correctly estimated the enormous political relevance of the fall of the Berlin Wall. Among the many processes it set in motion was a profound renovation of political extremes. The traditional far right fell into a crisis from which a new post-industrial radical right emerged, with globalization as its main critique and discourse: like the flip side of the anti-globalization movements that had accompanied the renewal of the classical left wing.

The political scientist Piero Ignazi observes that the new radical right developed from recently created parties – or significantly mutated old parties like the National Front – and presented notable differences to prior neo-fascist and far-right formations, most of which had disappeared from politics. Nationalism experienced intense revival in the 1990s. Some Europeans saw it as a refuge from the single market and globalization. Radical-right parties sought to present themselves as the greatest defenders of their 'national identity', which was threatened by globalization. Like two sides of a coin, xenophobic discourses focused on immigration also spread with the resurgence of nationalism. All this converged with movements that opposed a global economy and the supranational institution of the European Union, as it seemed to eliminate physical and cultural borders.

In this context, the racism of the 1930s gave way to identitarianism and xenophobia. The new radical right began appealing to identities that they considered to be threatened by Islam and the markets. Unemployment and immigration, two central elements in the post-Cold War years, had driven the political campaigns that brought some radical-right parties into national parliaments. The Flemish Bloc had been one of the earliest parties to appeal to these issues and had entered the Belgian Parliament as part of an electoral alliance in 1978. The Centre Party in the Netherlands did the same four years later. Despite very modest support (around 1 per cent), the high proportionality of their electoral systems had allowed both parties to win a seat.

The radical-right wave spread to nearly every country in Central and Western Europe, with new parties, such as the Republicans in Germany, alongside old traditional parties, such as the Freedom Party of Austria and the Swiss People's Party. These last two morphed into radical, right-wing populist parties under the new leadership of Jörg Haider and Christoph Blocher, respectively. Something similar occurred in Belgium in the late 1980s, with the growth of the Flemish Bloc and the National Front. In the Flemish Bloc especially, an ultra-right-wing tradition of collaborationist nostalgia converged with updated post-industrial discourses, as decades of biological, racist rhetoric evolved towards ultranationalist and identitarian positions in the 1990s. Analogous expressions arose in Scandinavia with the Danish People's Party, following the decline of the Progress Party (led by Mogens Glistrup), the Norwegian Progress Party (led by Anders Lange) and New Democracy in Sweden. In contrast to the National Front and other experiences on the continent, these three parties shared an element of anti-tax rebellion and markedly libertarian opposition to state intervention.

Indeed, the most relevant radical-right expression in Europe, and the first to highlight innovative projects with 'ecumenical' pretensions, was the French National Front, led by Jean-Marie Le Pen. Its transition from late 1970s neo-fascism to a post-industrial radical right became a model for many countries. The National Front had officially been established in 1972, with Le Pen as leader, under the impulse of the neo-fascist Ordine Nuovo. That group had been founded three years earlier and had gathered more than 5,000 followers in the wake of the success of the Italian MSI. In 1973, Le Pen and the National Front won only 1.7 per cent of the vote. They remained irrelevant until 1981, when François Mitterrand promoted the party to divide the French right. The National Front subsequently became the unifying force of the new radical right and broke into European politics with ten European parliamentarians (MEPs) in 1984. In the French presidential election four years later, Le Pen won 14.3 per cent of the vote. The party had managed to broaden its social base and gain support across classes. Proclaiming itself an 'anti-political' party, it praised direct democracy while denouncing right- and left-wing elites. The National Front soon became a reference for the entire radical right, which began to assume a discourse that Le Pen summed up during the second round of presidential elections in 2002: 'Socially, I'm left-wing; economically, I'm right-wing; but most of all, I'm a patriot, I'm a national patriot.'

Several factors shaped the post-1989 period in Europe. For a start the collapse of the Soviet Union and the Communist Bloc provoked a global crisis and political instability in Eastern European countries, which was countered by ideologies of order across Europe. Meanwhile rising unemployment and mass immigration of workers from all over the world revived xenophobia in Europe. With the deployment of neo-liberalism and mounting internal tensions, citizens found their scapegoats in American, Asian, African and Eastern European immigrants. These changes led political leaders to adopt xenophobic discourses that until then had seemed exclusive to the far right. State nationalisms and regional ethnonationalisms also revived amid misgivings about European unification, which some perceived as a threat to national sovereignties and cultures. Finally, the inadaptability of traditional parties and the incessant corruption cases that launched television news programmes across the continent effectively eroded confidence in the democratic system. These key elements explain the evolution of old and new far-right groups in Europe.

The new radical right gained prominence in Western Europe. In the mid-1980s electoral percentages for these parties had only scarcely been relevant in France and Italy (an average of 1.1 per cent for national elections that decade, according to Cas Mudde in *Populist Radical Right Parties in Europe* (2007)); but within a few years, everything had changed. Across Europe new parties appeared in the regenerating wake of the National Front. Its ideology, no longer based on nostalgia for historical fascism, offered new proposals in the dynamic post-Cold War context. Initially they attracted small groups of voters who were critical of the traditional right: men from the petite bourgeoisie, self-employed individuals and workers who felt abandoned by a social democracy that was turning towards Anthony Giddens's Third Way, a political philosophy that tried to reconcile post-Cold War social democracy and a reformed welfare state with market-oriented economics. (It was projected as a 'modernized' alternative to both traditional social democracy and neoliberalism.) They questioned the dangers of developing a neo-liberal market economy and criticized the cosmopolitan discourses of the 'Roaring '90s'. By the end of the century the National Front and the Freedom Party of Austria were more popular among workers than the French and Austrian Social Democratic parties.

In the February 1999 legislative elections, the Freedom Party under Jörg Haider won 27.2 per cent of the vote. They entered the Austrian government as part of a Christian Democrat coalition and had control of the vice-chancellorship and five ministries. This had enormous media impact, and many analysts interpreted it as the return of neo-Nazism to power. However, after three years of instability the coalition ended abruptly, prompted by Haider's decision to stir up a revolt of the party's radical base against its own ministers. Evidently the party was more at home in opposition than in government.

In July 2001 the far right reasserted itself in Italy with the new coalition government composed of Silvio Berlusconi's Forza Italia; the Lega Nord, led by Umberto Bossi; and Alleanza Nazionale (National Alliance), the post-fascist heir to the MSI. This coalition reflected the policies emanating from the party designed by Berlusconi. He had begun his career with a brief term as president in 1994, after the Tangentopoli scandal of 1992 had plunged the country's politics into turmoil. Behind this phenomenon was the success of Lega Nord, which had attracted attention from media and analysts across Europe as an expression of Italy's sociopolitical tensions and regional imbalances. After leaving Berlusconi's government in 1995 Lega Nord moved towards vindication of northern identity and openly advocated for the secession of Padania. In this context issues such as immigration and Islamophobia became central. Then, when Berlusconi – Il Cavaliere – entered the new government in 2001, the search began to find more conservative voters. The rightward shift of Berlusconi's populist government was reflected in the presence of the National Alliance, which won 12 per cent of the vote and 62 seats in 2001. Its leader, Gianfranco Fini, carried enough weight for Berlusconi to appoint him as the Italian representative for the convention to draft the foundations of the future (and failed) European Constitution. Of course, this required him to rectify his own statement from 1994 that Mussolini had been 'the greatest statesman of the twentieth century'.

As France and Holland followed in Italy's footsteps, the populist radical right became a key player in European politics. In April 2002 Jean-Marie Le Pen advanced to the second round of the presidential election for the first time, with almost 5 million votes and the support of 16.8 per cent of the electorate. France and many other countries began contemplating the need for a cordon sanitaire to stop 'fascism'. Though Jacques Chirac won

the second round by a wide margin and the leader of the National Front obtained only 18 per cent of the vote, the political impact was enormous. A few weeks later the media were buzzing about the vertiginous rise and assassination of Pim Fortuyn, a charismatic representative of the radical, anti-Islamic, populist right, during the Dutch legislative election campaign. Buoyed by the shock of his death, the Pim Fortuyn List became the second-largest party in the Netherlands and joined a new coalition government after winning 17 per cent of the vote.

By the end of the twentieth century most of Europe had at least one far-right party running in elections. The parties, along with the average votes they received, had doubled, and differences between Eastern and Western Europe were smaller than was (and is) thought. After the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989 and subsequent demise of the Soviet Union, far-right expressions also appeared in many post-communist countries. The Croatian Party of Rights (HSP) and the Slovak National Party (SNS) emerged with ideologies dating back to interwar fascism, while others – the Greater Romania Party (PRM), for one – fused these elements with a certain nostalgia for communism. Meanwhile several far-right leaders were elected from the lists of parties that did not reflect this tendency, including the Bulgarian Socialist Party (BSP), the Communist Party of the Russian Federation (CPRF) and Solidarity Electoral Action (AWS) in Poland. At the turn of the century the populist radical right was the dominant ideology and expression of the European far right. Despite their differences virtually all these parties displayed the common elements of nativism, authoritarianism and populism.

Spain and Francoism

In many senses, Spain had not participated in the processes that took place during the second half of the twentieth century; it has frequently been considered as an exception. However, things were not that easy. It was no coincidence that a significant portion of European collaborationism and fascism – outlawed and on the run but surviving – sought and found political refuge in Franco's Spain. Léon Degrelle, the leader of Walloon Rexism, and Ante Pavelić, who led the Croatian fascist movement, were the most visible and well known, but a broad fascist network based in Spain survived well into the 1970s, even after Franco's death, with strong ties to

the National Brotherhood of Franco's Guard, the CEDADE and Iberian Cross. Franco's regime was seen as a safe place to keep alive the flame of the counter-revolutionary ideal, combative Christianity and ultranationalist positions. It was the only regime (of those that emerged from the interwar crisis which had birthed fascism) to survive the defeat of 1945, thanks to its complete non-adherence to Axis policies and a mix of internal control with (brief) external isolation. However, this did not exempt it from the label: in Resolution 39 of 12 December 1946, the fledgling United Nations recognized the fascist nature of the Franco regime and excluded Spain from its international organizations.

Was Francoism fascism? It depends on what we mean by 'fascism'. Very few contemporary political regimes bear the name of their leaders. There is no Mussolini-ism or Hitler-ism (the closest historiographical designations, now clearly in disuse, would be a 'Mussolini regime' or a 'Hitler regime'). There is talk of Salazarism in Portugal (understandable given its longevity), but it does not refer to the period as a type of political movement. The fascist regimes in Italy and Germany took their names from the parties (the characteristically single parties of fascism and other authoritarian regimes) that served as the organizational, architectural and often administrative framework for power: fascism in Italy was the PNF and National Socialism in Germany was the NSDAP. The logical corollary in Spain, Falangism, generally referred only to the area of Falange influence and not the entire regime, except in a few opposition spaces at a very specific post-war moment.

Is the concept of Francoism a reflection of Franco's personal importance, or is it something more? We will not venture further in this terrain, which has been analysed extensively in the great reference works and the good political biographies available in Javier Rodrigo's *Generalísimo* – but it is important to keep it in mind when focusing on the political and cultural significance of the Spanish regime compared to other forms of populist ultraextremism, post-fascist authoritarianism or the institutional or marginal extreme right. We may be contemplating counter-revolutionary, radical, right-wing cultures and praxis in Spain based on their most extreme and successful forms because they were articulated *from power*, rather than *from the periphery* of power. In the deployed fascism and the authoritarian developmentalist post-fascism of Spain, Franco defied all political typology and ordinary legal categorization. Clearly,

defascistization occurred; members of political traditions other than fascism held power; developmentalist authoritarianism with a corporatist and fundamentalist religious basis was achieved. The Caudillo warlord leader principle remained firm until the end, with its narrative of how Franco unified and synthesized the entire process that had rescued Spain from the clutches of the liberal state, enabled its recovery and saved it from the Marxist threat. As the Falangist jurist Juan Beneyto Pérez expressed it in *Genio y figura del Movimiento* (1940), ‘there is only one source of law: the popular community, the people made into unity and hierarchy, blood and soil; and a single legislator: the *Caudillo*, head and root of the Homeland.’

The Falangist José María Fontana Tarrats may have been right when he stated that, for hundreds of thousands of Spaniards, Francoism meant devotion to the Caudillo in a formula of ‘remembrance and gratitude to a man’. Today, however, it means much more. In the same way that, in our opinion, linking the regime to Franco’s name worked to disassociate the Spanish regime from the family of European fascisms after the Second World War (which is highly debatable, at least during the Spanish Civil War and the 1940s, and did not convince the UN), the monolithic figure of the dictator in the political, administrative, cultural and identitary architecture of Spain from 1936 to 1975 made Francoism without Franco unsustainable, perhaps even unthinkable.

In other words, in the Spanish frame of Francoism, the dictatorial power was the far right. This has largely shaped the radical right-wing projects in Spain. The fascist party embodied the state and gave it architectural and administrative coherence. Ultra-Catholic and ultranationalist forms of socialization involved social order – with varying degrees of success – in the margins of an authoritarian, post-fascist political project imposed from power. It would be difficult to find fascism, or any kind of fascist dissent, outside that state structure. The survival of the Francoist political regime after the Second World War generated the perception that Falangism was subordinated to, or instrumentalized by, a non-fascist institutional apparatus in the first years after the Civil War. This self-indulgent vision has transcended the discussions of nostalgic apologists and embedded itself deeply in historiography, to the point that Falangists have even been described as ‘vanquished victors’. We do not see it this way, nor did Franco himself.

Some clear changes took place after 1946, when the dictatorship stabilized. The state of war ended in 1949 and agreements with the United States in 1953 concerning mutual security led to gradual acceptance of the regime by international organizations. These and other changes stemmed primarily from the signing of the Concordat with the Vatican in 1953. This new international equilibrium brought Spain out of diplomatic ostracism and placed it alongside other anti-communist regimes, just as the Korean War was ending. Many analysts consider this, together with the civil war in Greece, as the starting point of the Cold War. It also led to an internal reconfiguration that diminished the weight of the Falange and Falangism in state politics, though the FET-JONS continued to feed the state's institutional and administrative apparatus.

In this phase of international transition there has been a clear attempt to see in the debates between political families a struggle that ended in 1957 with the triumph of the Catholic and conservative sectors over the original ideologues of national syndicalism. The Franco regime had been built on the struggle between opposing projects: the incessant allies–rivals dialectic of the Falangist fascist project and the reactionary nationalist project of Acción Española. From this perspective the new state served as the battleground for a culture war between two anti-liberal but deeply divergent nationalist conceptions that could not come to terms. Collaboration may have been possible, but contradictions surfaced once the common enemy had been defeated and they were free of a cause that could hold them together. This very qualified opinion rightly identifies in Francoism much of what historical fascism denied. Where historical fascism reflected a kind of combative, violent, palingenetic and warmongering Catholicism, the regime proposed a conservative welfarist, rhetorical peace and brotherhood rather than alternatives for cleansing the anti-Spain. Where historical fascism renounced forms of political representation not subjected to social order, obedience and hierarchy, Francoist regime policies for Spain spoke of organic democracy, representation and monarchy.

In fact, defascistization was something intentional and ongoing that the regime hierarchy saw as a natural progression: from victory in the crusade to victory in peace. The legitimacy of 1936 was never abandoned, though Spain transitioned from national syndicalism to National Catholicism in 1945 and 1953, within a logic of political and administrative institutionalization. The arch-demon of revolutionary liberal democracy –

along with communism – was always lurking; it would be overcome by ‘organic’ and ‘natural’ Catholic democracy, as natural as Franco’s leadership. Established on the legislative foundations of the regime, the Francoist architecture adapted to an internal and external sociopolitical reality that was radically different to that of the fascist era. To some extent normalization was the key to the regime’s success.

The great difference regarding neighbouring countries was that in Spain the far right was the power, not some external agent that needed to revise and reconfigure its political bases. If it was no longer fascist in the 1950s and ’60s, this was because the regime itself had evolved while maintaining the essential features of its political architecture: a providentialist single leader, a clear authoritarian developmentalist vocation with elements of corporativism, and fierce religious fundamentalism. Significantly in 1964 the regime celebrated 25 years of peace – not victory – with all the pomp and laurels and hagiographic praise it could muster. Then, with the inauguration of the crypt of the Valley of the Fallen on the horizon, a decision was made to move the remains of some of the fallen ‘Red’ combatants (they had been shot) to its interior. From a propagandistic and self-legitimizing point of view, this essentially indicated that Francoism needed a discursive update and a fictional ‘recreation’ of a state of peace and national reconciliation. Thus, preservation of peace and internal order became Franco’s most important and lauded achievement.

Defascistization, understood as explicit distancing from any position that maintained affinity with fascist ideologies from late 1942 onwards, did not translate into what some historians and social scientists have presented as a denaturing of the New State’s Falangist pre-war aspirations, attitudes and proclamations about ‘generic fascism’ as a universal measure and ontological model. In other words, there were no anti-fascist sectors within the National Movement, either in the first stage or after the end of a political cycle in Europe; and there was no fascist opposition either. The Franco regime became a kind of mirrorless fascism and settled into a gerontocratic system, guided to the end by an elderly community of trench veterans.

The historian Miguel Ángel Ruiz Carnicer points out that towards the end of the regime there were at least three internal Falangist currents of thought and strategy. They diverged in form and substance but were indistinguishable in their loyalty to the *Generalísimo*. One was ‘ultra’ and

violent, comprised of small groups (Fuerza Nueva, FN; Guerrilleros de Cristo Rey) and strongly linked to the police and other security forces. Another was Falangist social populism, strongly rooted in José Antonio Girón de Velasco's vertical union structure. Though scarcely representative, it framed labour relations and the application of Catholic social doctrine in the working world for more than three decades, with all that this implies about the creation of an elite forged from its precepts and mechanisms for organization and action. The third current was one that Ruiz Carnicer described as 'pragmatic': not reflecting any affinity to Luis Carrero Blanco (who served as prime minister of Spain under Franco), but the success of individuals in building their own political careers. These would be very influential in the transition to the post-dictatorial system.

Significantly this implies that from a common trunk and strong political ties, alternatives were born within the Spanish right. They would have to find a new space after Franco's death in 1975 and beyond the great frontier of the 1976 Political Reform Law: the last of the fundamental laws. It was a game of thrones, conspicuously activated by the assassination of Luis Carrero Blanco by the Basque separatist organization ETA in 1973. This marked an end to the continuity alternative, along with any remote possibility of Francoism without Franco.

Considering how much of the post-Francoist right revolved around political projects that emerged from the cultural core of the regime, the history of the Spanish far right after Franco's death tells of fragmentation and discontinuities with dozens of groups and splinter groups. The Spanish far right developed in several stages. In the mid-1960s, a radical sector of the Franco regime began to mobilize, expressing critique of the timid signs of openness that were appearing. Veterans of the Civil War converged there with people born in the decades following the conflict. In 1966 two far-right entities emerged that eventually gained relevance: the Fuerza Nueva publishing house, the embryo of the party that bore its name, and CEDADE, which became the most prominent neo-Nazi entity in the country. The first sought to develop a Christian nationalist movement and confront liberalism and Marxism. Initially it was part of Franco's 'bunker', defending a return to the essences of Francoism and opposing openness. Created at a meeting in the monastery of San Miguel de las Victorias (Priego) in 1964, it achieved some resonance among military sectors in the final decade of Franco's life and evolved into a hegemonic ultra-right formation during the

Spanish transition to democracy. Meanwhile, CEDADE distanced itself from Francoist and Catholic rhetoric, calling for a return to Nazi and fascist values.

After Franco's death in 1975, the political change promoted by Juan Carlos I left the Falangist parties bewildered. Only Fuerza Nueva acquired any capacity for mobilization and social impact, catalysing what historian Xavier Casals described as a youth avalanche. In the 1977 legislative elections, Fuerza Nueva was part of a coalition that, in reference to the date of the failed *coup d'état* and the outbreak of the Civil War in 1936, unabashedly called itself the National Alliance 18 July. It obtained marginal results of just over 86,000 votes (compared to other post-Franco right-wing alternatives: UCD achieved over 34 per cent of the vote and Alianza Popular a discreet 8 per cent). Two years later, Fuerza Nueva reached a milestone when Blas Piñar became a deputy with 2.1 per cent of the vote, mainly from Castile-La Mancha, Madrid, Cantabria and a section of Castile and León.

Fuerza Nueva coexisted with smaller groups that competed for the name 'Falange' and an extremist, insignificant electorate. They focused more on organizing a potential *coup d'état* than obtaining meaningful parliamentary representation. Fragmentation in the far right (at one point CEDADE even accused Piñar of collaborating with 'international Zionism') contributed to its evolution towards marginalization: from the significant electoral success of the National Union coalition under Blas Piñar in the general elections of 1979, to deep crisis and collapse in the 1982 elections.

Blas Piñar's Fuerza Nueva never developed a programme or consolidated organizationally. It was never clear whether it would integrate into the emerging political system, as the MSI had in Italy, or destroy it through a *coup d'état*. The unresolved dilemma of being both a 'party of order' and 'anti-system' hampered its evolution, until it projected itself further into marginalization as a 'party of disorder'. Fuerza Nueva had serious difficulties adapting to the post-Franco political reality of pluralist and competitive democracy that understood political violence as something that must be rejected, especially from the second half of the 1980s onwards.

Fuerza Nueva disappeared, and the following years were dominated by various forms of Falangism, which continued to fade until a renewed radical right burst into view, reflecting European events in the early 2000s. In the 1980s and '90s, most middle-aged, far-right members left active politics, creating a gap between the more experienced and the younger

activists that made it impossible to develop anything like the French National Front. Blas Piñar founded the (Spanish) National Front in 1986 in an attempt to emulate the French project, but his neo-Francoism prevented any growth similar to that of Le Pen's party. Other more Lepenist initiatives – the National Democratic Alternative, which participated in the 1994 European elections, and National Democracy, created a year later – had similar trajectories. Far-right growth was concentrated in Madrid, Barcelona and Valencia. In Madrid, the discourse of Blas Piñar was perpetuated.

New and old ideas

Though analysts described the early successes of these forces as anecdotal and confined within national contours, much broader horizons soon appeared. Their longevity, programme similarities, political style and core ideas led political scientists to begin analysing them as part of a new political family: the radical right. Leading researchers sought explanations for its emergence and consolidation in the analysis of political supply and demand. Demand-based arguments highlighted how diverse political and social processes had modified interests, attitudes and preferences to make new radical-right proposals much more attractive than in previous decades. Meanwhile supply-side analysis focused on the potential effects of various aspects of the new political formations on electoral results. Though opposed to each other in appearance, the two approaches were actually quite compatible.

Analyses from the perspective of political demand have clearly predominated because they identified relatively common causes in most European countries, which made it possible to develop a global vision. With one eye on socio-economic factors, analysts from this position argued that support for these formations came mainly from citizens who competed for resources. Individuals who found themselves threatened by the consequences of neo-liberalism and globalization fought against those who simply had nothing. In that context, discourses that provided simple, straightforward causes (blaming immigrants and politicians for everything bad) and proposed simple, straightforward solutions (closing borders, 'national preference' policies) received increasing attention. To counter this rather simplistic view, some authors pointed out that support for the radical right came less from those in dire economic situations than from those who

feared the immediate consequences of rapid change in a post-Cold War world. In 2000, Michael Minkenberg argued that fear of change could affect much wider sectors than those who were worried about becoming unemployed. Despite the supposed competition between native and immigrant populations in a struggle for allegedly scarce resources, fear of losing socio-economic status was a key explanatory element for radical-right growth.

Along with issues directly related to immigration, processes related to economic and political globalization and the transition from a Fordist to a post-Fordist production model also required consideration. The internationalization of labour markets had left manual workers – especially those with low skills – unprotected, which began to increase pressure for job qualifications. Education and specialization became central factors for labour market insertion. As job insecurity for manual workers with low education increased significantly, feelings of vulnerability and insecurity became relevant. The professor of political science Hans-Georg Betz in *Radical Right-Wing Populism in Western Europe* (1994) described these individuals as ‘the losers of modernization’.

Fundamentally these sociocultural arguments claim that conflict over the distribution of goods had lost relevance for voters and in the political debate. They had been replaced by issues such as positions on immigration, authority, gender and the environment. Thus the politicization and growing relevance of cultural factors had enabled radical-right formations to gain significant voter support from an interclass electorate located on the right of the sociocultural axis. In that scenario, radical right-wing formations obtained better results when sociocultural issues were at the centre of political and electoral debates.

In contrast to these demand-based arguments, other authors focused on the importance of political supply, emphasizing the relevance of party actions – and the contexts in which they acted – in the success and failure of radical-right formations. This approach explained some aspects that the demand perspective could not, especially in relation to the great national differences in electoral support for these parties. Significantly it has enabled us to stop looking at the radical right as a mere beneficiary of political and social processes that transcend it. The analysts who adopted a supply perspective assumed (as did those who worked from the demand perspective) that potential electoral space for these formations existed in

every country. But why and how some of them had managed to extract electoral advantage from this potential, while others had not, needed to be explained. From this non-exclusive perspective, the two approaches could complement each other.

Concerning variables related to the political offer, Cas Mudde proposed distinguishing between factors external to political parties and those related directly to them. Accordingly, external factors fit in the concept of political opportunity structures and could explain how space was created for the emergence of a new radical-right formation. In these structures the institutional framework – the electoral system and its impact on the emergence of a minority formation – is an important factor, along with the effects of a state's political and administrative organization (centralized, federal, confederal), elements related to potential legal restrictions (prohibitions of parties or some of their activities) and the influence of the political context, or the role of institutional parties in opening or closing political spaces to these new formations. Intense debates have developed about the effects of adopting the themes and language on which the radical right had based its electoral success. With migration as a central element, some argued that traditional political forces legitimized these formations by adopting their approaches, while others believed that it actually distanced the radical right from the political scene. Finally, the role of the media as an external factor in the development of the radical right has been extensively analysed in the work of Pierre-André Taguieff and others.

In the internal landscape of political formations, Roger Eatwell and Matthew Goodwin have rather insistently emphasized the relevance of party organization and the role of the leader. Charismatic leaders such as Jean-Marie Le Pen, Umberto Bossi and Jörg Haider were fundamental to understanding the electoral success and power of their groups, though some parties without particularly attractive leaders also achieved notoriety. Cas Mudde observed that charismatic leadership seemed more crucial in the formative years of these parties, then gradually diminished. After emergence and early expansion, they became consolidated and developed their own internal organization.

For supply-side analysts, the type of discourse and image these groups projected was a crucial element because success somehow correlated with their capacity to present their proposals without being linked to the traditional far right. Thus they deliberately sought to make their platforms

appear unrelated to anti-democratic, anti-egalitarian, violent or openly anti-liberal approaches. The sociologist Jens Rydgren has suggested that radical-right discourses against immigration and 'politics' gradually came to be perceived as acceptable and somewhat harmless. Through modulated discourse and updated images and activities, they managed to distance themselves from smaller, openly racist and anti-democratic groups, most of them descended from classical fascism and neo-fascism. Their great success was to gain legitimacy in the eyes of the electorate.

Innovative radical-right approaches had not been forged in the final years of the Cold War; they had emerged in reaction to the subsequent post-war cultural and political consensus. Discourse revolved around authoritarianism, patriotism, the family and moral values, to capitalize on what Ronald Inglehart described in 1977 as the 'silent counter-revolution'. The new radical right drew from the renewal approaches of the French Nouvelle Droite and sectors of MSI dissidents in Italy, taking advantage of social, economic and cultural changes in the 1980s. These two elements explain both the continuity and the break with fascism and neo-fascism. Though the new radical right had clearly departed from the fascist past, its roots were there.

In broad strokes, these updated approaches revolved around two main themes: populist, anti-establishment rhetoric and outright rejection of the foreign population, in what Rydgren conceptualized in a 2005 article as an 'ethnopluralist' doctrine. The latter grew into a primary mobilization platform for the European radical right. Rejection of Islam and the Muslim population living in Europe took centre stage as a key homogenizing element in their political offer prior to the 9/11 attacks in the United States in 2001 and subsequent strikes in Europe. After decades of challenging the biological racism of the Second World War, immigration was now being rejected on the basis of 'cultural' or 'differentialist' racism. Culture, understood as a static, homogeneous and particular mix of values and lifestyles, had replaced race. In a nation perceived as an identity built around elements of the past, immigrant populations were analysed through the lens of their different, often antagonistic, cultural belonging. This logic placed them outside the nation and led to an obvious conclusion: 'excessive' influx of people with different cultures threatened the integrity of the nation. Opposition to immigration and the exaltation of cultural

diversity were two fundamental elements in defending one's own threatened nation.

The other fundamental element in this logic affirmed that individuals and their cultures were equal but different. Thus Pierre-André Taguieff argues that defending one's own cultural identity – which was always under threat – was the best way to defend cultural diversity. This culturalist discourse assumes that the coexistence of different cultures inevitably leads to conflict. It implies a belief that xenophobia is inherent to human behaviour; in other words, we instinctively tend to form homogeneous groups that are hostile to other groups.

This stratagem made it possible to blame immigrants for a broad range of social issues and shaped a discourse in defence of their exclusion based on three main arguments. The first was the cultural threat, which focused on the need to defend 'Western' society and values against the threat of Islam: a supposedly inherently intolerant religion with totalitarian traits. This approach gathered strength in the 1990s and became powerful in the new century. The local struggle was linked to a much broader European struggle and facilitated the transnational development of the radical right. The second argument alluded to problems arising from the presence of foreign populations who belonged to 'backward cultures', which made it impossible for them to adapt to the norms of European societies. This inevitably led to conflicts such as a decline in native students' school performance, citizen insecurity, the degradation of neighbourhoods in large cities and numerous other 'problems of coexistence'. The third argument denounced the alleged material damage caused by immigration, especially among the indigenous working classes, and around two aspects in particular: the labour market and access to state and local government resources. Here the radical right denounced another alleged relationship between unemployment and labour-market precariousness stemming from competition with the immigrant population. Equating immigrants with crime, urban decay, coexistence issues and diseases yielded good electoral results. Immigrants – especially the non-European populations – with help from the communists, homosexuals, drug addicts and democratic parties were responsible for the decline of civilization. The 'wholesome people' must rise up to safeguard the 'national identity'.

These ideas developed into what some authors refer to as 'welfare chauvinism' in defence of 'national preference', which argues that jobs and

public resources should go first to the ‘nationals’, to ‘people from here’. As anti-communism lost influence, ‘national identity’ became a core idea for radical-right parties. Feelings of belonging to a community differentiated by language, religion, culture or history gained ground against the ‘threat’ of immigration. The National Front placed the issue at the top of their political agenda and included it in their electoral campaigns. Concern about immigration and structural unemployment increased in Europe and fed the arguments about cultural antagonism and the ‘impossibility’ of integrating others into a nation conceived as immutable. Of course, immigration was not the only issue fuelling the growth of the new radical right. If it had been, these organizations would have disappeared after partial application of their agendas by the EU and its Member States. But they were not single-issue parties; they could adapt to national contexts and changing European scenarios.

This outright rejection of the immigrant population was coupled to a second element of anti-establishment populist rhetoric. Despite the slipperiness of the term ‘populism’, most authors tend to interpret it more as a political style than as an ideological proposal with specific, systematic content. For the radical right the populist component was essentially a strategic resource for achieving political mobilization favourable to its interests. Hans-George Betz described the rhetorical double manoeuvre involved: first through the appeal to an idealized people as the bearers of supposedly innate virtues that should extend to politics, and second through this people’s opposition to elites and foreign populations, which are regarded as alien to them. Thus anti-establishment and anti-foreigner discourses were two sides of the same coin.

In this context various groups raised the banner of ‘authentic’ democracy, asserting themselves and the mobilized ‘people’ as representatives of popular sovereignty. Unlike the fascist regimes and their contempt for democracy, radical-right parties cast themselves as the greatest defenders of ‘true democracy’: those who sought to ‘return’ it to the ‘sovereign people’. Their appeal to ‘the people’ departed from some of the classical (now obsolete) ideological adscriptions and outdated left–right divisions, while denouncing political (historical and majority parties), cultural (including the media) and economic elites. These speeches achieved remarkable relevance and generated tension among analysts. Their success, and their perplexity, lay in the fact that they did not directly

condemn parliamentary democracy, as the neo-fascist extreme right had traditionally done. Rather, they focused on the representatives of the system, who were seen as enemies of popular sovereignty.

Who voted for the radical right? Support for these formations went far beyond those who sympathized with interwar fascisms or the traditional post-war far right. Numerous studies point to how the socio-economic profile of radical-right voters evolved from the 1980s through the early 2000s. Growth occurred as the predominantly middle-class electorate of the 1980s was joined by the working classes in the 1990s. Both sectors were concerned about unemployment and the lack of social protection. The blue-collar vote consisted of manual labourers, lower-ranking white-collar workers and the unemployed. However, analysts do not quite agree on whether these were former left-wing voters or not, especially in France. The political scientist Pascal Perrineau argued that voters for Le Pen's National Front came from working-class sectors that had voted for the left in prior decades. In contrast, another political scientist, Nonna Mayer, observed that this working-class electorate was mainly composed of scarcely politicized youth who rejected the left-right division. Mayer contended that the working class and middle class had conflicting economic preferences: the former wanted a stronger state, and the latter wanted the opposite. Nonetheless this rather young and highly masculinized electorate was united in their critique of immigrants and political elites.

The debate did not end when Le Pen advanced to the second round of the French elections in 2002; in fact, it is still going strong to this day. A similar polemic continues about what to call these parties that emerged with electoral strength and political power at the turn of the century. The debates multiplied again when Donald Trump came to power in the United States in 2016. Concepts such as the 'new far right', 'neopopulism' or the 'radical right' proliferated in academic analyses and quickly transferred to the media. Could any connection be made between the experiences led by Hitler and Mussolini and these new groups? The scholar Andrea Mammone cautioned of the need for rigour before speaking of a complete break between the new radical right and the interwar movements. Both subfamilies shared an ultranationalist vision, had built their arguments around the 'decadence' of European societies, and featured relatively strong and charismatic populist leadership. Formations like the National Front, the Freedom Party of Austria and the Flemish Bloc also tended toward a

benevolent reading of the history of fascism and shared it with their followers. Jean-Marie Le Pen, for example, was condemned in 1997 for claiming that Nazi gas chambers had been a 'minor detail' of the Second World War. Jörg Haider, leader of the Freedom Party, was forced to resign as mayor of Carinthia in 1991 after praising the 'appropriate labour policy of the Third Reich'. Furthermore, many members of these formations came from the traditional or neo-fascist extreme right.

However, many scholars argued for a clear distinction between the two. Publications multiplied in the search to define what had emerged in the late twentieth century. Cas Mudde affirmed in 2007 that the lack of consensus among scholars had generated a war of words. Arguments abounded concerning the possible shared roots of the new groups and the interwar fascisms. The National Front and other new formations were compared and contrasted with interwar fascisms. However, the works of Piero Ignazi and Hans-Georg Betz managed to break with these views. Their influential texts in the 1990s began a line of inquiry that Mudde and others have continued to develop. The resulting proposal envisioned a broad ultra-right category that houses two subfamilies: a populist radical right that participates in the democratic system to erode it from within, and an extreme right that challenges it from the outside. Thus the two subfamilies are differentiated by their acceptance of and participation in liberal parliamentary systems.

The new radical right set out to gain spaces of power and influence within democratic systems to erode them. It had abandoned violence as a method of political action and was not deployed through armed militias, as the interwar movements had been. Nor did it advocate complete identification of the party with the state. From there it followed that the new formations, unlike the post-war neo-fascist groups and their successors, had no direct or explicit connections with classical fascisms. This new stage was directly linked to our present-day reality.

4

CONSOLIDATION OF THE RADICAL RIGHT

The rise of the radical right in Europe and other parts of the world is undeniable. It began expanding at the turn of the millennium and shows no signs of abating anytime soon. Though radical-right parties have been growing since the 1980s, when their ideas first began to appear on political agendas in major Western countries, the fundamental element of this new stage is the definitive incorporation of the radical right into the national and international political mainstream. It had existed on the fringes of a political game – designed and established through the general consensus of the main parties – that worked to exclude extreme politics, despite occasional shocks to the system. In the early 2000s cracks became visible as radical right-wing populist parties and leaders began to be seen as potentially acceptable partners in governing coalitions. Thus ideas previously confined to marginal political and media circles found their way into the agendas of many traditional parties. The centre of political debate shifted, profoundly altering what was considered acceptable and normal.

Since the 1980s traditional right-of-centre parties have gradually adopted nativist, authoritarian and populist arguments and policies. In Europe their programmes express Eurosceptic and Islamophobic positions along with critiques of ‘political correctness’. During their tenures Austrian Chancellor Sebastian Kurz and British Prime Minister Theresa May demonstrated this with strict policies on immigration and terrorism that even surpassed those proposed by Le Pen’s National Front. Boris Johnson’s June 2022 proposal to send asylum seekers arriving in the UK to Rwanda would have delighted many European far-right leaders a few decades earlier.

This profound change permeates all levels of politics. The transformation of conservative parties into renewed radical-right groups is a

central element of this period, though the core consists of populist radical-right parties born outside traditional political circles, such as the Federation of Young Democrats–Hungarian Civic Party (Fidesz) and Poland’s Law and Justice Party (PiS). Though the shift was observed earlier in Austria and a few other countries, as we saw in [Chapter Three](#), the significant novelty with these two parties is that transformation occurred while they were in power. Radical- and far-right parties founded before the end of the twentieth century have also undergone drastic changes and enjoyed increased electoral support. Figures provided by Cas Mudde in 2007 indicate an average increase from 4.7 to 7.5 per cent across Europe between the first and second decades of the twenty-first century. These formations have also managed to gain traction in countries that had categorically resisted them, such as Sweden and Germany. Most importantly in some countries they have become the most popular choice in more than one election; this has been the case for the Danish People’s Party, Fidesz, French National Rally and PiS. Across Europe, the radical right has become a common central force when it comes to forming national and regional governments. The Freedom Party of Austria, the Danish People’s Party, the Netherlands’ Party for Freedom and the Italian Lega Nord have all become coalition-government partners with mainstream parties in recent decades. Fidesz and PiS have even managed to form governments on their own; before 2000, only the Croatian Democratic Union had managed such a feat, led by Franjo Tudjman. Of course, the phenomenon goes beyond Europe: three of the world’s five most populous countries have very recently had, or still have, democratically elected far-right leaders. Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro came to power as leaders of mainstream parties. In India, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is the head of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) that represents the massive Hindutva movement. It includes violent and extremist groups such as the National Volunteers Organization (RSS), of which Modi himself has been a member since he was eight years old.

Normalization of the radical right is a fundamental characteristic of our time. This fourth wave of the far right – as expert Cas Mudde describes it – would be inexplicable without three key processes that have marked the last two decades. Three great crises in this century have empowered the projection of radical-right ideas at global, continental and local levels: Islamist terrorism and the ‘global war on terror’ following the 9/11 attacks; the Great Recession of 2008 and the subsequent policies pursued by the

European Commission and Member States; and the refugee crisis of 2015. These crises occurred as Europe itself was changing, with EU expansion to include Eastern Europe in 2004 and the debates that ensued. The inevitably profound consequences of the pandemic that broke out in March 2020 and the Russian invasion of Ukraine that began two years later remain to be examined.

After 9/11, the fantasy of a liberal world order was fatally undermined. A global war on terror was launched and Cold War rhetoric resurfaced in President George W. Bush's reference to a new 'axis of evil' in his State of the Union address of late January 2002. Both in Europe and the USA there was a public rejection of anything linked to the culture of Islam, leading to a notable rise in attacks against Muslim communities across Europe and the United States. Radical-right groups grew by fostering a sense of insecurity, propagating fears around the rapid changes that had occurred subsequent to the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989. Central among these was immigration from 'non-Western' countries.

Radical-right approaches contained a clear nativist component. The equation linking crime and immigration spread throughout the Western world at different intensities, and Islamophobia became a key element of the entire European far right. They argued that the spread of terrorism corresponded closely to the spread of immigration and to theories and policies that fostered multiculturalism. Terrorism and Islam were two sides of the same coin. However, this discourse was far from exclusive to extreme right-wingers: these and other arguments were rapidly being assimilated as common content into many major parties in Europe and America. In fact, they had gained substantial ground in European politics long before Donald Trump came to power in the United States. The French National Front was paradigmatic in this regard.

Le Pen's party tended to question the post-Cold War European order. In 2005, after more than a decade of widespread optimism, problems with the continental project became more evident when the referendum on the draft of the European Constitution failed in France and the Netherlands: two major countries in the European project. The prevailing 'no' vote was directly related to the accession of ten new states to the European Union in May of the previous year. Eight of them – Slovakia, Slovenia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, the Czech Republic, Hungary and Poland – had been members of the Soviet bloc. The first five, along with Bulgaria and

Romania, formally joined NATO the same year. Right-wingers from Eastern countries also entered the European Parliament in 2004. These Eastern European far-right and traditional-right parties tended to be more radical and more strongly opposed to immigration than their Western counterparts, shifting the political baseline in the European Parliament. A process of radicalization of these traditional Eastern European right-wing parties occurred, as they quickly adopted the anti-immigration policies on the far right of their domestic politics, as a reaction to European expansion. The contagion became central towards the end of that decade, as some of the most important traditional parties from those countries – Fidesz in Hungary, PiS in Poland or the Social Democratic Party of Slovakia – quickly assimilated the anti-immigration policies of far-right parties in their countries. This process was reinforced with the accession of Bulgaria and Romania to the European Union in 2007. Two years later, two openly ultranationalist and xenophobic parties entered the European Parliament: Ataka from Bulgaria and the Greater Romania Party. With these, radical-right and extreme-right parliamentarians obtained the twenty seats necessary to form their own group, which they called Identity, Tradition, Sovereignty. After thirteen years without such expressions in Europe, the creation of this group pointed to a worrisome resurgence across the continent and beyond. ‘The Far Right Is Re-Arming,’ ran a headline in the Spanish newspaper *La Vanguardia* in January 2007, as it forecast events and denounced the misogynistic behaviour of Ataka member Dimitar Stoyanov.

With the expansion of representation in Europe, the far right received a double boost: parties from Eastern Europe presented increasingly Eurosceptic and radicalized discourses in Brussels that helped normalize and encourage their radical counterparts in the West. Nigel Farage, then leader of the populist, Eurosceptic UK Independence Party (UKIP), provided a glaring example, with displays of verbal violence that the European Parliament had not experienced in years. Meanwhile Eurosceptic parties received greater funding from European institutions, which they used to expand the scope of their proposals. Paradoxically the European Union was – and is – financing the development of the parties that were attacking it. In 2014 the 45 MEPs of the Europe of Freedom and Direct Democracy group (EFDD), fruit of an agreement between UKIP and the Five Star Movement, had an annual budget of €5 million.

While this was unfolding, the Great Recession began on 15 September 2008, when Lehman Brothers, the fourth-largest investment bank in the United States, declared bankruptcy. In the biggest crisis of capitalism since 1929, Europe also had to confront its own demons. The austerity policies that followed, especially after the sovereign debt crisis of 2010, exposed the global questioning of the neo-liberal model along with some structural issues that threatened the future of the European Union, given its great difficulties in successfully forging a common identity and integrating new states from the margins of citizenship and the single currency. The enormous challenges of integrating very heterogeneous economies in tension could not be resolved with the prescriptions that Brussels and Frankfurt tried to impose. Thus the stark limitations of the shared European project became painfully evident.

As the alleged post-national liberalism of the European Union imploded, the populist radical right became the self-appointed defenders of national traditions and values that were perceived as threatened. Obscure, extremist political minorities became forces capable of competing with traditional parties such as the Christian Democrats, Social Democrats and Liberals, who no longer dominated European politics.

At first this crisis of representation was expressed through new leftist and progressive formations that sought to build alternatives to the two-party systems that had been consolidated after the Second World War. The left-right axis morphed into opposing forces described as ‘those above–those below’ or ‘we are the 99 per cent’. Movements such as Occupy Wall Street and 15-M in Spain showed that cultural and emotional elements must be added to divisions centred on social and economic factors because populisms, as French historian and sociologist Pierre Rosanvallon in *The Populist Century* (2021) emphasized, are also ‘regimes of passions and emotions’. Demands for sovereignty vis-à-vis national and supranational powers were central to the development of political parties such as the Greek Syriza and Spanish Podemos. From 2014 – when the European elections catapulted them into political arenas while the news reminded the world of the First World War centennial – to 2019, these and similar forces built their electoral campaigns around the struggle against neo-liberal globalization. But after five years of political action from within the institutions, their seductive capacity had waned significantly. Syriza’s failure in Greece and rapprochement with Vladimir Putin in 2015, along

with the increasing moderation of Podemos after it entered the Spanish government in 2020, marked the end of a cycle.

In a parallel process, European radical-right parties were part of the political system and their visibility was increasing. Cas Mudde observed in 1996 that it was not so much the growth of the radical right as the consequences of European policies that had made their populist proposals much more audible. The political, economic and institutional crisis of the second decade of the century precipitated both the victory of the French National Front in the European elections of May 2014 and the emergence of the openly neo-Nazi Golden Dawn party in Greece, which captured nearly 10 per cent of the vote.

In this scenario expressions of accumulated discontent emerged after decades of policies and institutions dominated by neo-liberal approaches. Inequality became a major issue as distrust of the economic and political elites grew. The political scientists Ivan Krastev and Stephen Holmes in *The Light that Failed: A Reckoning* (2019) describe how the appeal of neo-liberal capitalism and liberal democracy has profoundly diminished, and trust in the legitimacy of European institutions has declined exponentially. Not surprisingly the members of the Visegrád Group – Hungary, Poland, the Czech Republic and Slovakia – have led the way. After twenty years of neo-liberal policies following the collapse of the communist regimes, the promise of a better world has faded.

In this context Viktor Orbán returned to power in Hungary in 2010. His party, Fidesz, together with the far-right, antisemitic Jobbik party, obtained 70 per cent of the vote. Orbán took advantage of the disappointment stemming from the results of European Union integration in the wake of the 2008 crisis and the collapse of the post-communist left – which had governed twelve of the twenty years since the fall of the Berlin Wall – to turn his party into one of the greatest exponents of the renewed radical right. In his view, for the Hungarian nation to survive, the European Union's liberal conception of society as a network of producers without soul or tradition must end. Furthermore the cold, amoral, liberal language of human rights, civil society and legal procedures disassociated history from justice and the ethnic components of individual and collective rights.

During its eight years in opposition Fidesz had created and deployed a kind of parallel state through 'civic circles' and the media. Its conservative, nationalist electoral programme lacked clear lines, but upon winning an

absolute majority with 52.7 per cent of the vote and 263 out of 386 seats, it began to transform the state. It strengthened the executive branch by creating a super-Ministry of Civil Service and Justice, reduced parliament to a rubber-stamp entity for validating its policies and limited the power of institutions not elected by popular majority – from the courts to the tax authorities. The most important step was the constitutional reform of April 2011, which removed the concept of ‘Republic’ from the country’s name to emphasize its Christian heritage. The party returned to the Trianon Treaty of 1920 to revise contemporary national history and promote intense nationalism. It also modified electoral law, reduced the number of parliamentarians from 386 to 199 and increased the number of deputies elected by the majority system with respect to the proportional system. This gave greater parliamentary control to the ruling party. Meanwhile a network of like-minded businessmen began to acquire most of the media sources while others, such as the reputable newspaper *Népszabadság*, were shut down. Orbán’s political transformation of Hungary was accompanied by a cultural one, as reflected in his struggle against George Soros and the Central European University. The pressure was so strong that this leading research centre, directed by Michael Ignatieff, moved most of its activities to Vienna.

After a second electoral triumph in 2014, Orbán completed the authoritarian shift and conceptualized his illiberal democracy. His government assumed three characteristic traits of populism: strong anti-expert rhetoric, post-truth politics and the renationalization of politics. He created a parallel, partisan judiciary that significantly limited the independence of judges and effectively turned Hungary into a competitive authoritarian state with an increasingly beleaguered opposition. His landslide victory with more than 50 per cent of the vote in the April 2022 election seemed to indicate that Trump’s downfall, Bolsonaro’s decline and years of rapport with Putin had done nothing to diminish his power.

While this was unfolding, the pis revived in Poland in 2015. Jarosław Kaczyński’s government had fallen in 2007, but the radical right managed to return to power. pis won the first absolute majority since the fall of the Berlin Wall, then embarked on a process of judicial and constitutional reform that bore a clear resemblance to what was happening in Hungary, as did its economic policies. A few weeks after the new Polish government came to power, Viktor Orbán went to Poland to meet pis strongman

Jarosław Kaczyński. Like Fidesz, his party had seized on the fallout from the 2008 crisis and returned to power after eight years. Poland had one of the most successful post-Iron Curtain economies in Eastern Europe – annual average nominal profit doubled from 2004 to 2016 and unemployment fell by more than 12 per cent – and Polish millennials were the first generation with university attendance rates similar to those in Western countries; the internal divide was fundamentally cultural and moral rather than socio-economic.

Since coming to power in Hungary, Orbán has promoted an agenda contrary to that of Berlin and Brussels. His Orbanomics combine nationalization of the energy sector and pension plans, price regulation of basic services, incentives for small- and medium-sized enterprises, and increased tax pressure on banks, energy and telecommunications companies. Broadly speaking Hungary's dominant political party has sought to consolidate itself as a coalition between the nationalized working classes and an emerging national bourgeoisie. Dorit Geva, however, describes this linking of authoritarian neo-liberalism with hyper-nationalism as Ordonationalism, that is, an advanced neoliberal answer to the crisis of neoliberalism. Despite the rhetoric, Orbán's policies to support nationals – expanding school canteens, freezing indirect taxes, offering free textbooks only for Hungarian citizens – exclude most of the population.

The consolidation of PiS and Fidesz was closely correlated with the refugee crisis of the summer of 2015. Frontex data indicates that up to 1.8 million border entries were registered in the European Union that year and over half a million more in 2016, mainly from Syria, Afghanistan, Iraq and Kosovo. The crisis was a direct consequence of erratic Western policy – especially during the Arab Spring – which created the conditions for the proliferation of failed states and phenomena such as the Islamic State, an organization that controlled much of Syria and Iraq in mid-2015. Tensions mounted when Germany showed a degree of openness and the European Commission proposed a relocation and resettlement plan that would concentrate asylum seekers in Italy, Greece and Hungary, then distribute them throughout the European territory based on quotas for each of the 28 Member States. German Chancellor Angela Merkel's policy failed; at the end of the imposed period in September 2017, fewer than 45,000 people had been relocated. Most countries on the continent had failed to comply with hosting agreements.

By explaining this as a ‘refugee crisis’, the mainstream media played a key role in incorporating radical-right vocabulary into the political agenda. The voice of Viktor Orbán was among those heard most on the continent. In response to Merkel’s *Willkommenskultur*, which opened Germany and the European Union to asylum seekers, Orbán likened the refugees to ‘an army’ seeking to invade his country. He then approved measures to criminalize those who crossed the border illegally and proposed building a 175-kilometre (109 mi.) fence on the Hungarian borders with Serbia and Croatia. In response to the quota system implemented by the European Union, the governments of Hungary, Poland and Slovakia indicated their willingness to accept Christian refugees only. The issue was central to the election campaigns in Poland (2015), Slovakia (2016), Hungary and Slovenia (2018), and Orbán managed to establish himself as a point of reference for the European populist right. During the third bilateral meeting between leaders of Spain’s radical right-wing Vox party and leaders of Fidesz in November 2021, Vox’s Santiago Abascal emphasized his ‘absolute harmony’ with Orbán regarding the need to protect the borders of their countries.

Positions of reticence towards refugees were not exclusive to the radical right. Governments led by non-right forces in Austria, Denmark, the Czech Republic and the Netherlands followed similar practices, even though the latter two had a cordon sanitaire preventing the radical right from entering their governments. When Matteo Salvini became Minister of the Interior in June 2018, he closed Italian ports and criminalized NGOs that were saving migrants from drowning in the Mediterranean Ocean. The EU response to refugees and successive migratory waves from outside Europe have essentially helped to normalize conservative-right positions in general and radical-right positions in particular.

Such was the political climate that preceded Brexit. Not surprisingly Nigel Farage used the refugee crisis to bolster the call to leave the EU. The United Kingdom’s exit from the European Union was one of the most important foreign policy decisions of this century. Though largely motivated by internal divisions in the Conservative Party, UKIP’s arguments heavily influenced David Cameron’s decision to call the referendum in June 2016. Pressure also came from the most Eurosceptical wing of his own party, which welcomed UKIP’s anti-European views.

Populist views were fundamental to Brexit, which was presented as a confrontation between ‘ordinary people’ and the establishment. Criticism of the latter was levelled at targets ranging from the International Monetary Fund and the Bank of England to major world powers and trade unions. Michael Gove, Cameron’s justice minister, summed it up in a June 2016 Sky News interview when he said that Britons ‘have had enough of experts’. The campaign focused on sovereignty and immigration: two fundamental issues of the European, populist, radical-right agenda. Topics such as immigration and the need to ‘recover sovereignty’ from European institutions divided society and gave Brexit the victory by a very small margin. During the negotiations in Brussels, Theresa May also expressed the ambition to curb European immigration and get out from under the jurisdiction of the European Court of Justice by leaving the Common Market. Though UKIP would temporarily be languishing as a political formation, its agenda had prevailed.

Only a few months elapsed between the triumph of ‘leave’ and the victory of multimillionaire Donald Trump in the U.S. presidential elections. His rise to power in January 2017 marked a turning point for the radical right in Europe and around the world. Federico Finchelstein reported how National Front leader Marine Le Pen went so far as to claim that Trump represented a ‘global revolution’ and the victory of the people over the elites. Debates proliferated around his degree of rapprochement with fascism and some intellectuals wondered whether American politics had reached a ‘Weimar moment’. Although many of his voters came from what Hans-Georg Betz had described as the ‘losers of modernization’, others came from ultraconservative, high-income segments of society with established intellectual trajectories. The Trump phenomenon had local and global roots that went beyond ‘angry white men’.

During the presidency of Barack Obama (2008–16), the American radical right intensified its positions in response to the liberal, cosmopolitan rule of the first African American president in U.S. history. The Tea Party appeared in 2009, Steve Bannon took over Breitbart News in 2012, Alex Jones and Infowars became increasingly visible in the media, conspiracy theories proliferated (including the question about Obama’s birthplace), intellectuals such as Jordan Peterson or Ben Shapiro enjoyed ever wider acclaim, and activist forums like 4chan and 8chan multiplied. All this gave shape to the Alternative Right or ‘Alt-Right’, a concept formulated by Paul

Gottfried in 2008. This heterogeneous current was critical of the American neo-conservatism that had accepted the liberal democracy of the Reagan and Bush presidencies. The four main postulates of the Alt-Right programme – rejection of liberal democracy, defence of economic nationalism, radicalism and a commitment to isolationism in foreign policy – were clearly linked to the Nouvelle-Droite theses analysed in the previous chapter of this book. Samuel Francis's *Leviathan and Its Enemies* (1995), conveniently republished in 2016, became the reference book for the movement. It spoke of a political elite in the shadows and the illusory character of liberal democracy; these two fundamental ideas marked the Trump administration and can be traced back to the texts of Oswald Spengler, who wrote *The Decline of the West* (1918).

Once in power, Trump's 'paranoid style' – as Richard Hofstadter described the American populist tradition in 1964 – soon went global. He promoted authoritarian values that threatened liberalism and democracy. Populist rhetoric legitimized his style of government, one marked by racism, sexism, identitarianism, anti-globalism, economic nationalism and anti-immigration rhetoric. Trump managed to pass a moratorium on immigration from Muslim countries to the USA (the 'Muslim Ban') and worked to fulfil one of his most notorious propaganda pledges of constructing a wall along the southern U.S. border with Mexico. He also announced several measures to prioritize European migrants. Though only partially successful during his first term in office, these measures demonstrated clear harmony with European radical-right policies, especially those of the Italians.

From 2013 to 2018, Matteo Salvini extended Lega Nord approaches to the rest of Italy and turned this regional-nationalist party into a national one. He abandoned autonomist rhetoric, dropped the regional reference from the party name, and shifted his critique from southern Italy to Brussels and the European Union supra-state. The new Lega changed its propaganda colour from green to blue and replicated the design that had catapulted Donald Trump to the U.S. presidency. In a bid to become the reference for a plural right ranging from Forza Italia to the Alleanza Nazionale (by leveraging the internal crises of both formations), Salvini imposed a social, Lepenist turn aimed at connecting with the sectors most affected by the crisis. The slogan 'Italians First' united him with the movement that Trump seemed to be leading. The Lega grew thanks to a skilful media strategy,

adamant anti-European discourse and links to Putin's Russia through the Lombardy–Russia Cultural Association: an entity created in 2014 to develop a network of organizations in defence of Christian identity, the traditional family and the fight against globalism.

The legislative elections of March 2018 demonstrated the success of this policy: the Five Star Movement established itself as the first party in parliament and Lega obtained a historic 17 per cent of the vote. Between them they won half the total votes in an election with a 73 per cent participation rate. Salvini's negotiating skills led Giuseppe Conte's government to accept him as Minister of the Interior and Deputy Prime Minister. Having blocked the arrival of refugees and harassed NGOs working in the Mediterranean, the fight against immigration was now central to his policies. This was reflected in the security decree (known as the Salvini Decree) of 2018, which limited the arrival of foreigners while expanding capacities for national self-defence and arms sales.

The Conte government lasted just over a year and was perceived as a radical-right assault on power using the electoral system. The Five Star–Lega coalition was outside the traditional system and strongly critical of EU policies. The prospect of the continent's fourth-largest economy further eroding the continental project strained politics in Brussels, which was already negotiating Brexit and contending with Hungary and Poland. However, the Conte government was dissolved on 20 August 2019; the Five Star Movement and the Democratic Party formed a new cabinet. The figure of Salvini began to decline as that of Giorgia Meloni rose. A member of MSI in her youth and leader of the Brothers of Italy, she now competed with the Lega for dominance of the radical right and Italian representation in international networks. Her presence in the Vox campaign during the 2022 Andalusian regional elections reflected this.

Italy expressed the global phenomenon that was also spreading across Europe. In the French presidential elections of April 2017, Marine Le Pen won 34 per cent of the vote in the second round. In the European elections of May 2019, far-right parties achieved their best results in votes and seats; they were the most-voted-for parties in France, Italy, Poland, Great Britain and Hungary. By the end of that year the far right had seats in every national parliament in Europe except Ireland and Malta. Outside Europe Jair Bolsonaro became president of Brazil and Narendra Modi, who had an absolute majority in the second-most populous country in the world,

significantly improved his results. All this coincided with the end of 'Iberian exceptionalism': Vox had entered the Andalusian Parliament and Chega! acceded to the Assembly of the Republic of Portugal in October 2019. And the wave continues: in the French presidential election of April 2022, Marine Le Pen improved on her 2017 results and went into the second round with over 8 million votes. Despite Emmanuel Macron's victory, the combined votes for Le Pen and Éric Zemmour in the first round gave the far right more than 30 per cent of the vote, a share well above that obtained by the incumbent.

Continuity and innovation

Though part of the European population considered Donald Trump's presidential victory an unprecedented novelty, a phenomenon that could only be linked to the interwar fascisms, the origins of the rise of the radical right must be sought in the more recent past. Debates about it have occupied historians, sociologists, political scientists and intellectuals for the past twenty years.

First, they asked whether support for these parties should be understood as a protest against the traditional parties or a growing sympathy for radical-right positions – it was really a combination of both factors.

Second, as in the final decades of the last century, intense discussions have arisen concerning the weight of economic and cultural factors. The simplest version of this debate seeks to discern which of the two factors motivates people to vote for these parties. Economic factors would motivate voters stereotyped as the 'losers of neo-liberal globalization' to vote for the radical right to protest what they perceive as a situation of relative deprivation. Cultural factors would attract voters who openly reject another consequence of neo-liberal globalization: immigration and increasingly multicultural societies. In both approaches, voting for the radical right constitutes a form of protest. More recent research seems to agree that cultural factors outweigh economic ones, but the two positions are more complementary than exclusive because social and economic concerns can be translated into cultural approaches. Radical-right parties link social and economic unrest to immigration; they then offer the simple solution that limiting the number of immigrants would put an end to economic problems.

Third, is the rise of the radical right a strictly national–local phenomenon or a global process? Arguments for its global nature generally prioritize the ‘demand’ side of radical-right politics, while localist approaches emphasize the ‘supply’ side of party proposals, organization and leadership capacity. The globalists build their argument on the weighty consequences of neo-liberal globalization, which compel the ‘losers’ to punish traditional parties by voting for radical-right groups. These arguments, however, do not adequately account for globalized countries such as Japan, which do not have successful radical-right parties. Meanwhile more localist views emphasize aspects related to the electoral system and the legal framework of each country. The idea that majoritarian local systems like those of the United States and Brazil create an insurmountable barrier to these parties has been called into question. Broadly speaking it seems clear that the explanation must be found in the combination of both views. We are clearly witnessing a particularly intense radical-right wave with shared transnational elements. However, political ‘supply’ factors are central: in some contexts high unemployment and immigration do not constitute a ‘threat’ to national unity until a leader or a new party defines them as such. But in doing so the radical right always works on fertile soil and tends to take advantage of a public opinion primed by the media or traditional party leaders.

Despite local radical-right contexts and expressions in each country, the current wave shares a series of elements. Alongside the continuities with the radical right of the 1980s and ’90s, new elements have gained special relevance in recent years.

One of them is nativism, an approach rooted in the final years of the Cold War. It generally argues that only native-national members should live in each country; non-natives (and therefore non-nationals) represent potential threats to the survival and development of the state and the nation. In Spain slogans such as ‘Spain for the Spaniards’ and ‘Spaniards First’ represent this line of thought and are roughly equivalent to Nigel Farage’s ‘We want our country back’ and the Freedom Party of Austria’s ‘Austria First’. Of course, the most representative of them was ‘America First’, uttered dozens of times by Donald Trump during his first presidency. Cas Mudde contends that the goal of the radical right is to establish an ethnocracy: a democracy in which citizenship is based on ethnicity. From this springs the determination to build a monocultural state that, in extreme

versions, could ultimately place immigrants in a dilemma of assimilation or expulsion from the political community.

For the radical right and the far right, immigration and integration are closely intertwined and generally constitute a threat to the nation. These processes began to accelerate during the 1990s when traditionally emigrant countries – Italy, Spain, Greece – became receiving countries, and have continued to develop rapidly across Europe. From 1990 to 2020, the immigrant population increased from 7.4 to 15.8 per cent of the total population in Germany; from 6.4 to 14.2 per cent in the United Kingdom; from 2.5 to 10.5 per cent in Italy; and from 2.1 to 12.9 per cent in Spain. In this context Steven Forti in his book *Extrema derecha 2.0* (2021) pointed out that social perceptions about the weight of the foreign population in Europe are also increasingly removed from reality. In Italy most citizens believe that the foreign population accounts for 30 per cent of the country's total inhabitants, and in Spain the perception is 20 per cent. This tendency intensifies in Eastern Europe: Poles believe that foreigners represent 10 per cent of the country's total population, but the real figures barely exceed 1 per cent. These perceptions are fundamental for casting radical-right approaches. The 'great replacement' theory formulated by Renaud Camus, which Éric Zemmour applies to France – and the Vox party references in Spain – undergirds many of their anti-immigration arguments. These two French intellectuals base their theses about the West being destroyed by an 'avalanche' of foreign immigration on an antisemitic, racist tradition dating back to the nineteenth century. The 'invasion' is not caused, in their view, by inequality or poverty but by progressive politicians who create what in Spain has been insistently labelled as a 'call effect', an exponentially increasing migration because of the facilities supposedly offered in the countries of arrival that would make migration more attractive to potential migrants: a 'word-of-mouth' effect whereby each migrant would attract more and more migrants in the future. Viktor Orbán contends that this vision was projected through a global conspiracy masterminded by the billionaire George Soros, who is of Jewish origin. These arguments resemble those put forward in the libelous antisemitic work *The Protocols of the Elders of Zion* (1903) and generally do not distinguish between citizens and non-citizens when it comes to distinguishing natives from 'foreigners'.

Nativism also clearly influences radical-right positions on gender and sexuality, which target 'native' women in their propaganda. The traditional heterosexual family is considered a foundational element of the nation, and women's reproductive rights and autonomy are therefore limited to the reproduction of the nation. Their mission is directly related to the survival of the threatened nation. Not surprisingly Viktor Orbán's 2020 amendment to the Hungarian Constitution defined the family as a unit 'based on marriage and the relationship between parents and children'. These ideas upheld the 'constitutional identity' of a nation founded on 'Christian culture'. The most conservative views are found in Eastern Europe, while other groups in Western Europe propose and even promote women working outside the home (so long as they look after their children). However, some groups in northern Europe are openly in favour of women's rights, do not prioritize motherhood and claim that gender equality has already been achieved in their countries. Regardless of these differences, most radical-right groups take a very critical view of contemporary feminism. They often argue that it has gone too far and is no longer needed. Moreover, as Steven Forti cited in his 2021 work, they denounce the lack of freedom of Muslim women and the threat of 'the end of women's rights', as Marine Le Pen stated in 2015.

Authoritarianism constitutes another characteristic element of radical-right ideology. Most groups contend that the social order is under constant threat and prescribe severe punishment for the sources of that menace; these range from 'sexual deviance' to education in schools. Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart in their co-authored *Cultural Backlash: Trump, Brexit, and Authoritarian Populism* (2019) describe how authoritarian values tend to focus on three elements: security against risks of instability and disorder (the dangers of immigration, the threat of terrorism), preserving traditional community values ('us' defending 'European values' threatened by 'them') and obedience to strong leaders to protect the group and its customs. Together these 'politics of fear' lead to a quest for a perpetually threatened collective security. The novelty of the twenty-first century compared to the 1980s, for example, is the link between these two elements and terrorism. For the far right and radical right, terrorism is directly tied to immigration and multiculturalism.

Threats to the 'natural order' and the nation range from feminism and sexual identities to unemployment and crime; but the populist, radical-right

obsession with security transcends physical or criminal issues. Using arguments directly linked to minorities (nativism) and elites (populism), progressive politicians are blamed for a supposed tolerance that has encouraged crime. The solution involves developing repressive policies that nearly always target non-natives. The most glaring example of this was the creation of the Victims of Immigration Crime Engagement (VOICE) Office within the Department of Homeland Security during the first presidency of Donald Trump.

The third standard feature of radical-right ideology is populism as a direct consequence of globalization, with its outsourcing, automation, job losses and declining incomes for the middle classes. We saw in the previous chapter how some analysts have identified populist voters as the losers of globalization, but the ideology and attitudes of populist leaders also play a central role. Given the need to link demand and supply perspectives, as discussed earlier, the populist radical right is more than a mere outcome of the social and economic changes resulting from globalization.

In the Introduction, we pointed out that there is no such thing as a theory of populism. Authors such as Cas Mudde and Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser in their *Populism: A Very Short Introduction* (2017) describe it as a thin, imprecise and chameleonic ideology that divides society into two homogeneous and antagonistic groups: the pure people and the corrupt elite. Nonetheless its impact has been transversal and profound, to the point that the Bulgarian political scientist Ivan Krastev even refers to our time as the ‘age of populism’. Mudde has described populism as an ‘illiberal democratic response to undemocratic liberalism’ that exposes the problems of liberal democracy. Broadly speaking it defends ‘majoritarianism’ and a tendency towards illiberal forms of democracy in the name of popular sovereignty. The influence of the visions of intellectuals such as Chantal Mouffe and Ernesto Laclau on left-wing populism during the early years of Podemos, Syriza, Occupy Wall Street and other European experiences stemming from the 2008 crisis is widely known. While the political potential of populist approaches on the left has declined in recent years, they have become fundamental to the radical-right platform.

Federico Finchelstein describes populism and participation as two fundamental elements in current discussions among populist theorists. The political scientist Nadia Urbinati in *Me the People: How Populism Transforms Democracy* (2019) argues that populism ‘disfigures’, corrupts

and endangers democracy in its appeal to plebiscitary democracy. Pierre Rosanvallon bases the populist theory of democracy on three elements: the preference for direct democracy, a polarized and hyper-electoralist vision of popular sovereignty that rejects intermediaries and seeks to adapt institutions accordingly, and appropriation of the general will to the degree it is susceptible to spontaneous expression. Much of the populist radical right argues that politics should express the 'general will', which has been hijacked by governments and institutions.

In addition to being anti-elitist, populism also has a tendency towards anti-pluralism. Populists consider themselves the only ones who can claim moral representation of the people, so those who are not with them are the anti-people. According to Jan-Werner Müller, 'any remainder can be dismissed as immoral and not properly a part of the people at all.' The politics of recent years reflect a polarized democracy that can drift towards increasingly authoritarian power. 'We are the people,' said the Pegida movement in June 2017. 'We are returning the power of Washington to you, the American people,' Donald Trump had claimed on 20 January of the same year. Months later in the French presidential elections, Marine Le Pen spoke of the need to 'liberate the French people from an arrogant elite'. In this context the idea of a single, homogeneous and true people can result in a dangerous fantasy that encourages and feeds on ongoing polarization. Almost half of the British electorate were excluded by Nigel Farage's claim that the triumph of Leave had been a 'victory of the true people'. The same thing occurred with the constant appeal to *un sol poble*, 'a single people', during the pro-independence movement in Catalonia.

These three elements of nativism, authoritarianism and populism are fundamental to developing radical-right approaches to foreign policy. The transnational, even global, phenomenon has its own network of think tanks, foundations, associations, institutes and the like to develop national expressions from Budapest to Brussels, Moscow to Brasilia, Warsaw to Washington. While they do not reject pursuing international cooperation, each is fundamentally concerned for its own nation. Paradoxically Donald Trump's 'America First' slogan-symbol was a national call that became transnational. This tension between the national and the international explains why the radical right finds it difficult to develop stable parliamentary groups in Europe.

After several attempts and Jean-Marie Le Pen's failed EuroNat, a far-right political alliance, the European Alliance for Freedom was created in 2010, a right-wing and Eurosceptic political group. Its short life was fraught with tensions among member nations. Although several radical-right parties had won the 2014 European elections in their countries, Marine Le Pen, who led the project, did not manage to form a new official group until 2015, when it was renamed the Europe of Nations and Freedom. However, after moderate success in the 2019 elections, the new group that replaced it was more aligned with Matteo Salvini than with Marine Le Pen. His intervention was key to the new coalition founded in May of that year: the European Alliance of Peoples and Nations, a right-wing, populist alliance, which after the elections became Identity and Democracy. This parliamentary group competed with the European Conservatives and Reformists for representation of the European radical right. The first group was led by Lega and included the French National Rally, Alternative for Germany (AfD) and the Freedom Parties of Austria and the Netherlands. The second was headed by the Polish PiS and had many formations from the East, along with Sweden Democrats, Brothers of Italy and Spain's Vox party.

Since Viktor Orbán's party left the European People's Party group in March 2021, attempts to build a European supergroup have been relentless. A meeting took place in Warsaw in December 2021, attended by Orbán; the president of Poland's PiS; Le Pen of National Rally; Martin Helme, president of the Estonian Conservative People's Party (EKRE); Tom Van Grieken, president of Flemish Interest (Vlaams Belang); and Santiago Abascal of Vox. The next one was held in late January 2022 in Madrid. Despite divided positions regarding the potential Russian invasion of Ukraine – which materialized a few weeks later – Abascal hosted the meetings in a new attempt to unify the two parliamentary groups. The outbreak of the war launched by Putin seems to have pushed fulfilment of this objective somewhat out of reach, but it cannot be entirely ruled out. Important differences coexist alongside shared perspectives regarding the fight against the European federalist project as well as the globalist drift of the Brussels bureaucracy and its immigration policy. The stated aim in the joint declaration that came out of that meeting was to defend a 'Europe respectful of the sovereignty, freedom and traditions of the Member States'. After decades of proposals related to leaving the European Union and the

euro, most of the radical right has nuanced its positions and managed to become normalized in the process.

In fact, normalization and increased media visibility are among the great accomplishments of the radical right since their incorporation into parliaments and the political arena. For over a decade, the mainstream media has been increasingly promoting radical-right issues with policies that normalize their approaches. This was observed in the British *Daily Express* in relation to UKIP and Fox News during the Trump presidency. It was not just right-wing or fringe media; the *Wall Street Journal* went so far as to officially support Bolsonaro in the 2018 Brazilian presidential election.

Social media has been central to this normalization process. For over a decade, social scientists such as Manuel Castells and journalists like Paul Mason celebrated the end of traditional social barriers and a future of collaboration and transparency on an Internet that had favoured the emergence of the Arab Spring, the Indignados movement and the politicized hacking of Anonymous and WikiLeaks. Everything seemed to change when Donald Trump came to power, though it was not so sudden as it seemed. Social media had grown stale from excessive political correctness and had become integral to what Shoshana Zuboff called ‘surveillance capitalism’ in 2019. Twitter, now known as X, and Instagram were key in the emergence of Donald Trump, who used social media in four ways: pre-emptively (he always tried to be the first to promote and frame an idea), as a distraction (to divert public attention), as a diversion (to attack the messenger) and to ‘test the waters’ for a controversial idea. His presidency was awash in fake news from the very first day, when his chief advisor, Kellyanne Conway, coined the concept of ‘alternative facts’ to deny that fewer people had attended Trump’s inauguration than Barack Obama’s. Conspiracy theories began to proliferate, many driven by QAnon, which emerged from the 4chan forum and fed the movements against vaccinations and restrictions implemented by most governments during the COVID-19 pandemic that broke out in March 2020. Many of the positions put forward in 2016 about lawmakers who were hiding ‘the truth’ concerning Brexit and about the ‘great replacement’ theory grew into protests about the ‘health dictatorship’ in the autumn of 2020. Vox was no stranger to the process and largely followed the policies of Trump, Bolsonaro, Modi, Le Pen and Salvini.

Spain has often been considered an outlier among large Western European countries. In 1997, the political scientist Herbert Kitschelt stated that Spanish exceptionalism stemmed from the fact that it did not yet have a post-industrial economy where most of the employed population worked in the service sector. Other researchers attributed it to the still-relevant weight of the persisting memory of the Franco dictatorship. However, the new Spanish radical right began to develop in the first decade of the twenty-first century. In the 2003 municipal elections, four candidates from *Plataforma per Catalunya* (Platform for Catalonia, *PxC*), the party most comparable to the radical right that was consolidating across Europe, were elected as councillors after campaigning for 'greater immigration control'. The party grew and obtained seventeen councillors in the 2007 municipal elections. Its best results occurred four years later when 77 councillors were voted in. Although it received only half as many votes in 2015 and disappeared a couple of years later, it received considerable media attention and managed to introduce important novelties into the Spanish far-right vocabulary. *PxC* adopted a highly Islamophobic discourse that defended the welfare state in nativist tones. To defend an identity and social cohesion threatened by immigration, it combined regionalism, or even Catalan self-determination, with obsessive denunciation of the insecurity caused by immigrants. The contrast was described not in national terms but as a distinction between immigrants and natives. A particular combination of xenophobia, opposition to the multiculturalist establishment and chauvinistic defence of the welfare state clearly placed the party in the new European radical right. Its contacts with the National Front, *Lega Nord*, the Flemish Bloc and the Freedom Party of Austria developed in tandem with its growth in Catalonia.

The birth of Vox occurred simultaneously with the decline of *PxC*. Alejo Vidal-Quadras, José Antonio Ortega Lara, Santiago Abascal and a few others sought to create a current within the Popular Party (*Partido Popular*, *PP*), what Miguel González called the 'true *PP*'. These individuals became the nucleus of Vox. The leadership of Santiago Abascal soon became apparent. Cas Mudde and Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser described him as a 'false newcomer'.

Born in 1976 into a politically active family in Bilbao, Abascal's grandfather was a Francoist mayor of Amurrio (Álava, Spain) and his father had served as a Popular Alliance deputy for Álava in the Spanish Parliament. Abascal joined the *PP* at the age of eighteen, made a name for

himself in Álava, became president of PP's New Generations of the Basque Country, a member of the party's National Board of Directors, a member of its Basque Country executive, Secretary of Education in the Basque Country and regional deputy in the Basque Parliament. In 2013 Abascal left the party, arguing irreconcilable differences with Mariano Rajoy's leadership in relation to terrorist policy. In December 2013, he and nine others founded Vox. After several electoral failures, the party obtained 10.9 per cent of the vote and twelve deputies in the Andalusian regional elections on 2 December 2018. Vox entered a phase of meteoric growth and by November 2019 had become the third force in the national Congress of Deputies, with more than 15 per cent of the vote.

In many ways, Vox was the local expression of a global phenomenon. Like all the other cases, local and circumstantial factors were key to its exponential development from 2018 onwards. The Catalan secessionist crisis, which reached its peak in October 2017, became the central issue for Vox, which grew parallel to the formation of the socialist government in May 2018 under Pedro Sánchez. After the Andalusian parliamentary elections, Vox achieved similar results in the national legislative elections of April 2019, which gave the party 24 deputies. The following month, it emerged from the triple elections with representation in nine regional parliaments, along with 530 local councillors and 6.2 per cent of the votes for the European Parliament. On 10 November it became the third power in Congress with about 3.7 million votes (15.1 per cent of the total) and 52 deputies. It obtained similar distinction in the elections to the regional parliament of Castile and León in February 2022. There, the thirteen Vox deputies were decisive to the Popular Party's Alfonso Fernández Mañueco becoming president. Regional Vox leader Juan García-Gallardo was appointed vice president on 20 April, and Vox was given three regional councillorships.

Vox's success in Castile and León revealed several things. First, debate about the cordon sanitaire did not even arise in Spain, as it had in France, Germany and Sweden. Four years after its first step towards normalizing the party in December 2018, when the Andalusian Popular Party leader Juan Manuel Moreno Bonilla became president there, Vox was in government with the vice-presidency of Castile and León in 2022.

Xavier Casals observes how Vox incorporated issues from the Popular Party platform into its proposals and radicalized them, emphasizing

rejection of abortion, same-sex marriage and laws on historical memory (the public narratives on Spanish traumatic past). It adopted traditional Spanish far-right themes – the Spanishness of Gibraltar, opposition to the autonomous communities – along with European far-right issues aligned with the Visegrád group: immigration control, Islamophobia, denouncing a supposed ‘gender ideology’ and Euroscepticism. Then it imported some Trumpist ideas, making culture wars central and proposing that Morocco should pay for a wall to be built in Ceuta and Melilla, both in North Africa but part of Spain. The victory of the U.S. multimillionaire Trump in 2016 and the growth of the new radical right under his presidency empowered local conditions and removed any lingering complexes for European radical-right leaders. Vox joined the process by seeking to insert itself into the transnational networks that Trump was developing.

Like much of the European radical right, Vox combined elements of continuity with the ideas of groups such as the National Front, *pxc* and the wave of new approaches in the 2010s. The ideological mutation from its founding manifesto of 2014 to full incorporation into the European and international radical right became evident in January 2017, when Vox joined Marine Le Pen, Frauke Petry and Geert Wilders at a meeting of the European radical right in Germany. In March 2018, some of Vox’s top leaders met with Steve Bannon, chief strategist for the White House during Trump’s first presidency, who stamped his approval on Abascal’s party.

Vox successfully selected controversial topics and combined them in clearly innovative ways. Astrid Barrio in 2019 described a party discourse based on nativism, traditionalism, anti-feminism, securitarianism-authoritarianism, economic liberalism, moderate Euroscepticism and exacerbated nationalism. As with other European radical-right parties, its nativist ideology focuses on the fight against internal (separatism, especially Catalan nationalism) and external (globalism and immigration) enemies in the quest to achieve a monocultural, nationally homogeneous state. Its traditionalism defends values threatened by cultural and moral disintegration. Accordingly, much party policy is aimed at denouncing laws on sexual and reproductive health and legislative attempts to recognize diverse gender identities, all of which it considers ‘gender ideology’. As showed by the political scientist Carles Ferreira, Vox’s securitarianism-authoritarianism relates directly to these traditional values. It perceives that

Spain, like Europe as a whole, is threatened both by immigration and by those who seek to destroy it from within.

Neo-liberalism is another defining Vox trait that creates a fundamental point of divergence. The party staunchly defends the free market, individual economic freedom and private property. It openly distances itself from the ‘welfare chauvinism’ of the French National Rally and the traditionally progressive positions of European radical-right parties and expressions on economic matters such as protectionism, reindustrialization and defending job security. Vox also digresses from other radical-right parties in its perspective on the European Union. Its moderate Euroscepticism has always been much less belligerent than that of groups such as the French National Rally or Matteo Salvini’s Lega Nord. In the 2021 document *Agenda España*, Vox advocated ‘recovering judicial sovereignty’ and ‘proclaiming the primacy of national law over European law in matters that affect the common good of Spain and the general interests of the State’. It also called for a new European treaty ‘that gives Member States the leading role again’, as opposed to a European Commission ‘that no one elects’. Additionally, it demanded that international relations be undertaken exclusively by Member States and ‘all foreign political representation of regions and municipalities’ abolished. As we have seen these ideas were closely related to the mutation that had been observed in much of the European radical right in the three years prior.

The final and most relevant characteristic of Vox discourse is the strong nationalist, mythical and historicist component found in all its approaches. Its conception of what is Spanish corresponds closely to a series of ethnonational myths. Unlike other party discourses based on the civic value of an often-sacralized constitution, Vox projects a vision strongly anchored in historical episodes such as the ‘discovery’ of the Americas or the ‘reconquest’ of Spain by the Catholic monarchs in the Middle Ages. At the heart of its approach are the Christian roots of the nation, always in confrontation with the Muslim ‘other’. Abascal’s party appeals to an ‘Iberosphere’, a common space with Latin American countries and Spanish-speaking communities that can act as a counterweight to the European Union and a projection of Spanish influence. It would also provide a cultural counterweight to left-wing pan-Iberian organizations like the São Paulo Forum and the Puebla Group.

Vox's historicist, mythical and ultranationalist vision has its particularities. It makes very little reference to recent periods in Spain's history such as the Second Republic, the Civil War, Francoism or the transition to democracy. Since achieving regional and national electoral representation, Vox has distanced itself from Francoism and the violent right of the 1980s and '90s. The clearest demonstration of this was observed during the events that took place in the Valley of the Fallen in October 2019. Despite its criticism of the Sanchez government for reopening debates that the party considered sterile, there was no Vox representative in attendance during the transfer of the remains of Francisco Franco from the national monument he built as his mausoleum to his family plot in a private cemetery. However, the party's meteoric growth and absorption of members from various far-right organizations have complicated this distancing. Indeed, the absence of references to Francoism does not indicate an absence of ties between Vox leaders and that regime. The ambiguity regarding Francoism has led Vox to stand against Spain's recent laws on historical memory, which aim to recognize the victims of its Civil War and give them and their descendants rights, using arguments resembling those of the Popular Party. Not surprisingly, the accords between the two parties in Castile and León included the repeal of the Historical Memory Law (2007), as a way of 'vindicating our common history, understood as an integrating element for reconciliation, combating any attempt by those who try to use it to divide Spaniards'.

All these elements force us to ask ourselves again: who are Vox voters and how do they differ from those who vote for European radical-right parties? José Rama, Lisa Zanotti, Stuart Turnbull-Dugarte and Andrés Santana contend that Vox voter profiles are similar to those who support the radical right in Western Europe: mainly young men with low educational levels for whom democracy is not a relevant value. Data provided by the Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas (CIS) in April 2022 indicated the party's highly masculinized electoral potential: nearly 70 per cent of those who said they sympathized with Vox were men. The party constituents, however, are not in a situation of great economic hardship. Vicente Rubio-Pueyo reveals that votes for Vox come mostly from neighbourhoods with higher income levels and areas with a strong military presence. So far Vox voters are not the losers of globalization. The Vox perspective on Europe also differentiates it from its European peers. Because it originated from a

break with the Popular Party, Euroscepticism is markedly lower in Vox than in many other formations we have analysed. The same can be said of party views on the economy: its libertarian and neo-liberal ideas attract voters much more aligned with expressions led by Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro than with the French National Rally.

Vox is currently focused on the struggle against the ‘globalist agenda’, which supposedly entails the destruction of the middle class, family life, shared Western roots and the sovereignty of nations while also intensifying the ‘cancel culture’ and censorship of freedom of expression. In international politics, Vox remains firmly anchored in Atlanticism and has clearly aligned itself with the Polish far right and the Visegrád group in their generic opposition to greater European integration, their defence of a community of sovereign and ‘free nations’, and their demand for a new European treaty that would devolve leadership to the Member States and defend the history, traditions and Christian identity of Europe. Brazil’s Eduardo Bolsonaro, Argentina’s Javier Milei, Hungary’s Viktor Orbán and other leaders of the post-fascist right greet these ideas enthusiastically. Trumpist Ted Cruz, who had met with Vox’s top leaders in Washington just before the outbreak of the pandemic in 2020, stated that ‘we are facing an emboldened global left that seeks to tear down cherished national and religious institutions, and in too many cases, violently.’

Vox participated in the Group of European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR) alongside the Brothers of Italy and the Polish PiS. Ideologically Vox has been much more aligned with the parties of Giorgia Meloni, Marion Maréchal and Viktor Orbán than with Marine Le Pen, Matteo Salvini or Identity and Democracy. Though the party officially denies it, figures close to Vox have been instrumental in opening Maréchal’s Institut de Sciences Sociales, Économiques et Politiques (ISSEP) in Madrid. All things considered, it seems clear that Vox cannot be understood outside the global wave that has been forming for more than a decade.

In many senses the most relevant element of the processes we have considered in these pages can be conceptualized in the notion of the ‘normalization’ of the far-right movements and leaders. Normalization enabled radical-right parties to increase parliamentary representation, lead governments, participate in coalitions or support presidents from the outside. Their political weight is much greater now than it was twenty years ago, which leads to the obvious question: has anything changed with

respect to late twentieth-century radical-right voters? The question must be prefaced with the awareness that some currently consolidated processes are rooted in prior decades and are fundamental to explaining the current radical-right vote and its voters. These include the dissolution of class identities linked to factories and unions, the conversion of metropolitan environs into migrant ghettos, deindustrialization in heavily populated areas, competition in precarious labour markets that expel migrants from certain areas, diminishing expectations of social mobility and perceptions of traditional left-wing (and other) formations as out of touch with workers' concerns.

It is common to read that the model European far-right voter is Western, white, male, young-ish, has a low-to-medium educational level and is worried about immigration – however, this conception is only a stereotype. There is ample evidence to support the 'two-headed electorate' concept formulated by the scholars Daniel Oesch and Line Rennwald. They describe how the radical-right constituency reflects a combination of manual and salaried service workers with small business owners. In Europe it is quite difficult to establish common parameters for all countries. Differences appear between Western European countries and those of the former Communist Bloc, but also among the founding Member States of the European Union.

Fragmentation among radical-right voters is another key element. Political scientists seem to agree that the more popular a political party becomes, the more diverse its electoral base. Radical-right parties have only grown in the last two decades: from 1990 to 2009 the far-right obtained an average of 4.4 to 4.7 per cent of the vote in national elections of the EU Member States, but since then the figures have doubled. Vote fragmentation also contains a rural–urban dichotomy, which was especially relevant in the elections that brought Trump to power. This is linked to social issues, which have gained prominence in European election campaigns. The decline of manufacturing and the legacy of Fordist economies now in extinction create pockets of potential radical-right voters. However, the connection between the economic situation and the preference for disruptive options is not necessarily linear. The poorest in a society do not always choose to rebel against the system, not even through the ballot box. In fact, as Yascha Mounk argued in *The People vs. Democracy: Why Our Freedom Is in Danger and How to Save It*, economic anxiety is rooted more in forecasting

a future scenario than in present experience. Here, sectors of the population who still live in relative material comfort have greatest cause for concern. This aspect is especially relevant for understanding the importance of the age factor. In the Brexit vote, for example, young people were mostly opposed to Leave and UKIP.

Since the publication of Ronald Inglehart's book on postmaterialist values, *The Silent Revolution* (1977), analysts have been studying the radical-right vote from socio-economic and cultural angles. Now it seems that voters no longer decide based on social and economic preferences alone but also according to their values. The growth of welfare states has allowed voters to move beyond basic needs to issues such as environmentalism, feminism, the nation or immigration. In this context, education levels rather than economic factors become a more useful indication of likely political sympathies: according to Steven Forti, voters for the National Rally in France and AfD for Germany had the lowest levels of formal education in both countries. Britain and the United States confirm this trend: 75 per cent of people without post-secondary education voted for Leave and 64 per cent of whites without college education voted for Trump in 2016. According to Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart, voters for radical-right parties are concentrated among ethnic majorities and older, less-educated men who tend to be more religious. These tendencies were confirmed in November 2024, when Donald Trump was elected by more than 77 million Americans, though among his voters was a considerable percentage of Hispanic, Black and young people.

Latin America: the latest comer

After the fall of the Augusto Pinochet dictatorship in Chile in 1990, Latin America viewed the far right as a distant phenomenon, something that happened in Europe due to political conflicts occurring there.

First, the academic literature affirmed that a direct link could not be established because the comparatively low immigration in Latin America significantly limited the success of the main far-right approaches. However, some academics found this argument problematic, noting that in most Eastern European countries – which had not received many migrants – far-right parties had begun to show electoral growth, especially since the 2008 crisis.

Second, despite the characteristically xenophobic positions of the European and American far right, it would be reductionist to consider this the only defining feature.

Finally, it seems clear now that the far right has indeed landed in Latin America. The turning point came with the emergence of Donald Trump in 2016 and the triumph of Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil two years later. Neither leader was re-elected for an immediate second term though both obtained significant numbers of votes, despite their terrible management of the COVID-19 pandemic and the bleak economic balance at the end of their respective governments. From their impetus (and that of the European far-right wave) while in government, comparable forces began to gain ground across the continent, such as Nayib Bukele (Nuevas Ideas, NI) in El Salvador, José Antonio Kast (Republican Party) in Chile, Rafael López-Aliaga (Renovación Popular) in Peru and Guido Manini Ríos (Cabildo Abierto) in Uruguay. Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser has explained how this process was also fundamental to the triumph of Javier Milei and his party, La Libertad Avanza, in Argentina in 2023.

How did it come to this? After the neo-liberal and populist 1990s of Argentinian President Carlos Menem, Peru's Alberto Fujimori and Brazil's Fernando Collor de Mello, the first decade of the twenty-first century was a kind of golden age for the left in Latin America. One might think that the prevalent and high socioeconomic inequalities of the region would give the left an electoral advantage over the right. It was hard to imagine that the right could win elections with its usual offer, based on the idea that the invisible hand of the free market could solve the pervasive problems of poverty and inequality on its own. However, new groups and leaders in tune with the reflections of the European new radical right – significantly, the contributions of Alain de Benoist and the Nouvelle Droite – began to articulate their proposals for addressing these problems. They developed sociocultural themes that helped activate latent citizen demands around issues such as abortion, same-sex marriage or indigenous peoples. According to Pablo Stefanoni, the Latin American 'new right' effectively sought to distinguish itself from both the left and the conventional right through deliberate attacks on political correctness and by critiquing ideas considered to be progressive. It has shaped new political projects defined by collective institutional and extra-institutional mobilization to reverse rights promoted by previously marginalized communities and groups – such as

abortion or sex education in schools – while restoring and promoting supposedly traditional political, social, economic and cultural rights. In this way, as shown in an article published by Lindsay Mayka and Amy Smith in the journal *Latin America Politics and Society*, it seeks to maintain social hierarchies perceived as natural or national, including patriarchy and the subordination of LGBTIQ+ and indigenous individuals. Much more than the migration issue, the ‘new right’ works to win the support of morally conservative populist sectors by politicizing the sociocultural dimension over the socio-economic dimension. The weight of the evangelical Christian population in several Latin American countries makes this issue particularly relevant.

Like many other countries in that geography, Brazil has suffered several consecutive episodes of economic crisis since the fall of President Fernando Collor de Mello in late 1992. However, political instability was not a defining element until Lula da Silva’s second term ended in December 2010. After completing a first term as president, Dilma Rousseff, Lula’s successor in the Workers’ Party (PT), was impeached in August 2016. Aécio Neves, president of the Brazilian Social Democracy Party (PSDB), was about to defeat Rousseff at the polls when he became implicated in corruption scandals. The same occurred with Vice President Michel Temer of the Brazilian Democratic Movement Party (PMDB), who took office after the dismissal of Lula’s successor. Neves and Temer were thus ruled out of the 2018 presidential elections and caught up in Operation Car Wash: a police investigation involving corruption on a colossal scale. This left a political vacuum which facilitated the success of a political outsider. With populist rhetoric and an ‘us against them’ discourse, Jair Bolsonaro seized the moment to enter the race for the presidency. The failure of the traditional right to mitigate the economic problems leading to Rousseff’s impeachment, as well as its involvement in corruption scandals, decisively influenced the rise of the far right in Brazil.

Though very favourably positioned in the polls by mid-2017, Bolsonaro’s competitors did not yet take him seriously. With no political party to back him, he lacked the most important electoral resources. Nonetheless, with strong and consistent rhetoric, intelligent use of social media, and the loyal, enthusiastic support of a growing group of followers, he managed to win the 2018 elections. Grounded in very conservative ideological positions, Bolsonaro became the far right in Brazil. He

instrumentalized the rejection and resentment felt towards the main political parties, especially the PT and the left, who were imprecisely denounced as 'communists'. Bolsonaro, a former army captain who began his career in politics after being tried and acquitted by a military tribunal for planning terrorist acts as a pressure tactic to obtain a salary increase, became Michel Temer's successor.

Bolsonaro's Brazil was partially the result of the amnesty granted to the military personnel who had kidnapped, tortured and executed people during the dictatorship that ruled the country from 1964 to 1985. Once in power he promoted a very conservative national agenda spanning several political dimensions. In keeping with international far-right trends, he advocated the rejection of progressive cultural positions, an economic agenda favouring less state intervention, categorical opposition to any positive discrimination towards the Black population, and a zero-tolerance, 'iron-fist' policy on crime and corruption. He also deployed nativist social policies such as conditional cash transfer programmes. Bolsonaro's strong, coherent far-right rhetoric resonated with a portion of the public. His stances on abortion and gay rights, according to Timothy Power and Wendy Hunter, along with his violent opposition to crime – his campaign symbol was a two-handed gun imitation, with thumbs up and index fingers pointing straight out – were instrumental in expanding social support.

Among the most controversial and constant issues on Bolsonaro's agenda was the fight against gender equality and LGBTIQ+. He repeatedly related homosexuality to a disease that could be cured through strict discipline by the father, a strong male figure. He adopted positions that were clearly detrimental to women's rights in the labour market and strongly opposed legalizing abortion. In these aspects the sociocultural dimension of his agenda clearly digressed from that of the traditional right.

Rhetoric against the PT and the left in general was another defining feature of the Bolsonaro era. He associated it with anticommunism, exalting Brazil's armed forces (especially its army) and the 1964 coup. From his point of view the military had prevented the communist forces from taking over Brazil. His anti-communism also had obvious religious connotations, as it was directly linked to defending the traditional family and God. As stated by Latin America researcher Ariel Goldstein in 2019, these were the pillars of his political and cultural vision.

During his presidency Bolsonaro somewhat unexpectedly – though in direct correlation with a global wave – adopted a position of strong scientific denialism. According to Federico Finchelstein, as with Trump or Milei, it became one of his hallmarks after the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic in March 2020. He advocated alternative treatments; opposed social distancing, mask-wearing and lockdowns; and actively participated in illegal demonstrations during lockdown. His attitude was so radical that he was fined in the state of São Paulo for not wearing a mask in public places. For Bolsonaro, politicizing the pandemic was a way to keep conflict active as an element of his political style. It was central to his populist rhetoric of confrontation against a supposedly global progressive establishment; but when the fourth and fifth waves of the pandemic hit the country hard in early 2021, the disaster created by his measures damaged his image and led to a sharp drop in popularity. With the threat of electoral defeat looming on the horizon, the temptation to promote authoritarian solutions intensified.

Though Bolsonaro had oscillated between radical populism and the extreme right throughout his presidency, as he faced the growing threat of losing re-election and being put on trial for various challenges to the law during his term, he moved ever closer to the extreme right. This sense of deep democratic crisis marked the 2022 Brazilian elections, when defending and attacking the regime became an issue, bolstered again by the self-exclusionary rhetoric of friends and enemies.

Since his electoral defeat to Lula in October 2022, events have not favoured Bolsonaro. He remained silent about the attacks on the Federal Police Building in downtown Brasilia on 12 December 2022, when the elected representatives received their ratifying diplomas. He fled Brazil for Miami on 30 December to avoid transferring power to Lula. Finally he had to defend himself repeatedly over his participation in the assault on the Three Powers Square in Brasilia on 8 January 2023. These events marked the lowest point of Brazilian democracy since the 1964 coup. Even though Bolsonaro has been tried and convicted of abusing political power by the Supreme Electoral Court and will not be able to stand for election until 2030, Bolsonarism is alive and well in Brazilian politics. Bolsonaro won 43.2 per cent of the vote in the first round and 49.1 per cent in the second round of elections (the highest of any defeated candidate in Brazil's history) and his Liberal Party has the highest representation in the Chamber of

Deputies. It governs several states, including São Paulo, Minas Gerais and Rio de Janeiro.

Even as Bolsonaro was sinking in Brazil, Javier Milei emerged in Argentina. They had several points of connection and some differences, but no one would think of trying to understand them outside the frame of a global far-right wave.

In Argentina, in the decade dominated by left-wing Peronism expressed in the leadership of Néstor Kirchner and then his wife Cristina, a somewhat populist right-wing ideology and culture began to take shape during the government of the latter. It came onstage in the 2015 elections with the triumph of Cambiemos (Let's Change), a heterogeneous coalition led by the right-wing politician Mauricio Macri. This phenomenon was partially eclipsed by the victory of the Frente de Todos (Everyone's Front) coalition in the 2019 elections. The return to a Peronist government, with Alberto Fernández at the helm, looked nothing like Néstor Kirchner's first term. It quickly fell apart due to various factors: the COVID-19 pandemic, a drought affecting the agricultural sector (which produces most of the country's exports) and heavy speculation by business groups. All this translated into a situation of exponentially increasing poverty and an annual inflation rate that exceeded 130 per cent.

The victory of far-right libertarian Javier Milei with an astonishing 55 per cent of the vote in the second round of elections on 19 November 2023 constituted a massive political earthquake in a country where an outsider candidate had never reached the presidency. Milei had become a representative for the city of Buenos Aires in 2021 under the newly created movement called La Libertad Avanza (Liberty Advances). He managed to overcome the socio-economic barriers affecting votes for the right by reaching the less advantaged layers of society. He also radically altered the country's electoral map: the traditionally strong centre-right opposition in Argentina's agro-industrial 'centre' allowed him to create a distinction between a 'productive' country and one dependent on government assistance. Milei won in 21 of the 24 provinces, spanning the north and the south.

Why was Milei able to seize power? Because, as Pablo Semán and Nicolas Welschinger explain, he managed to generate 'a people'. This was the key element. His anti-caste and pro-market discourse levelled against the two major parties won over voters in the popular sectors. He had a

profound impact among young people and many other groups, from dogmatic anti-progressives reflecting the tendencies of the global radical right to those who emerged from the defeat of Macri, the pandemic and accelerated inflation to consolidate in the streets and on social networks. In many ways the distrust and frustration towards the Argentine state for its poor performance in health, education, security and the economy helped turn Milei's dogmatic anti-statism into a political movement. It attracted those disappointed by Cambiemos, those who had previously voted for the Frente de Todos and especially young people who were voting for the first time, after the pandemic, who saw the state as an enemy that curtailed their individual freedom. In this frame, the right built a sense of identity through open confrontation with a decadent situation associated with the left and with 'the caste'. Milei unified diverse and contradictory elements against a single culprit to forge a 'populism of freedom'. As Leigh Payne and others argued in 2023, he linked his preaching to the experiences of those for whom the choice between 'the right or rights' had lost meaning, because they considered the 'rights' to offer little real assistance. Like Trump, Milei attracts people as much by what he says as the way he says it. His groundbreaking performance was successful because of its positive message: it turned indignation into hope and angry criticism into passionate loyalty.

As stated by Pablo Semán in his 2024 book on the rise of the Argentine politician, Milei's 'people' occupied several strata of society, from anti-Peronists to openly conservative nationalists concerned mainly with the fight against abortion and the Comprehensive Sexual Education Law of 2006. A youth contingent that had been confrontational with the state during the pandemic also emerged in tandem with a precarious, ultra-neo-liberal labour structure. These were 'the people' and the rest were the 'anti-people'. The anti-caste narrative that won Milei the elections persisted in gestures that included turning his back on the legislative chamber, targeting the public sector and postulating an identity in his inaugural speech that did not include all Argentines but only the 'good' ones.

Milei's eccentricities should not hide his paleolibertarian influences, his reactionary anti-statism or his fondness for alt-right clichés, ranging from climate change denial to the dismissal of gender-based violence, to the belief in the supposed dominance of cultural Marxism. Milei's tactics and views are not new. Like far-right politicians everywhere he conjures the

ghosts of communism and alleges that his enemies seek to destroy Western civilization. A glorious past is invented and repeatedly invoked. Far-right politics has a deeply utopian character, continually in search of a 'paradise lost'. Milei draws his intellectual inspiration from a selective reading of the nineteenth-century Argentinian political theorist Juan Bautista Alberdi, who stated that the omnipotence of the state was to deny individual freedom, forgetting his role as a strong defender of collective rights and promoter of public education funded with public money. His economic views are equally dated and uninspiring, rooted in the ideas of the American economist Murray Rothbard (in fact one of his four dogs is named Murray). Rothbard inspired the Libertarian Party in the United States during the Nixon years. Then, as now, it combines anti-statism, anarcho-capitalism, ultra-propertarianism (a reductive approach to law via the right to own property) and reactionarism. As stated by Sergio Morresi and Hugo Ramos in an article of 2023, he combines these with a populist rhetoric, with its talk of 'good Argentines' versus 'the caste', the appeal to shock tactics, and religious and providentialist references.

Milei landed in government without a party, without cadres or technical teams, and without mayors or governors to organize his movement and implement his policies. With an increasingly messianic discourse and defending an epic vision of capitalism akin to that found in Ayn Rand's novel *Atlas Shrugged* (1957), Milei looked for support among the traditional right, managers of large private-sector companies and non-Kirchnerist Peronists, including former officials from Carlos Menem's government. After his first year in government, it remains unclear how he will maintain his libertarian, ultra-liberal discourse and policies in a context of relative internal political instability and with little power in the Congress and the Senate. Though the inflation indicators have provided some respite, and his popularity has not dropped ostensibly, the country's declining production, general impoverishment and numerous fronts of open internal and external conflict do not bode well for the libertarian president. The solution may lie in increasing repression and authoritarianism: in November 2024 his supporters launched Las Fuerzas del Cielo (The Forces of Heaven), a militant wing of his political coalition La Libertad Avanza.

Milei's initiatives are new, and yet not so new. One of his star measures, the Ministry of Human Capital, had already been implemented by Viktor Orbán in 2010. However, like Bolsonaro and Trump, their state-reduction

policies and their alignments illustrate a particularly interesting point of divergence between the Americas and Europe. This radical questioning of parliaments, state structures and liberal democracy itself has marked the future of Trumpism and Bolsonarism as well as the current development of Milei's government. They are responsible for the two most important attempts to end democratic regimes in two main Latin American countries in this century and in the contemporary history of the United States – both coup attempts reveal a violent evolution of the radical right in the Americas that differs from what we observe in Europe. Cancelling liberal democracy and replacing it with a semi-permanent state of exception is the basis of Nayib Bukele's 'punitive populism' model and its influence in Ecuador (despite Jan Topic's recent electoral defeat), Brazil, Chile and Colombia, where Diego Molano (political godson of former President Álvaro Uribe) stands out. Javier Milei participates in this evolution, combining North American paleolibertarianism with El Salvador-style repressive appeals.

The European radical right currently shows different developmental patterns, as seen in the evolution of Giorgia Meloni's government in Italy, the last ten years of the French National Rally, Vox in Spain, or even Poland and Hungary. In all these cases three factors have partially limited the normalization of the radical right and the destructive potential of its policies for liberal democracy. The first is the social state in Western Europe, inherited from the years following the Second World War; it has strengthened states and made the growing social inequalities since the 1980s less intense there than in the Americas. Second, the political cultures – social democracy, communism, Christian democracy – that dominated Western political systems until they imploded after the Great Recession of 2008 did not fundamentally question the need to maintain the welfare state. Meanwhile political evolution in Central and South America was marked by populism, military dictatorships and radical application of Friedman-style postulates, which subsequently weakened their states. Finally, the third factor that has acted to contain the radical right is directly related to the development of a common European project.

While the historical contexts of Latin America and Europe and their societies are different, Bolsonaro and Milei reflect the evolution of an increasingly influential radical right and ultra-right that is already normalized in local contexts. They form part of the fourth wave of the radical right, where conservative, anarcho-libertarian, classical liberal and

nationalist traditions coexist. This was evident in the audience that gathered at Milei's inauguration ceremony at the end of 2023: Bolsonaroists, assorted religious figures, rainbow flagbearers, meritocrats, precarious workers, alternative youth with tattooed arms, those with light skin, those with dark skin, were all there, all looking for a messianic leader. As Milei announced a fall in government debt by five percentage points and promised severe reductions to the size of the state, the crowds on the street called for the chainsaw: *motosierra, motosierra*.

These jubilant scenes speak more of resignation than of a new and hopeful future, and much more of the deep crisis of liberal democracy than expectations of progress. The return of Donald Trump to the presidency of the United States in January 2025 has reinforced Milei's ideas and projected them globally.

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CONCLUSION

With the fall of the Berlin Wall, the idea spread that the future looked brighter than ever – at least better than the twentieth century had been until then. Francis Fukuyama wrote in *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) that it was difficult to think of a future that was not ‘essentially democratic and capitalist’. All that has changed: hope in liberal democracy is very low and the ‘open society’ ideal is being questioned. Ivan Krastev and Stephen Holmes in *The Light that Failed* observe that there were only sixteen border fences on the entire planet in November 1989; today there are more than sixty. A third of the world’s countries are erecting barriers at their borders. Most Europeans and Americans are now convinced that their children’s lives will be worse than theirs.

A study by political scientists Yasha Mounk and Roberto Stefan Foa, which was included in a report published by the Barcelona Centre for International Affairs (CIDOB) in April 2017, indicated that two-thirds of Europeans born after 1980 said they would consider a military coup legitimate if they judged their government to be incompetent or failed. Despite the unavoidable relevance of the generational component, support for democratic values had also been declining among older age groups for a few decades. This data was corroborated by the Washington-based NGO Freedom House in a 1999 report on democracy in the twentieth century. In 1900, 12.4 per cent of humanity was governed by democratic systems with universal male suffrage, 36.6 per cent by absolute monarchies, 19.2 per cent by constitutional monarchies with limited suffrage, and 30.2 per cent were under colonial rule. By the end of the century, 39 per cent of the world’s population lived in free countries, 25 per cent in partially free, and 36 per cent in societies that were not free. Encouraged by the comparison, the president of the institution concluded that ‘the next century will be the century of freedom.’ However, in the first decade of the twenty-first

century, Freedom House warned of a progressive decline in democracy in many former Soviet countries, starting with the Russian Federation itself. Elsewhere analysts were observing the growth of a deep wave of discontent in Western countries. In 2010 *The Economist's* annual Democracy Index report stated that democracy was in retreat. The same report in 2011 stated that worldwide 'stagnation' of democracy had occurred from 2006 to 2008, followed by a phase of 'decline' from 2008 to 2011, primarily in Europe. The outlook worsened in the following decade – the 2015 report was eloquently titled 'Democracy in the Age of Anxiety' – and the impact of the pandemic that began in 2020 has further aggravated the situation. The Democracy Index reports that followed were even worse.

One cause of this, as we have seen, is the impact of policies stemming from the Great Recession that began in 2008. These have assisted the European drift towards what Giovanni Sartori called polarized pluralism: a highly fragmented party system in which the electorate tends to move to extremes. We see it in the emergence of left- and right-wing populist expressions; the Five-Star Movement in Italy; the collapse of the French Socialist Party; the presidencies of Bolsonaro, Modi, Trump and Orbán; the Catalanian pro-independence *procés* and the stellar rise of the Vox party in Spain.

However, to reduce everything down to economic factors would be ill-advised. In 2016, the year of Trump's first election victory, the U.S. economy had seen six consecutive years of growth, with higher rates than nearly all Western countries. The explanation is therefore more complex. The crisis of intermediation between states and parties drives change because the latter cannot fulfil their promises. The digitalization of our daily lives also reveals that these mediating bodies no longer have the authority of the previous era. European centre-right parties used to be seen as stable forces of order, but all versions – Christian Democrats, Conservatives and Liberals – have undergone profound transformations in confronting the populist radical right in recent decades. The long decline of social democracy is also linked to the development of the radical right and other relevant factors. In this crisis of social democracy, however, the conventional right has been unable to stop the rise of radical forces.

The primary element of the current crisis (the erosion of representative ties) is rooted in poor economic conditions, destructive austerity policies, corruption scandals and the loss of credibility among traditional parties.

Liberal democracies are complex systems based on political representation. If this fails, voters tend to lose their usual references and look for new leaders who represent a new project and promise to renew that bond. Through appeals to the 'nation' and 'identity', radical-right parties are often successful because they offer citizens an illusory sense of empowerment.

In this environment the radical right and the far right have grown in Europe and beyond. For some time now the relevant indicators have been pointing to parties and party systems in crisis; and where these are weak, both radical-left and radical-right populist approaches become strong, as was seen in the latest French elections. On 9 April 2022 *El País* published part of an interview with Jean-Jacques, a janitor in Châteaudun. He stated that he would vote for Jean-Luc Mélenchon in the first round, but if that left-wing leader did not make it to the second round, he might vote for Marine Le Pen. 'Anything,' he said, 'except Emmanuel Macron; anything but this European Union and this shitty globalization.' Jean-Jacques expressed what is certainly a widespread tendency in Europe.

The success of political parties and their projects is often measured by the votes they obtain in elections. From that point of view, we could say that the relevance of the radical right is growing but limited. However, if we consider variables such as the ability to introduce issues into local and global political agendas or shape public policy, the landscape changes. Tim Bale and Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser in *Riding the Populist Wave: Europe's Mainstream Right in Crisis* (2021) have shown how the traditional European right has evolved towards clear acceptance of anti-immigration policies and the values of the 'silent counter-revolution'. Radical right-wing parties that have participated in governments have increased their ability to limit or thwart initiatives such as the European Union's refugee resettlement plan. Their influence on the capacity for action of the most relevant international organizations has also been significant: clear examples include the announcement of the U.S. withdrawal from the Paris Agreement on climate change in 2017 and from the UN Human Rights Council in 2018.

Thus the radical right is no longer marginal in the international political context. The French scenario, in which the National Front (now known as National Rally) has been a major force for several decades, now applies to all of Europe. In the last two decades radical-right ideas and policies have escaped the confines of parties we usually label as such. The condemnation of multiculturalism, for example, is no longer limited to Alternative for

Germany (AfD) or the current National Rally: both Nicolas Sarkozy and Angela Merkel spoke of its failure during their presidencies, as have recent prominent Conservative Party politicians in the UK, like former Home Secretary Suella Braverman. Sarkozy actually promoted policies to ‘clean up’ the French suburbs; during his time as Minister of Immigration, Integration, National Identity and Cooperative Development the National Front made it to the second round of the 2002 elections. Neither are nativist approaches exclusive to parties such as Vox in Spain or the Lega Nord in Italy; some traditional parties in both countries clearly embrace them. They are not new, but the emergence of Vox has made them very visible. In Spain they are evident in the Popular Party (PP) and some regional right-wing formations. The creation of the first coalition government between the PP and Vox in Castile and León in April 2022 (twenty years after Le Pen made it to the second round in France) testifies to their influence. Pressure to reformulate gender policies began the day the regional government was formed, and the election of Gonzalo Santonja as Minister of Culture, Tourism and Sports showed that Vox’s think tank, the Disenso Foundation, had assumed a relevant role. A well-known defender of the Spanish language and bullfighting, Santonja assertively described the latter as ‘a mirror and symbol of the Spanish character’ while declaring the ‘posh-progressive’ government of Pedro Sánchez as ‘the dictatorship of environmental fundamentalists’.

The lines between the traditional right, heirs to formations born in the aftermath of the Second World War, and the radical right have become increasingly diffuse as the radical right has acquired ‘pathological normality’. Cas Mudde argues that it expresses the radicalization of conventional liberal values and is supported by the considerable portion of European and global electorates that is attuned to authoritarian, nativist and populist approaches. The radical right seeks to take ideas and values already present in our societies to an illiberal extreme. That is the root of the problem.

Are we facing a scenario similar to that of the 1930s in Europe? Is there a fascist danger? Throughout this book we have seen how far we are from repeating scenarios of nearly a century ago. During the interwar period, the financial, industrial and military elites supported fascism as a potential solution to the political crises that had begun after the First World War; they considered it the best option for confronting the dangers of Bolshevism.

Elites today back neo-liberalism with the support of the European Union, the U.S. establishment and supranational institutions worldwide. Though resulting from a crisis of hegemony, the radical right today does not represent a movement like fascism. Violence does not serve as their gravitational axis, nor do they feed on warmongering. Their conservatism, ethnicism and populism have little to do with the projects of Fascist Italy or Nazi Germany, which later expanded to much of Europe. There is no rigid social order, no militarization, no palingenesis, just a kind of stereotyped, non-mobilizing use of a kind of epic, mythical and – let's just say it – rather simplistic and sometimes ridiculous national memory: fascism as a moment of healthy nationalism, well-being or order. So far, however, current radical-right politicians have not called for war as a space for political construction, for the re-education of the masses, for a single national party, or for violence as a mechanism for ordering reality.

Furthermore, the contexts are very different. As historians, we believe that ideal-types and debates about the essences of fascism distance us from comprehending both the interwar phenomena and the present day. The best way to understand both periods is by studying the processes involved: not to identify essential expressions of these processes that might be repeated but to analyse their historical trajectories and interactions with all aspects of reality. The radical right shares symbolic and rhetorical elements with fascism: nostalgia for the dictatorial past, deep exclusionary nationalism, strong authoritarian and xenophobic tendencies. However, we think that radical-right formations today differ significantly – both in terms of context and the expectations they generate(d) – from Italian fascism and subsequent expressions.

Despite their differences, the dominant regimes of various countries in the last decade – the United States, Hungary, Brazil, Argentina, Poland, India – share several elements: party pluralism, relative freedom of the press and media, and more-or-less free elections. At the same time they ignore other characteristics of constitutional democracies such as freedom of expression, full separation of powers, and respect for and protection of minorities. The radical right does not formally reject democracy but criticizes it and accuses it of not being truly democratic. From outside power, or even from within (as with the Catalan independence movement or the Italian Five-Star Movement), they present liberal democracy as something disconnected from the will of the people, a subject as abstract as

it is nebulous. In this process, the construction of rights is replaced by identity mechanisms ranging from self-recognizing to customary rights. The people are elevated to subjects of law; political formulas and devices are invented that may not go beyond the legal channels of liberal democracy (parties, lists, associations, elections, parliaments, legislation) but try to subvert it from within (patriotic lists, self-styled associations created as vehicles of the popular will, votes that become referenda, representative chambers that legislate against the legal system). All of this gives metaphors priority in defining legal and political frameworks, creating a kind of low-flying ‘metaphor-politics’.

In the era of social networks, political debate is often hijacked by individual grandstanding and the saturation of favourable or unfavourable messages, often in a coordinated manner, by groups of ‘supporters’. Out of this network effect, we believe, rose the rapid, expansive identification of the radical right with fascism and the parallel correlation of progressivism with anti-fascism. This demonstrates the capacity of virtual communities to construct powerful political narratives – yet far from representing an egalitarian step, these networks of individual profiles are managed by extremely powerful companies and governments using non-transparent algorithms which may be said to drive opinion as much as they reflect it. This is dangerous, obscuring the historical differences between fascism and the far right. It matters that Trump’s supporters, for example, invoked the principle of democratic legitimacy when they accused their rivals of rigging the election, rather than claiming their leader’s natural right to rule the entire nation, which thus distinguishes Trumpist populism from fascism.

Direct critique of the separation of powers and fundamental institutions places the radical right on a path towards what the political scientist Fareed Zakaria described in the late 1990s as ‘illiberal democracy’, in reference to the Orbán regime. The Hungarian leader has held absolute majorities for more than ten years and introduced substantial reforms that have resulted in a new political system. As David Smith cited in *The Guardian* in 2025, Steve Bannon described Orbán as ‘Trump before Trump’. The evolution of Hungary, considered a model for Eastern European countries transitioning to democracy in the 1990s, sounds a warning for all European democracies. In 2020 Freedom House declared Hungary a ‘hybrid regime’. Over a decade ago, political scientist Jan-Werner Müller defined it as ‘authoritarian-nationalist-bourgeois’. The writer György Konrád referred to

it as ‘constitutional dictatorship’. They all signal Orbán’s regime as a potential horizon: not an inexorable path, not fascism, but a possible future scenario in Europe, Latin America and the United States.

This migration of the populist radical right from marginality towards normalization raises important questions for us as citizens. For how much longer will we be able to, or know how to, distinguish far-right formations from traditional-right parties? The lines are increasingly blurred in many countries. The Trump presidency projects this problem on a global scale. Should we regard the U.S. Republican Party as a traditional right-wing party that was stormed by an exceptional populist leader, or as a renovated party now integrated into the populist radical-right movement? The experience of Hungary should be analysed as serious warnings to the liberal democratic system. After more than ten years under Orbán, do clear differences exist between the original far-right Movement for a Better Hungary party (Jobbik) and Fidesz? In other words, for how much longer will we be able to talk about liberal democratic systems?

As we have seen, Spain ceased to be an exception some years ago. Vox embodies many current radical-right approaches and re-signifies them in the local context, especially by invoking the Spanish nation: a nation that excludes a considerable portion of its citizens and inhabitants. Some believe that this is not compatible with democracy. There are several reasons for this: Vox wants to outlaw regional–nationalist political parties to preserve the unity of Spain, curtail the rights of immigrant citizens and eliminate protection for sexual minorities. Each of these three elements constitutes a direct attack on principles of liberal democracy currently in force, which have been adapting to achieve great political consensus even though the original formulations and legal frameworks do not include references to sexual minorities or immigration. However, Vox has not explicitly rejected democracy but grown in its shadow as an expression of systemic crisis. Its idealized approaches to the past also attract openly anti-democratic voters whose political references are anchored in the period prior to 1975.

The danger for today’s democracies, despite the assault on the United States Capitol in January 2021, does not come from potential *coups d’état*. It lies in the development of ideologies and political projects that deteriorate democracies from within. The radical right does not threaten from the outside but from the very heart of the democratic system. On an increasingly subtle path towards anti-democratic forms, it is essential to

understand that, despite possible similarities between the interwar decades and the present day, we are not confronting fascism. Stigmatizing the radical right as fascist does little to aid our understanding of it. The underlying problem is not the emergence of the radical right. It is the crisis of liberal democracy and the lack of consolidated projects that give it muscle against corrosive processes that may empty it of content and turn it into something else, while we continue to point the finger at a fascism that existed only briefly, then was no more. Is no more. As historians, we find this unacceptable.

The future is unforeseeable, as is the evolution of the phenomena we have attempted to explain. Looking at them historically should help us approach them and strengthen democracy, or at least reflect on its virtues and limitations. It should also equip us to avoid the vaporous, postmodern evil of our time: trivialization through insult, mystification and decontextualization. It borders on anachronism, one hundred years after the March on Rome, to be identifying fascists or calling oneself anti-fascist. History is only a teacher for the future in its most simplistic conceptions. Phenomena as complex as those addressed here require more reflection than the 280 characters of a post on X can accommodate. To understand the crisis of democracy and foresee its evolution, let us stop analysing it with categories linked to the past and suspended in time and space, as if contexts did not matter or evolve. Instead, as has been our goal, let us read it historically using the tools available to us today.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

As authors, we have undertaken the challenge of writing a book that is more agile and free of undue academic baggage than our prior books. We started the writing process just after the Spanish regional campaigns of 2021, and we finished it shortly after the Andalusian elections of 2022, amid the hurricane of the Russian invasion of Ukraine (and the accompanying accusations of Putin as a fascist). We revised the manuscript for publication in English in late 2023, amid the Argentine election campaigns of Massa and Milei. We finished correcting the English translation right after the French elections of June 2024 and the failed turn to post-AN's LePenism, and just two weeks after the attempted assassination of Donald Trump in Butler, Pennsylvania. Just weeks before delivering the final manuscript, Milei presented Elon Musk with a chainsaw as a sign of Trump's announced cuts in the United States administration, a gift that the owner of X (formerly known as Twitter) gladly accepted, displaying it in spectacular fashion. We can surely say that we have been, and are, surrounded by the noise of an exhausting and all-too-often paralysing public debate.

To avoid the latter, we have chosen to stick to a very precise argument, one that will not end up as a simple, urgent analysis that clings to the contingency of the moment but lacks greater intellectual scope. We have attempted to construct a coherent book that would not be excessively academic. Nonetheless, historical explanations are complex and at times little suited to more direct analysis and circulation. If that is the case, we ask for understanding on the part of the reader.

In writing this book, Javier Rodrigo also made use of the resources provided through the ICREA-Acadèmia programme and the research project 'Perpetrators. Agencies, Actors and Beneficiaries of Francoist Violence, 1936–52 (PERPETRATE)' (PID2022-142394NB-I00), of the Ministry of Science and Universities. Resources for Maximiliano Fuentes were provided

through the research project ‘La democracia y sus enemigos: España, la primera posguerra, la dictadura de Primo de Rivera y sus articulaciones con Italia, Portugal y Argentina (1918–1931)’ (PID2020-112800GB-C22), also under the Ministry of Science and Universities. Both authors participate in the Generalitat de Catalunya’s Research Group GRECS, ‘Grup de Recerca en Guerra, Radicalisme Polític I Conflicte Social’ (2021-SGR-00045) and in the thematic network VOICES, ‘Violencia, Identidad y Conflicto en la España del Siglo XX’ (RED2022-134719-T). Thanks to all who read, debated and criticized the Spanish version of this book. Giaime Pala has been a huge help in finding errors, supplying knowledge and offering critique. The Spanish version of the manuscript, which was published under the title *Ellos los Fascistas* in 2022, and which was substantially revised and re-edited for English publication, was translated into English by Andrea Blanch and Daniel Blanch, PhD.

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